

HealWell

52 Weeks in Costly Hope

James Bell

LIVEWELL BY JAMES BELL

He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds.

— Psalm 147, verse 3

Introduction: A Devotional That Will Not Lie to You

I need to tell you what this book is before you trust it with your year.

Most devotionals are written from a safe distance. They are written by people standing on the dry bank, calling instructions to those of us in the water. They mean well. They are not lying on purpose. But they have forgotten what the water does to a person, how cold it is, how it pulls, how it gets into the lungs before you understand you are drowning. So they tell you to be still. They tell you that everything happens for a reason. They tell you that this present darkness is producing a glory you cannot see, and then they turn the page before you can ask the only question that matters, which is how you are supposed to keep breathing until the glory arrives.

I am not going to do that to you.

I came to faith as a grown man, out of atheism, with no childhood Sunday school to fall back on and no father who had shown me what a steady man looked like. I have buried people I loved. I have sat in the hospital room when the machine went quiet. I have prayed into a ceiling that gave me nothing back, for weeks, and I have wondered whether the silence meant there was no one there or whether it meant I was not worth answering. I am a pastor, which means people hand me their grief on a Tuesday and expect me to have somewhere to put it, and most days I do not. I am telling you this so you know that when I write about the dark, I am not describing a country I have only read about. I

live there too. I am writing to you from inside it.

This book is fifty-two weeks long because healing is not a weekend. It is not a conference. It is not a single good cry that resolves the thing forever. The Hebrew poets knew this. They wrote a whole book of laments and put it in the middle of the Bible, and God did not edit it out. He did not write in the margin, cheer up. He let the complaint stand. He let a man scream how long, O Lord, will you forget me forever, and He called it Scripture. That tells you something about what God can bear to hear. It tells you He would rather have your honest rage than your polite distance.

So here is what we will do. Some weeks we will simply name the wound. We will say grief out loud and not rush to fix it. We will say doubt and not be ashamed. We will say I am angry at God and discover that the saints have been saying it for three thousand years and the floor did not give way. The early weeks of this year lean into the lament, because you cannot heal a wound you will not look at, and most of us have spent our lives looking away.

Then through the long middle of the year we will sit in the endurance, which is the part nobody writes about because it does not sell. The waiting. The Saturday between the Friday and the Sunday, when the friend is in the tomb and no one yet knows about the morning. I want to keep you company there. That is the holiest work I know how to do.

And by the end of the year we will arrive at hope. But I am warning you now, it is not a cheap hope. It is not a bow on a box. The hope at the end of this book has nail holes in its hands. It is the hope of a God who did not stay safely in heaven explaining our suffering to us, but who came down into it, and was abandoned in it, and cried out from inside it, my God, my God,

why have you forsaken me. That is the only hope I have found that does not break under real weight. A God who suffered is the only God worth bringing your suffering to.

I should tell you what I am not, so you do not expect from this book what it cannot give. I am not a grief counselor, and this is not therapy, and if you are in the kind of darkness where you are thinking of ending your life, I want you to put this book down right now and call someone, a doctor, a hotline, a friend who will come, because there is no shame in needing help that a book cannot provide and there is every kind of courage in asking for it. I am a pastor, which is a different and more limited thing. What I can offer you is not a cure and not a technique and not a program that will fix you in fifty-two weeks. What I can offer you is companionship in the dark and the testimony of Scripture and the witness of a God who has been there. I cannot heal you. I have never healed anyone. But I can walk beside you and point, again and again, to the One who heals the brokenhearted, and I can promise you that the pointing is honest, that I am not aiming you at a mirage, that the God I am pointing to is real and has met me in my own dark more times than I can count. That is the whole of what this book is. A finger pointing, in the dark, at a light that does not lie.

You can read one week at a time. Read it Monday and carry it the rest of the week. Or read it the morning everything falls apart, whichever week matches the wound. There is no wrong order. The book is built like a year, but grief does not keep a calendar, and neither should you.

I will make you one promise. I will not lie to you. Not once in fifty-two weeks. I will not tell you it does not hurt, because it does. I will not tell you God will explain Himself, because mostly He does not. I will tell you the truth, and then I will point,

without flinching, to the only place I have ever found that held.

He heals the brokenhearted. That is the promise. But read it slowly. It does not say He spares them. It says He heals them, which means first they had to break.

So come in. Bring the wound. We will not waste your year pretending it is not there.

Week One: The Name of the Thing

Psalm 13

There is a particular cowardice in not naming what is wrong with us, and I have practiced it for most of my life.

We learn it young. We learn that when someone asks how we are, the answer is fine, and that the answer is fine even when the marriage is ending, even when the test came back, even when we cried in the car before we walked in. We become fluent in fine. And the trouble with this fluency is not only that it isolates us from each other, though it does. The trouble is that it isolates us from God, because you cannot bring to Him a wound you will not admit you have. You cannot ask Him to heal a thing you keep insisting is not there.

So I want to begin the year with the most honest prayer in the Bible, and I want you to notice that God let it stand.

How long, O Lord. Will you forget me forever. How long will you hide your face from me. The thirteenth psalm opens with four how-longs in two verses, and there is no apology in any of them. David is not being careful. He is not softening it for the congregation. He says God has forgotten him and hidden His face, which is to say David is accusing God of the very thing we are most afraid to accuse Him of, and the accusation became Scripture. The church has sung it for three thousand years. God put the complaint in the songbook.

God would rather have your honest accusation than your polite absence.

I think we have it backwards. We think reverence means we cannot say the hard thing. We think faith means we paper over the wound with a verse and a smile. But the psalmist had more reverence in his rage than we have in our pretending, because at least he was still talking to God. At least he had not walked away to complain about God to someone else. He brought the accusation to the only One who could answer it. That is not the opposite of faith. That is faith stripped down to its load-bearing beam.

Here is what naming the thing requires of you this week. It requires you to stop saying fine. Not to everyone, you do not owe the grocery clerk your grief. But to God, and maybe to one person who has earned it, you have to say the true word. Grief. Fear. I am so tired I do not want to wake up. He left. She is not getting better. I do not know if I believe any of this anymore. Whatever it is, it has a name, and the naming is the first act of healing, because a wound you will not name is a wound you have decided to carry alone forever.

Notice how the psalm ends, because this is the part that matters. It does not end with the problem solved. The enemy is still there. The face of God is still hidden as far as we can tell. Nothing in David's circumstances has changed by the last verse. And yet he writes, I will trust in your steadfast love, my heart shall rejoice. Not because the situation turned. Because he chose, inside the unchanged dark, to remember that the love had been steadfast before and might be steadfast still. That is not denial. He named the wound for four full verses first. He earned the right to that last line by refusing to skip the first four.

This is the whole year in miniature. We name the thing, all of it, without flinching. And then, having named it, we turn our face toward the only love that has ever held in the dark. Not because

the dark has lifted. Because the love is older than the dark.

I have sat across from people who could not say the word for years. They would talk around it, describe the symptoms of it, mention the doctor's appointments and the sleepless nights and the way the house felt different now, but they would not say the noun itself, the one true word for what had happened to them, because the moment you say it out loud it becomes real in a way it was not when it lived only in your chest. And I understand the fear, because saying it does make it real, the naming does land it in the room where you both have to look at it. But the thing that lives unnamed in your chest is not less real for being unspoken. It is only more alone. The wound does not shrink because you refuse its name. It grows, in the dark, fed by your silence, until it has taken up residence in places you did not give it permission to go. Naming it does not make it bigger. Naming it makes it bounded, gives it edges, turns it from a fog that fills everything into a thing with a shape, which is the first step toward a thing that can be healed.

I want to give you a small and concrete practice for this week, because naming is not only a thing you understand, it is a thing you do. Find a few minutes alone, somewhere you will not be interrupted, and say the true word out loud to God. Not in your head, where it stays safe and abstract, but out loud, in actual words your own ears can hear, because there is something about speaking a thing aloud that lands it in reality in a way that thinking it never does. Say what is wrong. Say the noun. Say I am grieving, or I am terrified, or I am so angry at you I can barely pray, or I do not know if I believe any of this. Say it plainly, without softening it for God's benefit, because He does not need the softening and you do not need the pretense. And then sit in the silence after you have said it, and notice that the

floor did not give way, that God did not recoil, that the relationship did not end because you finally told the truth. This is how the year begins, not with a feeling of healing, which may not come for a long time, but with the single brave act of naming, out loud, before God, the thing you have been carrying alone. The naming is the first step, and you can take it this week, in a few honest minutes, with the door closed and the true word finally spoken.

So begin here. Say the true word this week. Out loud, to God. He has heard worse, and He kept it, and He called it holy.

Week Two: When Fine Is a Lie

Genesis 32, verses 24 through 31

Jacob spent the night wrestling a stranger by a river, and he walked away from it limping for the rest of his life, and the Bible calls that night a blessing.

I want you to sit with how strange that is. We have been taught that an encounter with God should leave us better. Lighter. Restored to full strength, ready to march out and conquer. But Jacob met God at the Jabbok and left with his hip wrenched out of its socket, leaning on a stick, walking crooked into the rest of the story. The blessing and the wound came in the same grip. He could not have one without the other. And I have come to believe this is more honest about the spiritual life than anything we put on a coffee mug.

Last week we named the wound. This week I want to tell you that some wounds do not go away, and that this does not mean God has failed you.

I know that is hard to hear. We want healing to mean the limp is gone. We want the marriage restored, the body cured, the depression lifted, the child home. And sometimes, by grace, those things come. But sometimes the healing God gives is not the removal of the wound. It is the transformation of what the wound means. Jacob went into the river a deceiver, a man who had stolen and run and schemed his whole life, and he came out with a new name and a permanent limp, and the limp was the proof that he had finally met someone he could not outmaneuver. The limp was not the failure of the encounter. The limp was the

encounter.

Some wounds are not punishments to escape but proof you met something you could not control.

There is a thing we do when we are hurting where we bargain with God for the wrong outcome. We say, take this from me and then I will trust you. We make the removal of the pain the condition of our faith. And I understand it, I have prayed it, I have lain awake demanding it. But Jacob did not say let me go until you fix this. He said I will not let you go until you bless me, and the blessing he got was not a fix. It was a name, and a wound, and the rising of the sun over a man who would never walk the same again.

When the day broke, the text says, the sun rose upon him as he passed Peniel, limping because of his hip. I love that the sun rose anyway. The wound did not stop the morning. He walked into it crooked, but he walked into it, toward his brother, toward the reconciliation he had been terrified of, and the limp went with him every step. He did not wait to be healed before he kept living. He let the wound come along.

So this week, stop telling God you will trust Him after He removes the thing. You may walk with a limp the rest of your life. Most of the saints did. Paul had his thorn and asked three times for its removal and got an answer that was not yes but was somehow enough. My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness. Not around your weakness. In it. The limp is where the power shows.

You do not have to pretend the limp is not there. Jacob did not hide it. The whole nation of Israel took its name from a man who walked crooked toward grace. I think of the people in my own

life whose limps I have come to trust most. The widow who lost her husband forty years ago and still cannot say his name without her voice catching, who walks crooked under that loss every day, and who is, somehow, the steadiest and most tender soul in my congregation, the one I send the newly grieving to because she knows the country. The man who lost his business and his standing and never fully recovered either, who limps through a smaller life than he planned, and who has a depth in him now that the successful version of him never had. I do not believe their losses were good. I would undo them if I could. But I have watched the limp become the very thing that made them safe to others, the wound that marked them as people who had wrestled with something they could not control and had come away changed rather than destroyed. The straight-walking, the unwounded, the ones who have never been to the river and back, are often the ones with the least to offer the rest of us. It is the ones who limp who know the way through.

Your wound is not the disqualification you think it is. It may be, by morning, the very mark that you met God and lived.

Week Three: The Permission to Grieve

John 11, verses 32 through 36

Jesus knew He was about to raise Lazarus from the dead, and He wept anyway.

I cannot get past that. He was minutes from the miracle. He knew the tomb would open, knew the grave clothes would come off, knew Mary and Martha were about to get their brother back. If anyone ever had a reason to skip the grief and go straight to the resurrection, it was Him, standing there with the power to undo the whole thing in His chest. And He did not skip it. He saw Mary weeping, and the people weeping, and the text says He was deeply moved in spirit and greatly troubled, and then it gives us the shortest verse in the Bible. Jesus wept.

This is your permission, and I want you to take it seriously, because the church has spent a long time taking it away from you.

We are told, often by people who love us, that grief is a failure of faith. That if we really believed in heaven we would not cry so hard. That tears are a kind of doubt, a sign we have not surrendered, a hole in our trust that the dead are with the Lord. And it is all a lie, and Jesus is the proof it is a lie, because the Son of God stood at a grave He was about to empty and let the tears come down His face in front of everybody. He believed in the resurrection more than any human who has ever lived. He was the resurrection. And He wept.

Faith does not cancel grief. It cried at Lazarus tomb with full knowledge of the morning.

Grief is not the opposite of faith. Grief is love continuing to reach for someone love can no longer touch. It is the most honest thing a heart can do when it has lost what it was made to hold. And the God we worship did not stand above it, dry-eyed and serene, lecturing the mourners about eternal perspective. He came down into the middle of the weeping and added His own tears to it. See how he loved him, the crowd said. They read the tears correctly. The tears were the love.

So if you are grieving this week, whether it is fresh or whether it is the old grief that comes back without warning at a song or a smell or an empty chair at the table, I want you to stop apologizing for it. You are not weak. You are not faithless. You are doing the most Christlike thing available to you. You are loving someone you have lost, and the loving comes out as water, and the Lord of heaven did exactly the same thing at a graveside in Bethany two thousand years ago.

There is something else here you must not miss. Jesus wept even though He knew the ending. This means grief and hope are not enemies. You can know, with everything in you, that resurrection is coming, and still sob at the grave, because the grave is real and the loss is real and the wrongness of death is real, and Jesus refused to pretend otherwise even with the miracle loaded and ready. He held both. He grieved a death He was thirty seconds from reversing. If He can hold both, so can you.

Do not let anyone rush you out of the weeping. Not even out of love. Especially not out of theology. The shortest verse in the Bible is your defense. When they tell you to be strong, you can tell them that the strongest man who ever lived stood at a tomb

and wept, and the Father did not rebuke Him for it. He let the tears fall. He always has. There is a reason, I think, that the people who try hardest to talk us out of our grief are often the ones who are most afraid of their own. Grief is contagious in the sense that to truly sit with another person's grief, you have to let it touch the places in you that have not healed either, and that is more than most people can bear, so they reach for the bromide, the verse, the eternal perspective, anything to close the conversation before it reaches them. And I do not blame them, exactly, because grief is hard to be near. But I want you to know that Jesus did not do this. He did not reach for the comfortable thing to protect Himself from the contagion of Mary's tears. He let her grief touch Him. He was deeply moved, the text says, the Greek carrying the sense of being shaken in the gut, churned, undone. The Son of God let Himself be undone by a grieving woman at her brother's tomb, and out of that being-undone came not a lecture but tears. That is the kind of presence you can bring your grief to. Not the kind that flinches from it. The kind that lets it in.

He is not standing over your grief with His arms crossed. He is in it, weeping with you, even now, even here.

Week Four: Anger at God

Job 7, verses 11 through 21

I am going to say something that may frighten you, and I want you to stay with me through it. You are allowed to be angry at God.

Not because anger is good. Not because God deserves it. Because the alternative to bringing your anger to God is bringing it nowhere, which means swallowing it, which means letting it rot you from the inside while you smile through worship and die a little more each Sunday. I have watched people do this for years. They are furious with God for the cancer, the miscarriage, the affair, the bankruptcy, the silence, and they have decided that good Christians do not feel that way, so they bury it, and the burying does not kill the anger. It only kills the relationship. They go quiet with God. They stop praying the real prayers. And eventually they stop praying at all, not because they decided He was not there, but because they could no longer pretend in front of Him.

Job did not go quiet. Read what he says. I will not restrain my mouth. I will speak in the anguish of my spirit. I will complain in the bitterness of my soul. And then he turns and aims it straight up. What is man, that you make so much of him, that you set your heart on him, that you visit him every morning and test him every moment. He is accusing God of stalking him with suffering. He asks why God will not just look away from him for long enough to let him swallow his own spit. This is in the Bible. God put it there. And at the end of the book, when God finally

speaks, He says to Job's friends, the careful ones who defended God with all the right theology, you have not spoken of me what is right, as my servant Job has.

The man who shouted at God was commended. The men who defended God were rebuked.

Read that again, because it overturns everything we were taught. The friends said all the pious things. They protected God's reputation. They told Job he must have sinned, that God is just, that everything happens for a reason, that he should accept it quietly. And God was angry at them, not at Job. Job, who shook his fist at heaven and demanded an answer and refused to pretend he understood, Job is the one who spoke rightly. Because Job was honest, and the friends were only correct, and God can do more with honest than with correct.

I think God would rather you scream at Him than walk away from Him. The screaming is still a form of holding on. When you are furious with someone, you are still in relationship with them. It is when you go silent, when you stop expecting anything, when you decide they are not worth the argument anymore, that the relationship is actually over. God knows this. He would rather have your rage in His face than your back walking out the door.

So if you are angry this week, take it to Him. Not to the prayer journal you write to look spiritual. The real prayer. The one with the bitterness in it. Tell Him what you think He did. Tell Him what He failed to do. Demand the answer Job demanded. You will probably not get the answer, Job did not get an explanation either, God answered him with a whirlwind and a thousand questions of His own. But you will be where Job was at the end, which is on his face, not because he was beaten, but because he

had finally met the God he had been shouting at, and found that the God could take it.

There is a kind of anger at God that is really a compliment buried inside a complaint, though we rarely see it that way in the moment. You do not rage at a God you think is powerless. You do not demand answers from a God you believe is indifferent or absent or unreal. The very fury assumes that God could have done something, that He is real enough and strong enough and present enough to be held responsible, that He matters enough to be worth the argument. The atheist I used to be did not get angry at God, because there was no God to be angry at, only an indifferent universe that owed me nothing and to which my complaints meant precisely nothing. It was only when I came to believe that there was Someone there, Someone good, Someone who could have intervened, that the anger became possible, because anger requires a relationship, requires a someone, requires a love that has been, in your eyes, betrayed. Your anger at God is, underneath, a refusal to let Him off the hook of being real and good and present, and that refusal is closer to faith than the polite distance that has stopped expecting anything of Him at all.

The God who could take Job's fury can take yours. Stop protecting Him. He does not need your protection. He needs your honesty, and your anger, brought close, is more honest than your silence kept polite.

Week Five: The Silence

Psalm 22, verses 1 through 11

The worst thing is not the suffering. The worst thing is suffering while heaven says nothing.

I have sat with people in the rawest pain of their lives, and what undoes them is rarely the pain itself. It is the silence on top of the pain. They prayed and got nothing. They begged and the ceiling held. They did everything the church told them to do, the fasting and the believing and the standing on the promises, and God did not answer, and the not-answering became a second wound laid over the first. It is one thing to suffer. It is another thing to suffer and feel abandoned by the only One who could end it.

My God, my God, why have you forsaken me. Why are you so far from saving me, from the words of my groaning. I cry by day, but you do not answer, and by night, but I find no rest. This is the twenty-second psalm, and you know these words even if you do not know the psalm, because Jesus said them from the cross. The most God-forsaken sentence in human history was a quotation. The dying Christ reached for words to describe being abandoned by His Father, and the words He found were a psalm of complaint about God's silence. He prayed the silence into a scream and the scream into Scripture.

I want you to understand what this means, because it is the deepest comfort I know how to offer, and it is not a comfortable comfort. It means that God Himself has been on the other side of the silence. The Son cried out to the Father and, in that moment, for our sake, heard nothing back. The silence you are enduring is

a silence the second Person of the Trinity has personally endured. You are not praying to a God who has never felt unanswered. You are praying to a God who screamed into the dark and got no reply, and did it for you.

When heaven goes silent, you are standing exactly where the Son once stood.

This does not make the silence stop. I will not pretend it does. You may go through this entire week, this entire year, with the same closed sky over your head. The psalm does not record an answer coming. It moves from the complaint into trust without ever saying God spoke. That is the honest pattern, and it is the pattern of faith in the dark. You keep talking into the silence not because the silence breaks, but because the One you are talking to once stood in the same silence and came out the other side, three days later, alive.

Here is what the silence is not. It is not proof that God is gone. Jesus was never closer to accomplishing the salvation of the world than in the moment He felt most forsaken. The silence was not absence. It was the very center of the rescue. From the outside, on that Friday, it looked like God had abandoned His own Son to die. It looked like the prayer had failed. And it was, in fact, the hour the whole of history had been waiting for, the hinge of all our hope, the silence inside which everything was being saved.

I cannot tell you why God is quiet right now. I have stopped pretending I can read His timing. But I can tell you that the silence is not the same as the absence, and I can tell you that the Man who knew the difference best learned it by hanging in that silence Himself. Keep praying into it. You are in holy company. The last words of the psalm Jesus quoted are not about being

forsaken at all. They are, he has done it. I have learned to distrust the people who claim God speaks to them constantly, clearly, on demand, who seem never to have encountered the silence at all. Not because I doubt that God speaks, but because the Bible is so honest about how often He does not, about the long stretches when even the most faithful heard nothing. The boy Samuel grew up in a time when, the text says plainly, the word of the Lord was rare and there were not many visions. Abraham waited twenty-five years between the promise and the son, and Scripture records no conversations across most of that gap. Even Jesus, in Gethsemane, prayed three times for the cup to pass and received, as far as the record shows, no spoken answer, only an angel and the strength to go on. The silence is not the exception in the life of faith. It is, for most of us, most of the time, the norm, and the saints who have gone before us walked through far more of it than we are usually told. You are not failing at prayer because heaven is quiet. You are in the company of nearly everyone who has ever seriously prayed.

There is a strange comfort I have found in the timing of God's silences, though it took me years to see it. On that Friday, the silence over Golgotha was total. The Son cried out and heaven did not answer, the sky went dark, and to every witness it looked like the absolute abandonment of a good man by an absent God, the final proof that there was no rescue coming and never had been. And it was, in that very moment, the hour of the deepest divine action in the history of the universe, the moment God was accomplishing the salvation of the world, present and working with an intensity beyond anything that had come before, entirely hidden behind a silence that looked like absence. If you had measured God's presence that Friday by what you could feel or see, you would have concluded He was gone, and you would have been catastrophically wrong, because He was never more

present, never more at work, never more accomplishing His purposes than in the hour His own Son experienced as total abandonment. I cannot tell you what God is doing in your silence. But I can tell you that the cross forever broke the link between felt absence and real absence, that the two are not the same, and that the silence you are enduring may be, like that first silence, the very hour something is being accomplished that you will only understand on the far side.

The silence was never the end of the sentence.

Week Six: Tired in a Way Sleep Cannot Fix

1 Kings 19, verses 1 through 9

There is a kind of tired that sleep does not touch, and the Bible knows about it, and it sent an angel with bread.

Elijah had just won. On Mount Carmel he had faced down four hundred and fifty prophets of Baal and called down fire from heaven in front of the whole nation, the single greatest spiritual victory of his life. And the very next thing that happens is he runs for his life into the wilderness, sits down under a broom tree, and asks God to let him die. It is enough, he says. Take away my life, for I am no better than my fathers. The man who had just seen fire fall from the sky wanted to be dead. Victory did not protect him from the collapse. Sometimes it is the very thing that triggers it, when the adrenaline drains out and there is nothing left holding you up.

I want you to notice what God does not do, because it tells you everything about how He treats the exhausted.

He does not rebuke Elijah. He does not say, how dare you ask to die after I just sent fire from heaven for you. He does not deliver a lecture on gratitude or remind him of the victory or tell him to count his blessings. He lets him sleep. Then He sends an angel who touches him and says, simply, arise and eat. There is bread baked on hot stones and a jar of water. Elijah eats and lies back down. And the angel comes a second time and touches him again and says, arise and eat, for the journey is too great for you. Then

he walks in the strength of that food for forty days.

Sometimes the holiest thing you can do is sleep, and eat, and let God send the bread.

This is the most pastoral thing in the Old Testament and almost nobody preaches it. When God's servant was so depleted he wanted to die, God's first response was not spiritual. It was a nap and a meal. Twice. Before any word of correction, before any recommissioning, before the still small voice on the mountain that everyone remembers, there was sleep and bread and the gentle touch of an angel saying the journey is too great for you. God met the body first. He knew that you cannot reason with a man who has not slept, cannot preach to a man who has not eaten, cannot recommission a servant whose tank is dry. So He fed him. And then He let him rest. And only later, gently, did He ask what Elijah was doing there.

If you are this kind of tired, the kind that sleep does not fix, I want to free you from the lie that the answer is to try harder spiritually. Sometimes the answer is to stop. To eat something. To sleep. To accept the bread the angel brings and not feel guilty about how ordinary the bread is. We spiritualize our exhaustion and look for some deep sin or some failure of faith underneath it, when often the truth is simpler and kinder. The journey has been too great for you. You are a body, and the body has limits, and God built the limits, and He is not angry that you have hit them.

Elijah's recovery did not start with a revelation. It started with a meal. God did not despise the smallness of what His prophet needed. He sent exactly the bread the body required, and then He sent it again, because once was not enough, and God was not annoyed that once was not enough. We have built a Christianity, in many places, that is suspicious of rest, that treats exhaustion

as a badge of faithfulness and limits as a failure of commitment. We praise the pastor who never takes a day off, the mother who runs herself into the ground, the volunteer who says yes to everything, and we call it sacrifice when often it is just a slow form of self-destruction dressed up as devotion. But God built the Sabbath into the structure of the week before there was a single law about sacrifice or sin, built rest into creation itself, rested on the seventh day not because He was tired but to teach us that we are not machines and were never meant to run like them. The body that cannot go on is not rebuking your faith. It is telling you the truth about the creature you are, a creature with limits that God Himself designed and called good. To ignore those limits is not faithfulness. It is a quiet refusal to be the kind of being God made you to be, dependent, finite, in need of sleep and bread and rest, the way Elijah was, the way Jesus Himself was when He slept in the back of a boat through a storm because He was exhausted and the body needed sleep.

Let Him feed you this week. The journey is too great for you. He has known that longer than you have.

Week Seven: The Wound You Caused

Psalm 51, verses 1 through 12

Not every wound is done to us. Some we do ourselves, and to others, and the grief of that is its own country, and most devotionals will not take you there.

We are good at writing for the victim. We know how to comfort the one who was wronged, the one who lost, the one who suffered something undeserved. But what about the one who did the wronging. What about the man who blew up his marriage, the woman who said the thing she can never take back, the parent whose words are still echoing in a grown child who will not call. What about the guilt that is not false guilt, not the shame the enemy invents, but the true and accurate knowledge that you are the reason someone is hurting. The church often has nothing for that person except a quick word about forgiveness that skips over how much it costs to actually face what you did.

David faced it. The fifty-first psalm was written after the worst thing he ever did, the adultery and the murder he committed to cover the adultery, a man with absolute power destroying a family and arranging a death to hide it. And when the prophet finally cornered him with it, David did not minimize it. He did not blame his circumstances or his upbringing or the woman or the stress of the kingdom. He wrote, against you, you only, have I sinned and done what is evil in your sight. He owned it all the way down. No excuses. No softening. Just the naked admission of a man who knew exactly what he had done.

Real repentance does not explain the sin away. It stops, and looks at it, and tells the truth.

I have come to believe that this is one of the hardest forms of healing, because the wound and the guilt are the same thing. You cannot grieve what happened without grieving your own part in it. And the temptation is to run from that in one of two directions. Either you minimize, you tell yourself it was not that bad, everyone makes mistakes, you move on too fast and leave the real reckoning undone. Or you drown, you decide you are beyond grace, you let the guilt define you, you punish yourself forever because at least the punishing feels like justice. David does neither. He looks straight at the worst of himself, calls it by its true name, and then asks for the only thing that can actually help, which is a mercy he has not earned and cannot earn and knows he cannot earn.

Have mercy on me, O God, according to your steadfast love. According to your abundant mercy, blot out my transgressions. He does not appeal to his own goodness, he has none left to appeal to. He appeals entirely to God's character. And then he asks for something stranger than forgiveness. He asks to be remade. Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me. The word for create is the same word from Genesis, the word for making something out of nothing. David is asking God to do an act of creation inside the ruin of his own soul, because he knows the old heart cannot be patched. It has to be made new.

If you are carrying a wound you caused, hear this carefully, because it is the gospel and it is for you specifically. The blood of Christ is not only for the sins done against you. It is for the sins you did. The same cross that pays for your wounds pays for the wounds you inflicted, and the offer of a clean heart is not

extended only to the innocent, because none of us are innocent, and a gospel for the innocent only would be a gospel for no one.

You do not have to stay in the ruin. But you do have to walk through it honestly first, the way David did, naming it, owning it, refusing the easy exits of minimizing and despair. There is a clean heart on the other side. It is not cheap. I want to say a hard thing to the person who cannot forgive themselves, because I have met so many of them, sitting in the back pews, certain that the cross was for everyone but them. There is a strange pride hidden inside the refusal to accept forgiveness, though it does not feel like pride, it feels like humility, like taking sin seriously, like honoring the gravity of what you did. But to insist that your sin is too great to be forgiven is to insist that your sin is greater than the cross, that what you did outweighs what Christ did, that the blood which paid for David's adultery and murder, for the thief on the cross, for Paul who hunted Christians to their deaths, somehow runs out when it reaches you. That is not humility. That is a backwards arrogance, a refusal to let the cross be as large as it is, a determination to keep paying for a debt that has already been paid in full, as though your suffering could add something the blood of Christ left undone. Lay it down. Not because the sin was small, it was not, but because the payment was complete, and to keep paying is to call the finished work unfinished.

There is a peculiar mercy in the way David's psalm of repentance has been preserved and prayed for three thousand years, and it is this: the worst thing David ever did became the occasion for the most honest prayer about grace that the church possesses. We do not pray Psalm fifty-one because David was a good man who slipped. We pray it because David was a man who did something monstrous and found, on the far side of his own evil, that the

mercy of God was deeper than his sin. The psalm exists because the failure existed, and the church has been comforted by the psalm precisely because every honest person who prays it knows they are praying the words of a murderer and an adulterer who was, nonetheless, restored. This is the strange economy of grace, that it shines most clearly against the darkest backgrounds, that the people who have done the worst and been forgiven become, in their forgiveness, the clearest witnesses to a mercy the comfortable never have to test. If you have done a thing you cannot undo, you are not therefore disqualified from being a witness to grace. You may be, like David, precisely the kind of person whose restoration declares the depth of God's mercy more loudly than any unbroken life ever could.

It cost God His Son. But it is real, and it is offered, even to you, even for the thing you did.

Week Eight: Waiting Without Knowing

Habakkuk 1, verses 2 through 4 and chapter 2, verse 3

How long shall I cry for help, and you will not hear. This is a prophet talking, and God let him talk, and the talking is in the Bible.

There is a particular agony to waiting when you do not know how long the wait will be, or whether it will end at all. A short wait you can endure, because you can see the finish. A wait with a deadline, however far off, gives you something to count down toward. But the worst waiting is the open-ended kind, the kind with no horizon, where you do not know if you are waiting for something that is coming or grieving something that will never come. The healing that may or may not arrive. The reconciliation that may or may not happen. The prayer that may be answered next week or never. That is the waiting that wears a soul down to nothing, because you cannot even pace yourself. You do not know how far you have to walk.

Habakkuk was in that waiting. He looked at the violence and injustice around him and cried out to God and got nothing, and his complaint is one of the most modern-sounding passages in the Bible. How long shall I cry for help, and you will not hear. Why do you make me see iniquity, and why do you idly look at wrong. He is not asking a theoretical question. He is asking why God is doing nothing while everything falls apart, and he asks it directly, to God's face, and waits.

And here is what I want you to see. God answers him, but the answer is not what Habakkuk wanted. The answer is essentially, wait. The vision is for an appointed time. It hastens to the end, it will not lie. If it seems slow, wait for it, it will surely come, it will not delay. Notice the strange double thing God says. He admits it will seem slow. He does not pretend the wait is short. And in the same breath He insists it will not be late. From inside the wait it feels like delay. From God's side it is exactly on time. Both are true at once, and learning to hold both is most of what faith is.

The wait that feels endless to you is on schedule to God, and both of those things are true.

I am not going to tell you the wait is easy. It is not. The Bible does not say it is. Habakkuk does not end his book pretending the wait did not cost him anything. What he ends with instead is one of the most honest declarations of faith ever written. Though the fig tree should not blossom, nor fruit be on the vines, though the produce of the olive fail and the fields yield no food, though the flock be cut off from the fold and there be no herd in the stalls, yet I will rejoice in the Lord. He lists every single thing that has not come, every barren tree and empty field and lost flock, and then he says yet. Yet I will rejoice. The rejoicing is built on the far side of the honest accounting of all that is missing.

This is the only kind of waiting-faith I trust, the kind that names the empty fields out loud before it says yet. Not the faith that pretends the harvest is fine when the trees are bare. The faith that counts the bare trees, all of them, and then turns toward God anyway, not because the harvest came, but because the God is worth waiting for even if it does not.

You may be waiting for something this week that has no horizon. I cannot give you the date. Neither could Habakkuk. But you can do what he did. You can name every empty field, and then you can say yet, and the yet does not require the harvest to come first. The hardest part of open-ended waiting is what it does to your sense of time, the way it dissolves the normal markers by which we measure a life. A person waiting with a deadline can endure almost anything, because they can see the end and pace themselves toward it. But the open-ended wait has no pacing, no horizon, no way to know whether you are near the end or barely begun, and so it forces you to learn a different relationship with time altogether, one in which you stop trying to see the end and learn instead to live faithfully inside the not-knowing. This is, I think, one of the deepest works God does in the waiting, though we never would have chosen it. He weans us off our addiction to seeing the end, our insistence on knowing the timeline before we will trust Him, and He teaches us, slowly and against our will, to trust the One who holds the timeline rather than the timeline itself. Habakkuk did not get a date. He got a God worth waiting for without a date, which is a harder gift and a better one, because dates expire and God does not.

It only requires a God who is worth the wait, and there has only ever been one of those, and He is the one you are waiting for.

Week Nine: Doubt Is Not the Enemy

Mark 9, verses 21 through 24

I believe, help my unbelief. A father said it with a sick child in front of him and Jesus did not correct the contradiction. He healed the boy.

We have made doubt into a sin, and it has done enormous damage. We have taught people that to question is to fail, that a real Christian does not wonder whether any of it is true, that if you find yourself one morning unsure whether God is there at all you must hide it, confess it, defeat it, certainly never say it out loud in church. And so the doubting believer, who is often the most thoughtful and honest person in the room, learns to perform a certainty he does not have. He smiles through the service. He says amen at the right times. And inside he is drowning, alone, convinced that he is the only one in the building who is not sure, when in fact half the pews are full of people doing exactly the same performance.

The father in Mark's gospel did not perform. His son had been tormented for years, and he came to Jesus at the end of his rope and said, if you can do anything, have compassion on us and help us. If you can. The doubt is right there in the request. He is not even sure Jesus is able. And Jesus turns the phrase back on him, all things are possible for one who believes, and the father cries out the truest sentence a struggling soul has ever prayed. I believe, help my unbelief. Both at once. Faith and doubt in the same breath, the same heart, the same man. And Jesus did not say, come back when you have sorted that out. He healed the boy

on the spot.

Faith is not the absence of doubt. It is what you do with your hands while you are still unsure.

I came to faith out of atheism as a grown man, and I want to tell you something the certain people will not tell you. The doubt did not vanish at conversion. It is not as though I crossed a line and never looked back over my shoulder. There are mornings still, after years of pastoring, after preaching ten thousand words about the resurrection, when I wake and the whole structure feels thin, and I wonder if I have built my life and my family and my calling on a story. I am telling you this from the pulpit, more or less, because I think a pastor who pretends he has never doubted is lying to his people and the lie is wounding them. They need to know that the man up front, the one who seems sure, has cried out help my unbelief in the dark more times than he could count.

Here is what I have learned about doubt, and it changed everything for me. Doubt is not the opposite of faith. Unbelief that has hardened into refusal, that has stopped asking, that has walked out the door and slammed it, that may be the opposite of faith. But honest doubt, the doubt that is still asking, still wrestling, still bringing the question to God instead of away from Him, that doubt is a form of faith. Because you do not wrestle with someone who is not there. You do not cry help my unbelief into an empty universe. The very act of bringing the doubt to Jesus is the faith. The father proved he believed by the fact that he showed up with the boy at all.

So if you are doubting this week, stop trying to feel certain. Certainty is not the goal and it never was. Abraham was not certain, he laughed at God's promise. Sarah was not certain, she laughed too. Thomas was not certain, he wanted to put his

fingers in the holes. And Jesus did not banish any of them. He let Thomas touch the wounds. He gave the doubting exactly what they needed to keep walking, not certainty, but His own presence, His own scarred and living self, close enough to grab.

Bring your unbelief to Him. Out loud. He has never once turned away a person who came doubting and honest. He turned away the proud and the certain and the self-righteous. The doubters He healed. Say the father's prayer this week, both halves of it, and do not be ashamed of the second half. There is a particular gift that doubting believers bring to the church, and the church too rarely receives it, preferring the comfort of those who seem sure. The doubter has had to ask the hard questions, has had to look the difficulties full in the face rather than glancing away, has had to build whatever faith they have on something sturdier than inherited certainty, because inherited certainty is exactly what they lost. And so the faith that a doubter holds, when they hold any at all, tends to be a tested faith, a faith that knows its own reasons, a faith that has counted the cost of belief and chosen it anyway with eyes open. The untroubled believer often has not been tested and does not know whether their faith would survive the testing. The doubter knows, because they are being tested right now, every morning, and they are still here, still bringing the boy to Jesus, still crying help my unbelief, which means their faith has already survived more assaults than the comfortable believer's has ever faced. Do not despise your doubt as a weakness. It may be the forge in which the only faith strong enough to hold you is being made.

The second half is where most of us actually live.

Week Ten: The Body That Will Not Cooperate

2 Corinthians 12, verses 7 through 10

There is a particular loneliness to living in a body that has betrayed you, and Paul knew it, and God said no to his prayer about it three times.

We do not talk well about chronic pain in the church. We are good at the acute crisis, the surgery, the diagnosis, the moment everyone rallies with casseroles and prayer chains. But the long grind of a body that simply will not cooperate, the pain that does not resolve, the illness that has no cure and no end and no casserole because everyone got tired of asking years ago, this we do not know what to do with. The person living it learns to stop mentioning it. They learn that their suffering has become background noise to everyone else, even as it remains the loudest thing in their own life. They wake into it every single morning. They go to sleep in it every single night. And the church has largely moved on.

Paul had something in his body that he called a thorn in the flesh. We do not know exactly what it was, and I am glad we do not, because it lets every sufferer read their own affliction into it. A messenger of Satan, he calls it, sent to harass him. And he did the only sensible thing. He prayed for it to be taken away. Three times, he says, I pleaded with the Lord about this, that it should leave me. Three times. This is a man who had healed others, who had seen the dead raised, who had every reason to expect his own healing. And the answer he got was no.

Sometimes the most faithful prayer, prayed by the most faithful saint, gets a no.

I need you to sit with that, because the prosperity preachers will not let you. They will tell you that if you are still sick it is because you did not believe hard enough, did not pray right, had some hidden sin, lacked the faith to claim your healing. It is a cruelty dressed as encouragement, and it has tortured sick people for generations, layering guilt on top of pain. And it is a lie, and Paul is the proof it is a lie. The greatest missionary in church history prayed three times for his healing and God said no, and it was not because Paul lacked faith. It was because God had a different and harder gift in mind.

My grace is sufficient for you, the Lord told him, for my power is made perfect in weakness. Not removed in weakness. Made perfect in it. God did not take the thorn. He did something stranger and, I have come to believe, deeper. He met Paul inside the thorn and gave him a grace there that he could not have received any other way. The strength was not in the healing that did not come. The strength was in the presence that came instead, into the unhealed place, and stayed.

I will not pretend this is the answer you wanted. If you are living in a body that will not cooperate, you wanted the thorn gone, and so did Paul, and so do I when I pray for the people in my church who have suffered for decades. The no is real. I am not going to dress it up. But I have watched something in the people who learned what Paul learned, a depth, a tenderness, a nearness to God that the comfortable never seem to find. They would still trade it for healing. So would Paul. But they have discovered a grace in the unhealed place that is, against all expectation, sufficient. Not pleasant. Not what they asked for. Sufficient.

If your body has betrayed you, you are not being punished, and you are not short on faith. You may simply be one of the ones to whom God says, my grace is enough, and means it, and proves it, slowly, in the dark, where the comfortable cannot follow you. That is a hard gift. It is still a gift. There is a loneliness in chronic illness that healthy people simply cannot enter, and I want to name it for the sufferer who has stopped trying to explain it. It is the loneliness of a body that has become a full-time job no one else can see, the endless calculations about energy and pain that you make before every ordinary decision, the way you have learned to mask the suffering so as not to burden people, until the masking itself becomes exhausting and isolating. It is the loneliness of watching friends drift away because your limitations are inconvenient, of canceling plans so often that people stop inviting you, of becoming, in the eyes of a world built for the well, a complication. And it is the loneliness of a faith community that does not know what to do with a body that will not be healed, that has prayed and seen no result and has quietly, perhaps without meaning to, moved on. If that is your loneliness this week, I want you to know that God is not among those who have drifted away. He has not grown tired of your unhealed body. He stays in the room with the chronically ill long after everyone else has run out of casseroles and prayers and patience, and His grace, sufficient in the unhealed place, is the one thing in your life that does not have a limit.

I have stopped, over the years, asking God only to remove the thorns from the people I love, though I still ask that too, because it is right to ask. I have started also asking Him to meet them in the thorn, to make His grace sufficient in the unhealed place, to give them the deeper thing if He will not give the easier one. It is a harder prayer to pray, because it admits the possibility that the healing may not come, and we do not like to admit that, it feels

like a failure of faith to pray for anything less than total deliverance. But Paul's thorn taught me that there is a grace that only lives in the unhealed place, a nearness to God that the comfortable cannot reach, and that to pray only for removal is sometimes to pray past the very gift God is waiting to give. So I pray both now. Remove it, Lord, if You will. And if You will not, then meet them in it, and make Your grace enough, and let Your power be made perfect in the weakness You did not take away.

Paul came to boast in it. Most weeks I cannot get that far. But I believe him, because I have seen it on the faces of the ones who suffer well, and it is real.

Week Eleven: The Death of a Dream

Genesis 17, verses 15 through 17 and Romans 4, verses 18 through 21

Some griefs have no funeral. The dream dies, and there is no casket and no service and no one brings a meal, and you grieve it alone because the world does not recognize it as a death at all.

The marriage you thought you would have. The child you could not conceive. The career that never came together. The healing you stopped expecting. The version of your life you were so sure of at twenty that simply did not happen, and now you are forty or sixty and you are living a different life than the one you planned, and most days you have made peace with it, but some days the grief of the lost dream comes back as sharp as any death, and you cannot even explain it to anyone, because nothing actually died that they can see. Only the future you were counting on. Only that.

Abraham knew this grief. God promised him a son, and then made him wait twenty-five years, until Abraham was ninety-nine and Sarah was ninety, long past every biological possibility, long past the age where hope is even reasonable. And when God restated the promise that late, Abraham did something the Sunday school version leaves out. He fell on his face and laughed. The father of faith laughed at God's promise, because the dream had been dead so long that resurrecting it seemed absurd. Shall a child be born to a man who is a hundred years old. He had buried this dream a hundred times in his heart. He had stopped letting himself hope. And now God was asking him to hope again, and the asking felt almost cruel.

The hardest thing God ever asks is not to give up a dream. It is to hope for one you already buried.

Paul, looking back on Abraham, describes it with a phrase that has never left me. In hope he believed against hope. Against hope. Abraham hoped in the teeth of every reason not to. He considered his own body, as good as dead, and Sarah's womb, also dead, and he did not weaken in faith. Notice Paul does not say Abraham pretended the deadness was not there. He looked right at it. He considered it, fully, the hundred-year-old body and the ninety-year-old womb, all the dead facts. And he hoped against them anyway, not by denying the death, but by trusting that the God who promised was able to do what He said even over a grave.

I am not going to promise you that your dead dream will be resurrected. That is exactly the kind of lie this book refuses. Some dreams stay dead. Abraham got his son, but plenty of faithful people died still waiting, and the eleventh chapter of Hebrews says so plainly, these all died in faith, not having received the things promised. So I will not tell you the child is coming, or the marriage will heal, or the dream will yet be born. I do not know that. Neither do you.

What I will tell you is harder and truer. The God who raises the dead is the kind of God you are dealing with. That is His nature, the deepest fact about Him, that He brings life out of places where life is no longer possible. He did it for Abraham. He did it on Easter morning. And even when He does not raise the particular dream you buried, He has promised to raise something, somewhere, out of the death, because that is simply what He does, that is who He is, the God of resurrection, and resurrection is not the absence of death. It is what comes after a real one.

Grieve the dream. It was a real death and it deserves a real grief. But do not assume the grave is the end of the story just because it is the end of this chapter. You are dealing with the God who specializes in the impossible morning. He may not give you back the dream you buried. But The grief of a dead dream is complicated by the fact that you often cannot tell anyone about it, because it sounds like ingratitude. You have a decent life, people would say, a roof, a job, your health, why are you mourning a thing that never even happened, a child you never had, a marriage you never entered, a calling that never came. And so you carry the grief in secret, ashamed of it, telling yourself you have no right to mourn a future that was never guaranteed in the first place. But a dream is a real thing, and its death is a real loss, and the fact that the world does not recognize it does not make it less. You loved that future. You oriented your life toward it. You made decisions because of it, hoped for it, prayed for it, and its not-coming is a genuine bereavement, even if there is no body and no funeral and no one to bring a meal. Give yourself permission to grieve it properly, the way you would grieve any death, because it is one. The God who grieved at Lazarus tomb does not think your grief for a dead dream is foolish. He invented the heart that could love a future enough to mourn it.

Abraham laughed at the promise, and I have come to love that he laughed, because it tells me God can work with a faith that has been disappointed into bitterness, a faith that no longer dares to hope out loud. God did not rebuke the laugh. He kept the promise anyway, and in time He gave the son, and He even let the laughter live on in the boy's name, Isaac, which means laughter, so that every time Abraham called his son he would remember that he had laughed at the very thing God then did. Your buried hope, your laugh of unbelief, your refusal to be

disappointed one more time, is not too much for God to work with. He kept His word to a man who laughed in His face. He can keep working in a heart that has stopped daring to hope.

He has never once let a death be the final word, and He is not about to start with yours.

Week Twelve: Loneliness in a Crowd

Psalm 142

You can be surrounded by people and utterly alone, and David wrote a psalm about it from inside a cave, and the loneliness in it is the kind you feel in a full room.

There is the loneliness of being physically by yourself, and that is real, and it has its own ache. But there is a deeper loneliness that no amount of company cures, the loneliness of being unknown, of being among people who do not see you, who do not understand what you are carrying, who would not know what to do with the real you if you showed them. You can have a full calendar and a busy church and a house with people in it and still lie awake at night with the specific desolation of being unknown by all of them. I look to the right, David says, and there is none who takes notice of me. No refuge remains to me. No one cares for my soul. He wrote that, and he was a king with an army.

The fact that David was rarely physically alone makes this psalm sharper, not softer. He was a man constantly surrounded, leader of armies, magnet for followers, never short on company. And still he cried out that no one cared for his soul. Because the loneliness he names is not solved by population. It is the loneliness of carrying a weight that no one around you can carry with you, of being seen for your role and your usefulness and your strength while the actual you, the frightened and exhausted you, remains invisible. Pastors know this loneliness intimately. So do parents. So does anyone whom everyone leans on and no one carries.

The loneliest place is not an empty room. It is a full one where no one knows your soul.

And here is what David does with it, which is the only thing that has ever actually helped me with my own version of this. He does not fix it horizontally. He does not go looking for the one person who will finally understand, which is the trap we all fall into, the endless hunt for the human who will completely know us and never disappoint us, a human who does not exist, because no human can fully know another, and to demand it of them is to crush them. Instead David turns vertical. I cry to you, O Lord. I say, you are my refuge, my portion in the land of the living. He brings the loneliness to the one Being who can actually meet it all the way down.

This is not a consolation prize. I want to be careful here, because it would be easy to hear, since people fail you, settle for God, and that is not what I am saying and not what the psalm says. The truth is the reverse. The reason no human can fully meet your loneliness is that you were made for a knowing that is deeper than any human can give. The loneliness is not a malfunction. It is a homing signal. It is the part of you that was built for God refusing to be satisfied with anything less, and every time a crowd fails to fill it, the failure is pointing you toward the only One who can. You out of my soul, and find that you are already fully known.

You are known. Right now, in the cave, in the full room where no one sees you, you are completely and exhaustively known by the One who made you, down to the thoughts you have never said out loud, down to the grief you have never named to a single soul. He searches you and knows you, the psalmist says elsewhere, He knows your sitting down and your rising up, He discerns your thoughts from far away. You have never been

unknown, not for one second, not even in the cave. The loneliness is real. But it is not the truth about you. I have noticed that the loneliness of being unknown drives us toward two opposite and equally futile strategies, and most of us oscillate between them our whole lives. The first is performance, the attempt to be so impressive, so useful, so admired that the admiration will fill the hole, and it never does, because being admired for a role is the very opposite of being known as a self, and the more we are praised for the performance the more invisible the actual person behind it becomes. The second is withdrawal, the decision that since no one will truly know us we will stop trying, will build the walls higher, will settle into a self-protective isolation that at least cannot be disappointed. And both of these are attempts to solve horizontally a loneliness that is, at root, vertical, a homesickness for a knowing that no human relationship was ever designed to provide. The psalmist found a third way, which was neither to perform for the crowd nor to withdraw from it but to turn, in the middle of the unknowing, to the One who already knows. Not as a consolation prize. As the only actual answer to a loneliness that points, by its very depth, toward the only One deep enough to fill it.

It helps me, in the loneliness, to remember that Jesus Himself knew it. He was surrounded by crowds who wanted what He could give them, by disciples who followed Him for three years and still did not understand Him, by people who pressed in on every side and yet did not truly know the man at the center of it all. On the last night, in the garden, He asked three of His closest friends simply to stay awake with Him while He prayed, and they fell asleep, three times, leaving Him to face the worst hour of His life essentially alone. He knows the loneliness of being unknown in a crowd, of being surrounded and still solitary, of asking for company in the dark and receiving sleep. So when you

bring this particular loneliness to Him, you are not bringing it to a God who cannot imagine it. You are bringing it to One who felt it in its sharpest form, in a garden, abandoned by His friends, and who therefore meets your loneliness not from above it but from inside it.

The truth about you is that you are seen, all the way to the bottom, by the only eyes that could bear what they would find there.

Week Thirteen: When You Cannot Pray

Romans 8, verses 22 through 27

There are seasons when you cannot pray, when the words will not come, when you kneel and nothing rises, and I want to tell you that the Spirit prays in the place where your words have failed.

We assume prayer requires words, and good words, the right words, eloquent and faithful and full of trust. And so when we hit the season where we cannot find any words at all, when grief or exhaustion or depression has hollowed us out to the point that we open our mouths to God and nothing comes, we conclude that we have stopped praying, which we take to mean we have stopped being faithful, which becomes one more thing to feel guilty about on top of everything else. The very season when we most need to pray is often the season when we are least able to, and the inability feels like abandonment, like even this last line to God has gone dead.

Paul knew this place. He writes that the whole creation has been groaning, and that we ourselves groan inwardly, and then he says the thing that has carried me through more than one wordless winter. We do not know what to pray for as we ought. The apostle Paul, who wrote half the New Testament, admits that there are times we do not even know what to ask. And then, immediately, the rescue. But the Spirit helps us in our weakness. The Spirit himself intercedes for us with groanings too deep for words.

When you have no words left, the Spirit is praying the prayer you cannot, in groans deeper than language.

Read that slowly, because it changes what prayer even is. When you are kneeling in silence, unable to form a single sentence, emptied out, with nothing to offer God but the wordless ache in your chest, Paul says that ache is itself a prayer, and that the Spirit of God takes it up and translates it, carrying to the Father a meaning deeper than any words you could have found anyway. The groan you thought was the absence of prayer is the presence of the Spirit, praying through you, in a language beneath language. You were never not praying. You were praying the deepest prayer there is, the one too deep for words, and you did not even know it.

This means the quality of your prayer life in the dark season does not depend on your strength. It depends on the Spirit, who does not get tired, who does not run out of words, who is interceding for you right now, in this moment, with a precision you could never manage. He knows what you need that you cannot articulate. He carries the ache to the Father in terms the Father fully understands. Your part, in the wordless season, is not to perform a prayer. Your part is simply to stay in the room. To keep kneeling, or lying there, or breathing toward God, even with nothing to say. The staying is the faith. The Spirit handles the rest.

I have walked through seasons where the only prayer I could pray was to show up, sit in the chair where I usually pray, and offer God my silence and my exhaustion, because I had nothing else. And I want to tell you that those seasons were not the failures of my prayer life. They may have been the truest prayers I ever prayed, because there was no performance left in them, nothing but the raw need, handed over wordlessly to a God who

reads the heart and does not require the speech.

If you cannot pray this week, stop trying to find the words. Just go to God with the groan. Bring Him the ache exactly as it is, unshaped, unspoken, and trust that the Spirit is already turning it into the prayer you could not pray. I have come to think that our insistence on eloquent prayer, on the right words and the right posture and the right feelings, is a subtle form of pride, a desire to bring God something impressive, to earn the audience by the quality of our performance. And the wordless season strips that away entirely, leaves us with nothing to offer, no eloquence, no fervor, no impressive faith, only the raw groan of a depleted soul that cannot manage a single sentence. We experience this as failure. But I wonder if it is closer to the truth of what prayer always was, underneath the words we used to dress it up. Because God was never impressed by our eloquence in the first place. The Pharisee prayed beautifully and went home unjustified, and the tax collector could only beat his chest and say God, be merciful to me, a sinner, and went home right with God. The deepest prayers in Scripture are rarely the polished ones. They are the cries, the groans, the wordless reaching of people who had run out of everything except their need. When you cannot pray, you have not lost the ability to pray. You have lost the ability to perform prayer, which is a different and smaller thing, and what remains, the bare groan, is the very thing the Spirit most loves to carry.

You are not failing at prayer. You are praying in the deepest way a human can, which is to come with nothing, and let God supply even the words.

Week Fourteen: The Shame You Hide

Genesis 3, verses 8 through 13

The first thing sin did was make us hide, and we have been hiding ever since, sewing fig leaves, ducking behind trees, performing a wholeness we do not have.

Shame is different from guilt, and the difference matters. Guilt says I did a bad thing. Shame says I am a bad thing. Guilt can be addressed, you can confess the act, make it right, receive forgiveness. But shame is not about an act. It is about the self. It whispers that there is something rotten at your core, something that, if anyone ever saw it, would end every relationship you have, that you are fundamentally unlovable and only managing to be loved by keeping the truth hidden. And so the shamed person becomes an expert in concealment, performing the acceptable version of themselves while the real self cowers behind the tree, certain that exposure means death.

Watch what happens in the garden, because it is the first shame and it sets the pattern for all of ours. Adam and Eve eat, and immediately their eyes are opened, and the first thing they perceive is their own nakedness, and they sew fig leaves together to cover themselves. Then they hear God walking in the garden, and they hide. Adam, where are you, God calls, and Adam answers, I heard the sound of you in the garden, and I was afraid, because I was naked, and I hid myself. There it is, the whole anatomy of shame in one verse. Exposure. Fear. Hiding. The conviction that being seen is the worst thing that could happen.

Shame tells you that if God really saw you, He would leave. The cross says He saw you, and stayed, and died.

But here is what I want you to notice, because it is the gospel hiding in the oldest story. God comes looking. He does not wait for Adam to come out from behind the tree, cleaned up and presentable. He walks into the garden in the cool of the day and He calls, where are you, not because He does not know, but because He wants Adam to come out of hiding and be found. The God against whom they had sinned came searching for them in their shame, while they were still covered in fig leaves, still hiding, still convinced that being seen would destroy them. He came toward the shame, not away from it.

And there is one more detail, easy to miss, that has undone me more than once. After the judgment, before He sends them out of the garden, God does something with His own hands. The Lord God made for Adam and for his wife garments of skins and clothed them. Their fig leaves were not enough, the homemade covering of the ashamed never is, and so God Himself made them something better, which required, for the first time in the story, the death of an animal. The first death in the Bible was God covering human shame at the cost of blood. It is a shadow, thrown forward across the whole of Scripture, of a cross where God would cover our shame at the cost of His own Son.

This is what I most want you to hear if you are hiding this week behind whatever fig leaves you have sewn. The God you are hiding from already knows. There is no version of you so rotten at the core that it would surprise Him, because He has already seen all the way down, and He came looking anyway, and He covered the shame Himself, at His own cost, with His own hands. Shame's deepest lie is that exposure means abandonment, that if God really saw you He would turn away. The cross is the

permanent refutation of that lie. He saw you, all the way to the bottom, and He did not turn away. He stayed. He bled. He covered you.

Come out from behind the tree. Not because you have made yourself presentable, you cannot, the fig leaves never work. Come out because the One who is calling your name already knows what is behind the tree and is holding a covering He made Himself, paid for in blood, offered to you exactly as you are, ashamed and hiding and afraid. Where are you, He is still asking. The thing that makes shame so durable, so resistant to the ordinary reassurances, is that it is not really about anything you did, and so it cannot be fixed by addressing what you did. You can confess every sin, make every amend, do every right thing, and the shame remains, because shame was never about the sins, it was about the self, the deep conviction that underneath all the particular failures there is a fundamental wrongness in you that no confession can reach. This is why the gospel has to go deeper than forgiveness to actually touch shame. Forgiveness addresses the things you have done. But shame requires something more, requires being seen at the level of the self, the very level you are most terrified to be seen at, and being loved there, not in spite of what is found but with full knowledge of it. This is precisely what God offers and what nothing else can. He does not love you because He has not yet seen the bottom. He has seen the bottom, saw it before you were born, saw every thought and motive and hidden rot, and He set His love on you with that full knowledge, which is the only love that can ever actually reach shame, because it is the only love that cannot be undone by exposure, having already been given in full possession of everything the exposure would reveal.

He is not asking so He can condemn you. He is asking so He can

clothe you.

Week Fifteen: The Friend Who Failed You

Psalm 55, verses 12 through 14 and verses 20 through 22

It is not an enemy who taunts me, then I could bear it. It is you, a man my equal, my companion, my familiar friend. David wrote that about a betrayal, and the betrayal was by someone he had worshipped beside.

There is a wound that only the people closest to us can inflict, and it goes deeper than any injury from a stranger or an enemy. We expect the enemy to hurt us, we have defenses up, we are not surprised. But the friend, the spouse, the family member, the fellow believer we trusted, the one we let inside the walls, when that person turns and wounds us, the wound carries a particular poison, because it was made possible only by the trust we extended. We handed them the knife when we let them close. And the betrayal does not only injure us, it teaches us, falsely, that closeness itself is dangerous, that the safest thing is to never let anyone inside the walls again.

David knew this exact wound. The psalm is raw with it. We used to take sweet counsel together, within God's house we walked in the throng. They had prayed together. They had walked into worship side by side. And then the friend turned. My companion stretched out his hand against his friends, he violated his covenant, his speech was smooth as butter, but war was in his heart, his words were softer than oil, yet they were drawn swords. The smoothness is part of the cruelty, the way the betrayer kept up the appearance of friendship while the knife was

already out. David is not describing a clean break. He is describing the specific agony of being knifed by someone who was still smiling at him.

The enemy you can guard against. It is the friend inside the walls who can wound you to the bone.

I am not going to rush you to forgiveness this week, because the church often does that, and it does damage. It tells the betrayed person to forgive before they have even been allowed to grieve, treating forgiveness as a way to skip the pain rather than a thing that comes out the far side of fully feeling it. David does not skip the pain. He spends verse after verse naming exactly what was done to him, the covenant violated, the smooth words, the drawn swords behind the buttery speech. He lets himself feel the full weight of the betrayal before he does anything else with it. And so should you. The wound is real. Name it. Do not let anyone shame you into a premature peace that papers over a real injury.

But notice where David finally takes the wound, because this is the line that has held me. Cast your burden on the Lord, and he will sustain you. He will never permit the righteous to be moved. After all the naming, after the full accounting of the betrayal, David does not take the wound to revenge, and he does not take it to bitterness, and he does not take it to a wall built so high no one will ever get inside again. He takes it to God. He casts the burden, the unbearable weight of being betrayed by a friend, onto the only One strong enough to carry it without being poisoned by it.

Because here is the danger of the betrayal wound, the thing it does if you carry it alone. It hardens you. It turns you into someone who cannot trust, cannot open the walls, cannot risk closeness again, and in protecting yourself from the next betrayal

you wall yourself off from every future friend, and the betrayer wins twice, once in the wounding and once in the wall. The only way I have found to keep a betrayal from hardening me is to cast it on the Lord, to hand Him the burden of it, to let Him carry the weight so that I do not have to turn it into armor.

You may have been betrayed by a friend, and if so, you carry a wound that strangers cannot give. Grieve it fully. Name it honestly. And then, when you have, cast it on the One who was Himself betrayed by a friend, with a kiss, in a garden, and who carried that wound all the way to a cross without letting it harden Him into anything but love. The betrayal wound has a long aftershock, and I want to warn you about it, because it is where the real damage often happens, long after the initial blow. The aftershock is suspicion, the slow spreading of distrust from the one who betrayed you to everyone who reminds you of them, and then to everyone, until you find yourself scanning every new relationship for the signs of the coming betrayal, holding everyone at a distance, certain that closeness is just the setup for the next knife. The betrayer wounded you once. But the suspicion, if you let it spread, wounds you a thousand times, in every relationship you might have had and refused out of fear, in every friend you kept at arm's length because the last one got too close. This is how the betrayal wins twice. Not only in the original injury, but in the person it turns you into, walled off, guarded, alone, slowly starving for the very closeness you can no longer risk. The only defense against this slow second death is to cast the wound on the Lord rather than building it into armor, to let Him carry the betrayal so that it does not calcify into a permanent suspicion that poisons every future love.

He knows your wound from the inside. Give Him its weight.

Week Sixteen: Fear That Wakes You at Three A.M.

Psalm 56, verses 3 and 4 and verses 8 through 11

When I am afraid, I put my trust in you. Notice the order. The fear comes first. The trust comes after. David does not pretend he was never afraid.

There is a particular fear that does not visit during the day, when the light is good and the tasks distract. It comes at three in the morning, in the dark, when the defenses are down and the mind is unguarded, and it sits on your chest with everything you are most afraid of. The diagnosis. The money. The child. The future. The thing you cannot fix and cannot stop thinking about. You lie there in the dark while it runs its loops, and there is no one to talk to and nothing to do, and the fear feels enormous in a way it never does in daylight, because at three a.m. there is nothing between you and it.

The Bible does not shame this fear. I want you to hear that clearly, because much Christian teaching does. It quotes do not be afraid as though it were a command you could simply obey by deciding, as though fear were a sin to repent of rather than a human response to real danger. But David, the man after God's own heart, says plainly, when I am afraid. Not if. When. He assumes the fear. He does not pretend a faithful man is never afraid. He simply tells you what he does with the fear when it comes, and what he does is not stop being afraid by sheer will, but turn the afraid self toward God in the middle of the fear.

God is not waiting for you to stop being afraid. He meets you inside the fear, at three in the morning, in the dark.

And then David says something so tender it has made me weep at my own kitchen table in the early hours. You have kept count of my tossings, put my tears in your bottle. Are they not in your book. The Hebrew imagines God collecting every tear in a bottle, keeping a record of every sleepless turning in the bed. It means that the three a.m. fear, the tossing, the tears you cry alone in the dark that no one else will ever know about, are seen. They are counted. They are kept. God is not absent from your sleepless night. He is awake in it with you, collecting your tears, keeping count of every restless turn, present in the dark hour you thought you were enduring entirely alone.

This is the comfort the Bible actually offers the fearful, and it is not the comfort of denial. It does not say the thing you fear will not happen. Sometimes it does happen. David's enemies were real, the danger was real, and God did not promise him the danger would evaporate. What God promised, and what David clung to, was presence. In God, whose word I praise, in God I trust, I shall not be afraid. What can flesh do to me. Not because flesh can do nothing, flesh can do a great deal, flesh killed the prophets and crucified the Christ. But because the worst that flesh can do is not the final word over a person whose life is hidden in God.

So when the fear wakes you this week at three in the morning, do not lie there ashamed of being afraid. The shame only adds a second weight to the first. Instead, do what David did. Turn the afraid self toward God right there in the dark. Tell Him you are afraid, in the present tense, exactly as you are. And then remember that He is awake with you, counting your tears,

keeping the record of every turning, present in the very hour you thought you were most alone. The fear may not lift before morning. But you are not enduring it by yourself. You never were. There is a cruelty in the way we sometimes quote do not be afraid, as if it were a switch a faithful person could simply flip, and I want to take that cruelty apart, because it has wounded a great many genuinely faithful and genuinely frightened people. When the angel says do not be afraid, or when Jesus says it, the words are almost never a rebuke. They are nearly always a comfort, and the comfort comes attached to a reason, and the reason is presence. Do not be afraid, for I am with you. Do not be afraid, for I have redeemed you, I have called you by name, you are mine. The command not to fear is never a demand that you manufacture fearlessness by willpower. It is an invitation to look away from the thing you fear and toward the One who is with you in the facing of it, and the not-being-afraid, when it comes, comes not as an achievement of your courage but as a byproduct of His presence, the way a child's fear quiets not because the child decided to be brave but because the father came into the room. You cannot order yourself to stop being afraid. But you can turn toward the One whose presence, slowly, in the dark, has a way of loosening fear's grip on a heart, not by argument, but simply by being there.

The God who does not sleep is keeping watch over your sleepless night, with a bottle for your tears.

Week Seventeen: The Long Defeat

Numbers 14, verses 26 through 34

Sometimes the consequence of a failure lasts longer than you do, and a whole generation died in a wilderness because of one bad night, and God did not undo it.

We want our failures to be reversible. We want the story where the prodigal comes home and the feast is thrown and everything is restored as though the years in the far country never happened. And sometimes, by grace, that is the story. But sometimes it is not. Sometimes a failure sets a consequence in motion that simply has to run its course, that cannot be prayed away or repented out of existence, that you and others will live inside for years or decades or the rest of your life. The marriage that does not reconcile no matter how you change. The estrangement that outlasts your apology. The damage you did that keeps doing damage long after you stopped. The wilderness that you have to walk all the way across because there is no shortcut back to the garden.

Israel stood at the edge of the promised land, sent in spies, and lost their nerve. The spies came back saying the land was good but the people were giants, and the nation refused to go in. They wept all night. They talked of stoning Moses and going back to Egypt. And the consequence God pronounced was not a quick correction. It was forty years. An entire generation would wander and die in the wilderness, and only their children would enter the land. According to the number of the days in which you spied out the land, forty days, a year for each day, you shall bear

your iniquity forty years. The failure of one night became the shape of forty years.

Some consequences cannot be undone by repentance. They can only be walked through, with God in the wilderness.

I am not going to soften this, because the Bible does not. There are failures whose consequences outlast our remorse. You can be genuinely, fully, brokenly sorry, and the consequence still stands, because consequences are not the same as condemnation, and forgiveness is not the same as the erasure of results. God forgave that generation, in the sense that He did not destroy them on the spot and did not abandon them. But He did not reverse the consequence. They still wandered. They still died in the sand. The forgiveness and the long defeat existed at the same time, and learning to hold both is one of the hardest things in the spiritual life.

But here is what I cannot let you miss, because it is everything. God went with them into the wilderness. Read the rest of the story. The cloud by day and the fire by night did not abandon them at the border. The manna did not stop falling. The God who pronounced the forty years walked every one of them, all the way across the wilderness, with the very generation under judgment. Their clothes did not wear out. Their feet did not swell. He was present in the long defeat, sustaining them through the consequence He had Himself decreed, not removing the wilderness but refusing to leave them alone in it.

If you are walking through a consequence that will not lift, a long defeat that your repentance cannot reverse, I will not lie to you and say it will suddenly resolve. It may not. You may have to walk all the way across. But you will not walk it alone. The

God who did not remove Israel's wilderness did not abandon them in it either, and that is the pattern, that is what He does. He does not always undo the consequence. He goes with you through it, the cloud and the fire, the manna, the presence, all the way across the sand, until the far border, which does come, even if not for you, even if only for your children. I want to draw a line, carefully, between consequence and condemnation, because the failure to draw it has tormented many sincere believers. Condemnation is the verdict of guilt, the sentence of separation from God, and that, for the person in Christ, has been fully removed, paid, taken away, there is no condemnation left for you to fear. But consequence is different. Consequence is the natural outworking of an action in a world God built to run on cause and effect, and forgiveness does not always reverse it. The forgiven drunk driver is still forgiven and may still go to prison. The forgiven adulterer is still forgiven and may still lose the marriage. God lifts the condemnation freely and completely, but He often leaves the consequence in place, not as a punishment, the punishment was borne by Christ, but as the honest shape of a world where actions have weight. And here is the mercy hidden inside that hard truth: God does not abandon you to the consequence the way a judge abandons a prisoner to a cell. He walks the consequence with you, present in the wilderness He did not remove, sustaining you through the very results He did not reverse. The cell is real. But you are not alone in it. The One who forgave you is also the One walking beside you through what the forgiveness did not undo.

The wilderness has an edge. He will walk you to it.

Week Eighteen: When God Feels Absent

Psalm 88

There is one psalm in the whole book that ends in the dark, with no turn toward hope, no resolution, no light at the end, and God put it in the Bible on purpose, and I think it is the most honest thing in there.

Almost every lament psalm makes a turn. It complains, it accuses, it cries out, and then somewhere near the end it pivots, but I will trust, yet I will praise, the Lord has heard. We have come to expect the turn. We read the dark verses knowing the bright ones are coming, and the turn lets us breathe. But the eighty-eighth psalm does not turn. It begins in trouble and it ends in trouble. Its last word, in the Hebrew, is darkness. You have caused my companions to shun me, the psalmist says in the final verse, my one companion is darkness. And then it stops. No hope. No resolution. Just the dark, and the silence after it.

I cannot tell you how much it means to me that this psalm exists. Because there are seasons when you cannot make the turn. When the hope will not come on schedule, when the praise will not rise, when you have cried out and cried out and God still feels utterly absent, and every other psalm with its tidy pivot toward trust feels like one more thing you are failing at. And then you find the eighty-eighth, which does not turn, which sits in the dark with you and does not pretend, and you realize that God included a prayer with no happy ending precisely so that the person in the unending dark would have words too. He did not leave you out

of the songbook.

God put a psalm with no happy ending in the Bible so the one who cannot find hope would still have a prayer.

Look at what this psalm is, structurally, because it is important. It is a prayer. From the first verse, O Lord, God of my salvation, I cry out day and night before you, to the last, it is addressed to God. The man feels completely abandoned. He says God has put him in the depths of the pit, that God's wrath lies heavy on him, that God has caused his friends to flee. He blames God directly for the darkness. And yet he says all of it to God. The whole psalm of abandonment is spoken to the very One who feels absent. That is the paradox at the heart of faith in the dark. He keeps talking to the God he cannot feel. He addresses his complaint of God's absence to God's face.

This is the thing I most want you to take from the strangest psalm in the book. Faith is not the feeling of God's presence. If it were, this man had no faith, because he felt nothing but absence and ended in darkness. Faith is continuing to speak to God when you feel nothing, continuing to cry out day and night to a God who seems to have left, refusing to stop addressing Him even when every sense tells you no one is there. The psalmist's faith is not in his feelings. It is in the stubborn fact that he is still praying, still crying out, still saying O Lord, into a dark that gives nothing back.

If God feels absent this week, and no turn toward hope will come no matter how you try to manufacture it, I want to free you from the lie that you are failing at faith. The eighty-eighth psalm is your defense. You are permitted to end in the dark. You are permitted to cry out with no resolution, to feel abandoned, to find your one companion is darkness, and to still be, in that very

moment, a person of faith, because you are still speaking to God. The presence will return. It did for the man who wrote this, eventually, somewhere beyond the psalm. But even before it returns, you are not faithless for sitting in the dark. You are in the Bible. I think the existence of this psalm is one of the strongest arguments for the honesty of the Bible, and therefore for its truth, that I know. A religion designed by human beings to comfort and to sell would not include a prayer that ends in unrelieved darkness. It would not give the despairing a song with no resolution, would not preserve, for three thousand years, the words of a man who felt God had abandoned him and never recorded a rescue. Every instinct of religious marketing would edit this psalm out, soften its ending, append a hopeful verse, turn it toward the light. And it is still there, dark to the last word, because the God who inspired Scripture cared more about telling the truth than about keeping the brochure clean. He knew there would be people who reached the bottom and could not climb out on schedule, and He made sure they would find, when they opened the book, a prayer that met them exactly where they were, in the dark, with no false light, with nothing but the stubborn fact of a man still speaking to God from inside total abandonment. That is not the mark of a comfortable religion. It is the mark of a true one, willing to sit in the dark with its people rather than lie to them about how dark it is.

I have noticed that the seasons of God's felt absence are often, in retrospect, the seasons in which the deepest work of faith is done, precisely because they strip faith down to its essence. When God's presence is vivid and near, faith is easy, almost effortless, carried along on the felt assurance of His nearness, and we cannot quite tell whether we are trusting God or merely enjoying the feeling of His presence. It is only when the feeling is withdrawn, when the presence goes dark and we are left with

nothing but the bare choice to keep believing or to walk away, that we discover whether our faith was ever really faith at all, or only the enjoyment of a feeling. The dark night, as the old writers called it, is not the absence of God's work but its intensification, the burning away of everything in our faith that depended on feeling rather than on God Himself. The saints who went deepest into God almost all passed through long stretches of His felt absence, and they came out with a faith that no longer required the feeling, a faith that could hold God in the dark. If you are in that dark this week, you are not regressing. You may be in the very furnace where a faith that can survive anything is being forged, the faith that holds God by sheer trust when every feeling of Him has gone.

You are in the most honest prayer it contains.

Week Nineteen: The Comparison That Steals Your Joy

John 21, verses 18 through 22

Lord, what about this man. Peter asked it about John, and Jesus answered with a sentence that has set me free more than once. What is that to you. You follow me.

There is a thief that operates quietly, almost invisibly, and it does not announce itself as suffering, which is why we rarely bring it to God. It is comparison. We look at the lives around us, the marriage that seems easier than ours, the children who turned out the way ours did not, the career that came together, the faith that seems untroubled, the suffering that someone else was spared, and something curdles in us. We do not call it a wound, but it is one. It is the slow poisoning of every good thing we have by the constant measuring of it against what someone else has, and it can hollow out a life from the inside while we keep up the appearance of being fine.

Peter had just been restored. He had denied Jesus three times, and Jesus had walked him through three tender questions on the beach, do you love me, undoing the three denials one by one, recommissioning him, feed my sheep. And then Jesus told Peter something hard, that he would die a martyr's death, that he would be led where he did not want to go and stretch out his hands and be carried off to be killed. A heavy word, but an honest one. And what does Peter do with this sober prophecy about his own death. He turns around, sees John, and asks, Lord, what about this man. What is going to happen to him. In the very moment of

being told how he will suffer, Peter is already comparing, already measuring his lot against his brother's.

The fastest way to ruin the life you have is to spend it measuring against the life you do not.

Jesus answer is not gentle, and I am glad it is not, because I have needed the bluntness. If it is my will that he remain until I come, what is that to you. You follow me. In other words, John's story is not your business. What I am doing in his life, the suffering I give him or spare him, the years I grant him or do not, that is between him and me, and it has nothing to do with your obedience. Your job is not to manage the comparison. Your job is to follow me, on the road I have for you, which is the only road you have been given and the only one you are responsible to walk.

I have found this to be one of the most liberating sentences in the gospels, because comparison is endless and it cannot be won. There is always someone whose suffering is lighter, whose blessings are heavier, whose path looks easier from the outside, and as long as you are looking sideways at them, you cannot walk your own road, you are too busy measuring. And the comparison is almost always based on incomplete information anyway. You do not actually know what John was carrying. You see the outside of other people's lives and the inside of your own, and you compare the two, and it is a rigged measurement that will rob you every time.

What is that to you. You follow me. The cure for comparison is not to win it, you cannot. The cure is to stop looking sideways and start looking forward, at the One who is calling you down your particular road, the road no one else is walking, the road that was measured out for you alone and that has its own crosses

and its own graces that you cannot trade for anyone else's. When the comparison rises this week, and it will, hear the Lord turn you back to the only direction that matters. Comparison has gotten immeasurably worse in our time, and I would be failing you not to name it, because the device in your pocket is a comparison machine of unprecedented power. It shows you, all day long, the curated highlights of ten thousand other lives, the vacations and the weddings and the achievements and the apparently effortless happiness, and it shows them to you precisely when you are most tired, most discouraged, most prone to measure your unedited interior against everyone else's edited exterior. It is a rigged comparison delivered continuously to your hand, and it is making a generation miserable, teaching people to despise their own real lives by holding them against the false highlight reels of strangers. Peter at least had only one John to compare himself to, standing right there on the beach. You have an infinite scroll of Johns, each one apparently more blessed than you, none of them showing you their three a.m. fears or their secret griefs or the parts of their lives that look exactly as broken as yours. When the Lord says what is that to you, follow me, He is offering you a freedom the scroll will never offer, the freedom to lift your eyes off the endless sideways comparison and fix them on the one road that is actually yours.

Not at your neighbor's life. At the back of the One who is walking ahead of you, saying the only word that frees you. Follow me.

Week Twenty: The Child Who Walked Away

Luke 15, verses 11 through 24

A father stood at the edge of his property scanning the road, day after day, for a son who had taken his money and his blessing and disappeared, and the Bible says that father is God, and that he is still watching the road.

There is a grief specific to parents, though it visits others too, the grief of loving someone who has walked away and will not come back. The child who left the faith. The child who left the family. The one you raised and prayed over and poured your life into, who is now living in a far country, by their own choice, beyond your reach, and you cannot make them come home, and the helplessness of that is a particular torment. You would walk through fire for them. You would give anything to fix it. And you can do nothing but wait, and pray, and watch a road that stays empty.

The parable of the prodigal son is usually preached to the son, a call to the wayward to come home. But this week I want to preach it to the father, because I think the father is the one who is suffering through the whole middle of the story, and the Bible tells us the father is God. Watch him. The younger son demands his inheritance early, which in that culture was effectively saying I wish you were dead, give me my share now. And the father gives it. He does not chain the boy to the house. He lets him go, lets him take the blessing and squander it, lets him walk down the road into ruin, because love that cannot be refused is not

love, and a son who cannot leave is a prisoner, not a child.

Love that cannot be refused is not love. The father let him go, and then watched the road every day.

And then comes the line that I cannot read without my throat tightening. While he was still a long way off, his father saw him and felt compassion. While he was still a long way off, his father saw him. Do you understand what that means. It means the father was watching. Every day, for who knows how long, the father had been scanning that horizon, looking down the road his son had vanished on, so that on the day a distant figure finally appeared, ragged and broken and rehearsing an apology, the father recognized him while he was still too far away to call out. The father saw him first. The watching had never stopped.

I want the parents reading this, and anyone grieving a person who walked away, to sit in that image, because it is the only comfort I have found that does not lie. You cannot make them come home. The father in the parable could not either. He had to let the boy go and then endure the not-knowing, the empty road, the silence, the years. But he did not stop watching, and when the boy turned, the father was ready, was already running before the apology was finished, was throwing his arms around a son who still smelled of the pigsty. The father's love did not wait for the boy to clean himself up. It ran toward him in the dirt.

I cannot promise you that the one you love will come home. The parable does not promise it about every prodigal, only this one. Free people make free choices and some of them stay in the far country until the end. But I can promise you this, and the parable is the proof. The God who is the Father in this story is still watching the road. He has not given up on the ones who walked away, and He is more invested in their return than even you are,

because He is the better Father, the one whose love is purer than yours, and He is scanning the horizon with a compassion that will run the whole length of the road the moment a distant figure appears. There is a temptation, when someone you love is in the far country, to go after them in ways that do not help, and I have watched it wound parents and children alike. We try to control them home, to manipulate or guilt or coerce them back, to make the far country so uncomfortable through our pressure that they will return just to escape us. But the father in the parable does not do this. He does not send servants to drag the boy back, does not cut off all support to force the issue, does not lecture or pursue or pressure. He lets the boy go, and then he waits, and the waiting is agony, but it is the only thing that leaves room for a real return, a return of the heart and not just the body. Because a child who is coerced home is not home, they are imprisoned, and the moment the pressure lifts they will run again. The father wanted his son, not his son's compliance, and so he endured the unbearable thing, the open road and the empty horizon, rather than reach for the control that would have brought back a body without a heart. If you are watching for someone in the far country, this is the hardest discipline, to love them enough to let them stay gone, to keep the door open without dragging them through it, to wait, as the father waited, for the day they turn on their own.

Keep watching with Him. You are not watching alone.

Week Twenty-One: The Weight You Were Never Meant to Carry

Matthew 11, verses 28 through 30

Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke. Notice He does not offer you no yoke. He offers you a different one.

We are carrying things we were never meant to carry, and we have carried them so long we have stopped noticing the weight, the way you stop noticing a backpack you have worn all day until you finally set it down and feel your shoulders rise. We carry the burden of being enough, of holding everything together, of being the strong one, the one who never needs help, the one whose job it is to manage everyone else's needs and never voice our own. We carry guilt that was already paid for. We carry futures that have not happened yet. We carry the weight of outcomes that are not ours to control. And the carrying is exhausting us, and we think it is just what life is, this constant straining under a load we never agreed to pick up.

Jesus offers rest to exactly this person. Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden. The Greek word for heavy laden is the picture of someone loaded down, weighed under a burden too great for them, and Jesus calls precisely that person to come, and He promises rest. But then He says something that confuses people, and the confusion is the whole point. Take my yoke upon you and learn from me. He offers rest, and in the same breath He offers a yoke, which is the very symbol of labor, the wooden beam laid across an animal's shoulders to make it pull. How is a

yoke rest. Why does the answer to being burdened involve taking on another burden.

Jesus does not offer you a life with no yoke. He offers to take the one that is crushing you and give you His.

Because the rest Jesus offers is not the absence of all burden. That is not available in this life, and anyone who promises it is selling you something. The rest He offers is the exchange of an unbearable yoke for a bearable one. We are crushed not because we carry something, we were made to carry something, but because we are carrying the wrong things, burdens that were never assigned to us, weights that belong to God and that we have foolishly taken onto our own shoulders. The need to control what we cannot control. The responsibility for outcomes that are His, not ours. The guilt He already carried to the cross. We are heavy laden because we picked up His load and tried to carry it ourselves, and it is crushing us because it was never ours to carry.

For my yoke is easy, He says, and my burden is light. Not because it is nothing, a yoke is still a yoke, following Jesus still costs you everything. But His yoke fits. It is fitted to you, custom-made, the right size, and it is shared, because a yoke is built for two, and He is in it with you, pulling alongside, taking the greater share of the weight onto His own shoulders. The exhaustion of trying to carry your life alone is replaced by the strange rest of pulling in tandem with the One who is strong enough for both of you and who refuses to let you pull alone.

So this week, I want you to do an inventory of what you are carrying, and ask of each weight, honestly, whether it was ever yours to carry. The outcome of your child's choices. The future you cannot see. The guilt that is already paid. The need to be enough, to hold it all together, to never need help. Lay down the

ones that were never yours. Hand them back to God, who can carry them without strain. And take instead the yoke that fits, the one He is already wearing beside you. The heaviest weight most of us carry, and the one we are least likely to recognize as not ours, is the weight of outcomes. We have been taught, often by a distorted version of faith, that if we just do enough, pray enough, try enough, believe enough, we can control how things turn out, and so we shoulder the full burden of every outcome as though it rested on us, the health of our children, the success of our work, the salvation of the people we love, the future none of us can see. And it crushes us, because outcomes were never ours to carry. We are responsible for faithfulness, not for results. We can plant and water, Paul says, but God gives the growth, and the growth is His department, not ours, and the exhaustion of trying to manufacture growth we were never assigned to produce is one of the great unnecessary burdens of the religious life. Jesus did not carry the weight of outcomes either, in His humanity. He healed who came to Him and let the rest go, He preached and watched many walk away, He entrusted the results to His Father and slept in the boat. The rest He offers begins precisely here, with handing back to God the outcomes you have been trying to control, and discovering that your job was always smaller than you thought, just the next faithful step, with the results left in hands stronger than yours.

The rest He offers is real. But it begins with setting down the load you were never meant to lift.

Week Twenty-Two: Grief That Comes in Waves

Lamentations 3, verses 19 through 26

Grief does not move in a straight line, and the Bible has a whole book named for it, and even that book moves in waves, sinking and rising and sinking again.

We are told grief has stages, and we picture them as a staircase, denial then anger then bargaining then depression then acceptance, as though you climb them one by one and arrive at the top, finished, healed, done. And then the actual experience of grief makes a liar of the staircase, because grief does not climb, it crashes. It comes in waves. You can have a good week, even a good month, you can think the worst is behind you, and then a song plays, or you reach for the phone to call them before you remember, or the anniversary arrives, and the wave takes you back under as though no time has passed at all. And on top of the grief comes a second misery, the sense that you are doing it wrong, that you should be further along, that the wave means you are regressing.

The book of Lamentations does not climb a staircase. It moves in waves, and the most famous passage in it sits right in the middle of the wreckage. Remember my affliction and my wanderings, the writer says, the wormwood and the gall. My soul continually remembers it and is bowed down within me. He is at the bottom of a wave, sunk under the memory of everything lost, the city destroyed, the people scattered, the suffering total. And then, from the very bottom, without anything in his circumstances

changing, he says, but this I call to mind, and therefore I have hope.

The mercies are new every morning not because the grief is gone, but because you will need new mercy tomorrow.

What he calls to mind is one of the most beloved lines in all of Scripture, and I want you to notice that it rises out of the bottom of a wave, not the top of a staircase. The steadfast love of the Lord never ceases, his mercies never come to an end, they are new every morning, great is your faithfulness. New every morning. Think about why it has to be new every morning. Because the grief will be back in the morning too. He is not saying the mercy fixed everything and now the grief is over. He is saying the mercy arrives fresh each day precisely because each day brings its own need for it, its own wave, its own version of the weight. The mercy is new every morning because the grief is also new every morning, and God matches the one to the other.

This is the rhythm of grieving honestly, and it is not a staircase, it is a tide. Some mornings you will wake with hope, and the steadfast love will feel near, and you will think you have turned a corner. Other mornings the wave will take you back under, and you will need the mercy to be new all over again, and it will be, because that is the promise, new every morning, every single one, including the mornings you sink. The faithfulness is not measured by your steadiness. It is measured by His, and His does not waver when yours does. The mercies come fresh on the days you are at the bottom exactly as surely as on the days you are at the top.

So if grief is coming in waves for you this week, and you are berating yourself for not being further along, stop. There is no

further along. There is no staircase. There is a tide, and you ride it, sinking and rising and sinking again, and on every single morning, the bottom ones included, the mercy is new and the faithfulness is great. You are not doing it wrong. There is a particular wave that ambushes the griever, and I have learned to warn people about it so it does not knock them flat with surprise. It is the wave that comes not in the obvious moments but in the ordinary ones, not at the funeral or the anniversary, where you are braced for it, but in the grocery store when you reach for their favorite food out of habit, in the car when their song comes on the radio, in the morning when you wake for half a second having forgotten, before the remembering crashes back in. These ambush waves are the cruelest because you are never ready for them, and they make you feel as though you have lost all the ground you gained, as though months of slow healing have been erased in an instant. But they have not been erased. The ground you gained is still there. The ambush wave is not a regression, it is simply the nature of grief, which is bound to the love that produced it, and which will reach for the lost one as long as the love lasts, which is forever. You do not stop loving them, and so you do not stop grieving them, not entirely, not ever, you only learn to carry the grief in a way that lets you also live. The waves come further apart over time. But they come, and when they do, the mercy is new that morning too.

Week Twenty-Three: The Prayer That Was Not Answered

2 Samuel 12, verses 15 through 23

David fasted and wept on the ground for seven nights for a dying child, and the child died anyway, and what David did next is one of the strangest and most honest things in the Bible.

We do not know how to talk about the prayer that gets a no. We know how to celebrate the answered prayer, the healing that came, the job that opened up, the relationship restored, and we tell those stories in church and call them testimonies. But the prayer that was not answered, the child who died despite the fasting, the marriage that ended despite the years of intercession, the healing that never came no matter how the whole congregation prayed, those stories we do not tell, because we do not know what they mean, and we are afraid that telling them will damage someone's faith. So the person whose prayer got a no suffers twice, once in the loss and once in the silence around it, the sense that their unanswered prayer is somehow shameful, a failure to be hidden.

David's prayer got a no. His infant son was dying, and David pleaded with God, fasted, lay all night on the ground, refused to eat, refused to get up, for seven days. His servants were afraid to tell him when the child finally died, certain he would harm himself in his grief. And then David does the thing that has puzzled readers for three thousand years. When he learns the child is dead, he gets up off the ground, washes, changes his clothes, goes into the house of the Lord and worships, and then

asks for a meal. His servants are bewildered. Why are you acting this way, they ask, you fasted and wept while the child lived, and now that he is dead, you rise and eat.

*While there was hope, David prayed with everything.
When the answer was no, he got up and kept living.*

David's answer is one of the most clear-eyed things any griever has ever said. While the child was still alive, I fasted and wept, for I said, who knows whether the Lord will be gracious to me, that the child may live. But now he is dead. Why should I fast. Can I bring him back again. I shall go to him, but he will not return to me. Read what David is doing here, because it is not resignation and it is not denial. He prayed with everything he had while there was any hope at all, he held nothing back, he lay on the ground for a week. And when the answer came, and it was no, he did not pretend the no was a yes, and he did not collapse into a faith-destroying bitterness either. He acknowledged the no as real, grieved its reality, and then got up and kept living, carrying one quiet sentence forward like a coal in his hand. I shall go to him.

That last line is the hope, and it is a hard-won hope, the only kind this book trusts. I shall go to him, but he will not return to me. David does not get his son back in this life, the prayer for that was answered no, and David does not pretend otherwise. But he knows the separation is not final. He will go to the child. The no he received was a no about now, about this life, about the child returning to him here. It was not a no about forever. The reunion is real, even though the prayer for healing was denied, and David holds both at once, the genuine no and the deeper yes, without letting either one erase the other.

If your prayer got a no this week, or a year ago, or one you are

still carrying, I want to give you David's example, because it refuses both lies. It refuses the lie that you should not have prayed so hard, you should have, pray with everything while there is hope. And it refuses the lie that the no means God failed or was never there. David worshipped after the no. He grieved it honestly and worshipped anyway, and carried forward the one hope that the no could not touch, the hope of going to the one he lost. Some prayers get a no. David's did. I want to address the guilt that so often follows the unanswered prayer, because it is its own quiet torment. When the healing does not come, when the child dies, when the marriage ends despite everything, the bereaved often turns the failure inward and asks what they did wrong. Did I not pray enough. Did I not have enough faith. Was there some sin, some lack, some failure in me that caused God to withhold the yes. And this guilt is a special cruelty, because it takes a person already crushed by loss and adds to their grief the unbearable suggestion that the loss was their fault, that more faith or better prayers could have changed the outcome. It is a lie, and David's story refutes it. David prayed with everything he had, fasted for seven days, lay on the ground all night, and the child died anyway, and David did not conclude that he had failed. He understood that the outcome was in God's hands, not his, that his job had been to pray faithfully and God's job had been to decide, and that the no was God's sovereign answer and not David's spiritual failure. Your unanswered prayer is not the measure of your faith. The saints prayed and got many no answers, and they were not faithless, they were faithful people living in a world where God says no for reasons we cannot see. Lay down the guilt. You did not fail. You prayed, and God answered, and the answer was hard, and none of that was your fault.

And he got up, and washed his face, and worshipped, and kept

the deeper promise burning in his hand. I shall go to him. So will you.

Week Twenty-Four: The Saturday Between

Matthew 27, verses 57 through 66

There is a day in the Christian story that nobody celebrates, the day between the cross and the empty tomb, the Saturday, and I have come to believe most of us live there.

We know about Friday, the day of the cross, the day of suffering, and we know about Sunday, the day of resurrection, the day of triumph. We preach them both. But between them sits Saturday, the day the body lay in the tomb, the day after the worst had happened and before anything good had, and the Bible says almost nothing about it, because there is almost nothing to say. The disciples did not know Sunday was coming. For them, Saturday was not the day before the resurrection, it was just the day after the death, with no morning in sight. The Lord was dead. The dream was over. The body was sealed in a borrowed grave behind a stone they could not move, and they sat in their locked room in the dark and waited for nothing, because as far as they knew there was nothing left to wait for.

I think most honest believers spend most of their lives on Saturday. Not Friday, the acute crisis is mercifully rare, the day the worst actually happens. And not Sunday, the resurrection, which is real but which mostly waits for the end of all things. Most of life is the in-between, the long Saturday after the loss and before the restoration, when the bad thing has already happened and the good thing has not yet come and you are simply living in the gap, in the not-yet, in the silence of a God

who seems to be doing nothing while the body lies in the tomb. The grief is not fresh anymore but it is not healed either. You are just waiting, and you are not even sure what for.

Saturday is the day you must live by a hope you cannot yet see, when the tomb is sealed and the morning has not come.

What I want you to see about that first Holy Saturday is that the disciples were right to grieve and wrong about the ending. They were not wrong that the Lord was dead, He was. They were not wrong that it was the worst thing, it was. Their grief was accurate. But they did not know what was happening on the other side of the stone, in the dark they could not see into, where God was at work in a way no human eye could perceive. The most important day in the history of the world, the day before the resurrection, looked from the outside exactly like defeat. It looked like nothing. It looked like a sealed tomb and a failed messiah and a God who had abandoned His own Son to rot.

And it was, in fact, the hinge of all hope. The waiting was not empty. God was not absent from that Saturday, even though every disciple experienced Him as absent, because they were measuring His presence by what they could see, and what they could see was a grave. This is the discipline of Saturday faith, and it is the hardest discipline there is. To believe that God is at work in the sealed tomb, in the silence, in the gap, when everything visible says the story is over. To live by a hope you cannot yet see, on the testimony of a morning that has not yet come, in a darkness where God appears to be doing nothing and is in fact doing everything.

If you are living on Saturday this week, in the long gap between the loss and the restoration, in the silence after the worst and

before the better, I will not pretend you can see Sunday from where you sit. The disciples could not either. Saturday faith is not the faith that sees the morning coming. It is the faith that keeps the body wrapped with care and the spices ready, that does the next small faithful thing in the dark, that waits without proof because the One who said He would rise has been trustworthy before. The stone is still sealed. The morning has not come. But the God of the empty tomb has not abandoned the Saturday. He is in the dark behind the stone, at work where you cannot see, and The hardest thing about Saturday faith is that it cannot be sustained by results, because on Saturday there are no results, only the gap. Friday faith has the cross to look at, a clear and terrible event. Sunday faith has the empty tomb, a clear and glorious one. But Saturday faith has nothing to look at, no event, only the absence of one, the long flat stretch where God appears to be doing nothing and you have only His past faithfulness and His bare promise to go on. This is why Saturday is where most people abandon the faith, not on Friday, when the drama of suffering can almost feel meaningful, but on Saturday, in the boredom and the silence and the apparent nothingness of the gap, when the question is no longer can I survive this catastrophe but can I endure this endless ordinary waiting in which nothing happens and nothing changes and God says nothing at all. And the only thing that carries a person through Saturday is the memory of who God has been before and the stubborn trust that the silence is not the same as absence. The disciples did not have that trust on the first Saturday, they had given up. But you have something they did not have. You know how the story ended. You know that the Saturday they thought was the end was actually the eve of the most important morning in history, and that knowledge, held in the dark, is the substance of Saturday faith.

Sunday has a way of coming that no one on Saturday could have predicted.

Week Twenty-Five: When You Have Nothing Left to Give

1 Kings 17, verses 8 through 16

A widow was gathering sticks to cook a last meal for herself and her son before they starved, and a prophet asked her to feed him first, and the Bible calls this mercy.

There is a particular exhaustion that comes from being the one everyone draws from, the well that everyone lowers their bucket into, until one day you lower your own bucket and it comes up dry. The caregiver who has nothing left. The parent emptied by years of giving. The pastor, the nurse, the one who has poured out and poured out until there is no more to pour, and yet the needs keep coming, and you stand there with nothing in your hands and a line of people still asking, and the despair of that is real, the sense that you have been used up and there is no refill in sight.

The widow of Zarephath was at the absolute end of her resources. There had been a drought, a famine, and she was down to a handful of flour in a jar and a little oil in a jug. When Elijah found her, she was gathering a few sticks to build a fire and cook one final meal for herself and her son, and then, she said plainly, we will eat it and die. There was nothing left. No reserve, no hidden store, no next meal after this one. She had calculated exactly how much was in the jar, and it came to one last supper and then starvation. This was not poverty with a margin. This was the end.

God did not fill the jar so she would have enough to give. He gave through her, and then the jar did not run out.

And Elijah asks her for the impossible thing. He asks her to make him a small cake of bread first, from the very last of her flour and oil, before she feeds herself and her son. On the face of it this is monstrous, a prophet demanding the dying woman's final meal. But Elijah attaches a promise to it, a word from the God of Israel. The jar of flour shall not be spent, and the jug of oil shall not be empty, until the day the Lord sends rain. And she does it. She gives away the last of what she has, on nothing but a word, and then the text says, the jar of flour was not spent, neither did the jug of oil become empty, according to the word of the Lord. She, her household, and Elijah ate for many days.

Here is what I want you to see, because it cuts against how we think about being empty. God did not fill her jar first and then ask her to give out of the abundance. He asked her to give from the bottom of an empty jar, and the provision came in the giving, not before it. The flour multiplied as it was used, the oil replenished as it was poured. She never had a full jar she could look at and feel secure about. She had a jar that simply did not run out, day by day, meal by meal, exactly enough and never more, provided in the very act of pouring it out. The miracle was not a stockpile. It was a daily sufficiency that only appeared as she kept giving.

I am not telling you to keep pouring out from a place of depletion by sheer willpower, that is how people break, and God is not asking you to grind yourself to dust. But I am telling you that the God of the widow's jar is the God you serve, and He has a way of providing in the pouring that you cannot see when you are staring into an empty jar, calculating that there is only one

meal left. The provision often does not come as a refill you can see in advance. It comes as a strange daily sufficiency, enough for today, appearing exactly as you need it, never enough to make you feel secure and always enough to keep you fed. If you have nothing left to give this week, bring the empty jar to God. I want to say something protective to the depleted, because the church has too often made a virtue of the very emptiness that is destroying its most faithful people. We tell the exhausted caregiver that her sacrifice is beautiful. We praise the burned-out servant for his selflessness. We hold up the empty, the depleted, the poured-out as the highest examples of love, and in doing so we sometimes bless a person right into their own destruction, encouraging them to keep pouring from a jar that has nothing left while we admire their devotion. But the widow of Zarephath was not commended for running herself empty as a spiritual achievement. She was met by God in her emptiness with provision, with a miracle that meant she did not have to choose between feeding the prophet and starving her son, because God supplied what her own jar could not. The lesson is not pour yourself out until you die and call it faithful. The lesson is bring your empty jar to the God who provides, and let Him be the source rather than your own depleted reserves. If you are running on empty this week, the answer is not to admire your own depletion or to grind out a little more from a jar that is dry. The answer is to bring the emptiness to God and let Him be the one who fills it, daily, in the pouring, the way He filled the widow's, so that you are giving from His supply and not from the last of your own.

He has been known to make the last of the oil last longer than anyone could explain, for as long as the drought endures, until the rain finally comes.

Week Twenty-Six: The Halfway Point

Psalm 121

You are halfway through the year now, and I want to stop and ask where you are, and I want to give you a psalm for the climb, because that is what the second half of any hard year is, a climb.

We are at the midpoint. If you started this book in the first week of the year, you have walked through six months of naming wounds, sitting in laments, enduring silences and absences and unanswered prayers. And if you are honest, you may not feel healed. You may feel, in fact, more aware of your wounds than when you started, because we have spent half a year refusing to look away from them, and that refusal, while it is the only road to real healing, is exhausting. So before we walk into the second half of the year, I want to pause at the halfway marker and give you the psalm that pilgrims sang on the road up to Jerusalem, the song for people in the middle of a long climb with the summit not yet in sight.

I lift up my eyes to the hills. From where does my help come. The pilgrim is on the road, looking up at the hard climb ahead, the hills standing between him and the holy city, and he asks the honest question of everyone in the middle of a long ascent. Where is my help going to come from. He does not pretend the climb is easy. He does not pretend he has the strength for it on his own. He looks up at how far there is still to go, and he asks where the help will come from, and then he answers his own question. My help comes from the Lord, who made heaven and

earth.

The God who got you to the halfway point is not going to abandon you on the climb to the summit.

What I most want you to hear at this midpoint is the relentless promise of this psalm, which repeats one idea over and over until it sinks in. He will not let your foot be moved. He who keeps you will not slumber. The Lord is your keeper, the Lord is your shade. The sun shall not strike you by day, nor the moon by night. The Lord will keep you from all evil, He will keep your life. The Lord will keep your going out and your coming in, from this time forth and forevermore. Count how many times the word keep appears. The psalm hammers it. The God who watches over your climb does not sleep, does not look away, does not take a shift off. He keeps you, present tense, continuously, the whole way up.

I think the halfway point of a hard road is the most dangerous place, more dangerous than the beginning. At the beginning you have fresh strength and adrenaline. Near the end you can see the summit and it pulls you forward. But in the middle, the start is too far behind to encourage you and the end is too far ahead to see, and the middle is where people quit, where they sit down on the trail and decide they cannot make it, where the not-yet-healed give up on healing because half a year of facing the wound has worn them down and the other half looks impossible. The middle is where you most need to hear that your keeper does not slumber.

So at this midpoint, before we climb into the second half of the year, I want you to lift up your eyes, not in despair at how far there is to go, but toward the One from whom your help comes. You have made it halfway. That is not nothing. The God who

kept your foot from slipping for six months of facing hard things is the same God who will keep your going out and your coming in through the six months ahead. He has not slumbered once. He is not going to start now. Let me say something honest about the middle of a hard year, because if you have walked with me through six months of facing wounds, you may be wondering whether this was a mistake, whether all this honesty has only made things worse, whether you were better off when you were not looking so closely at the pain. And I understand the doubt, because there is a stretch in the middle of real healing where you feel worse before you feel better, where the wounds you have finally allowed yourself to see seem more vivid and more painful than when you were ignoring them. This is not a sign that the work is failing. It is a sign that it is working. A wound that has been ignored for years does not begin to heal painlessly the moment you finally attend to it. It often hurts more at first, the way a frozen limb hurts as the blood returns, the way a numbed grief aches when feeling comes back to it. The increased pain in the middle is the pain of a thing that was deadened beginning to live again, and living, after a long deadness, is not comfortable. So if the first half of this year has made you more aware of your wounds rather than less, do not despair and do not quit. You are not going backward. You are thawing. And the thawing is the necessary and painful beginning of a healing that the long numbness was preventing.

The second half of the climb is real, and it will cost you, but you do not climb it alone, and you do not climb it on your own strength, and the One who is keeping you has never yet let a pilgrim slip from His hand on the road up to the city.

Week Twenty-Seven: The Sin You Cannot Stop

Romans 7, verses 15 through 25

For I do not do what I want, but I do the very thing I hate. Paul wrote that, the apostle Paul, about himself, and if he could not get free of it, the shame you carry about your own repeated failure is not what you think it is.

There is a specific despair in the sin you cannot seem to stop. Not the dramatic falls, but the same quiet failure, week after week, year after year. The anger you keep losing. The lust you keep returning to. The bitterness you cannot put down. The thing you have confessed and confessed and prayed to be free of, and you are not free of it, and the repetition has worn a groove of shame in you so deep that you have started to believe you are simply a hypocrite, a fraud, a Christian in name who cannot actually live it, because surely a real believer would have conquered this by now. And the shame does not make you holier. It makes you hide, and the hiding makes you weaker, and the cycle tightens.

Paul knew this exact cycle, and he describes it with a rawness that has comforted strugglers for two thousand years. I do not understand my own actions. For I do not do what I want, but I do the very thing I hate. He is not describing his life before Christ. He is describing his life as an apostle, a man who had given everything to God and still found himself doing the thing he hated, failing at the very holiness he preached. I have the desire to do what is right, he says, but not the ability to carry it out. For

I do not do the good I want, but the evil I do not want is what I keep on doing. The greatest theologian in church history could not stop sinning, and he said so, in writing, in Scripture.

The war you are losing in private is the proof you have been made new, because the old you did not even fight.

I want you to hear what this does and does not mean, because it is easy to misread. It does not mean sin does not matter or that you should stop fighting it, Paul calls it wretched and longs to be delivered from it. But it does mean that the presence of an ongoing struggle is not the proof you feared it was. The very fact that you hate the sin, that you do not want to do it, that it grieves you and you keep fighting it and confessing it and getting back up, is evidence that something has changed in you. The old self did not fight. The old self did the sin and felt nothing. The war you are exhausted by, the war you keep seeming to lose, is itself the sign that a new self is alive in you, at war with the old, refusing to make peace with what it used to do without a thought.

And then Paul, in the depths of the cycle, cries out the question and gives the answer that is the whole gospel. Wretched man that I am. Who will deliver me from this body of death. And the answer is not a technique, not a better strategy, not seven steps to victory. The answer is a person. Thanks be to God through Jesus Christ our Lord. The deliverance is not something you achieve by trying harder. It is someone you are united to, who has already won, and who is at work in you, finishing what He started, on a timeline that is His and not yours, a timeline that apparently includes ongoing struggle even for apostles.

So if you are losing a war this week against a sin you cannot stop, I will not give you a cheap promise of instant victory, because Paul did not have instant victory and I will not insult

you with what the Bible itself does not claim. But I will tell you that your struggle is not proof of your fraudulence. It is proof of your new life. The condemnation you feel is not from God, Paul says in the very next breath, there is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus. I have come to believe that the timeline of our sanctification is one of the places where God most offends our pride, because we want to be done, want the victory now, want to arrive at a holiness we can be satisfied with, and God seems determined to keep us dependent instead. If He freed us from every sin the moment we asked, we would quickly forget that we needed Him, would mistake our holiness for our own achievement, would become the proud and self-righteous people that the gospel exists to humble. The slow pace of our deliverance, the way the same sins keep humbling us year after year, keeps us at the foot of the cross where we belong, keeps us needy, keeps us grateful, keeps us from the far greater danger of a holiness we could boast in. I am not saying God wants you to sin. He hates it, and so should you, and you must keep fighting it with everything you have. But I am saying that the lingering struggle, the failure to arrive, the war that goes on longer than you think it should, may be doing a work in you that instant victory could not, a work of humility, of dependence, of keeping you forever in need of a grace you cannot earn. The thorn was not removed from Paul, and the war was not won quickly in Paul, and Paul became, through both, a man who boasted only in his weakness and his Savior.

The war is real and it is long and you may fight it your whole life. But you fight it as a beloved child, already forgiven, already counted righteous, being slowly remade, and not as a fraud one failure away from being cast out. Keep fighting. The fight is the evidence. The verdict is already in your favor.

Week Twenty-Eight: The Anniversary

Joshua 4, verses 1 through 7

There are dates on the calendar that you dread, the anniversaries of loss, and the Bible has something to say about building markers, about setting up stones, about how we are supposed to remember.

Grief keeps an anniversary whether you want it to or not. The date she died. The day he left. The morning of the diagnosis. The anniversary of the accident. The body remembers even when the mind tries not to, and the week before the date you find yourself inexplicably heavy, sleeping badly, short-tempered, and then you look at the calendar and understand. Some part of you has been counting down. And the day itself arrives like a weight, and you do not know what to do with it, whether to mark it or ignore it, whether remembering honors the loss or just reopens the wound, and there is no instruction manual for the anniversary of the worst day of your life.

The Bible is not silent about how to remember. When Israel finally crossed the Jordan into the promised land, after forty years in the wilderness, God told them to do something deliberate with the memory. He told them to take twelve stones from the middle of the riverbed, where the priests had stood while the waters held back, and to carry them to the other side and build them into a marker. And He told them why. When your children ask in time to come, what do these stones mean to you, then you shall tell them. The stones were a memorial. A way of

holding a moment in time, of refusing to let it be forgotten, of building a place where the memory could be visited and honored and passed down.

We are not commanded to forget our hardest days. We are commanded to build something honest where we can remember them.

Notice that God did not tell them to forget the wilderness and just enjoy the new land. He told them to build a monument so they would always remember the crossing, the hard place, the moment God brought them through. Remembering was not a failure to move on. Remembering was an act of faithfulness, a way of keeping the truth of what had happened, both the suffering and the deliverance, alive in the life of the community. The stones honored the hard thing. They gave it a permanent place. They said, this happened, it mattered, we will not pretend it away.

I think we get the anniversary wrong in two opposite directions. Some of us try to ignore it, to power through the date as though it were any other day, and the ignoring costs us, because the grief does not disappear when we refuse to mark it, it just goes underground and comes out sideways. And some of us are consumed by it, the anniversary swallows us whole and we live in the wound and cannot find our way back out. The stones suggest a third way. Build something. Mark the day deliberately, honestly, with intention. Light a candle. Visit the grave. Tell the story to someone who will listen. Write the letter you cannot send. Make a marker, a place to set the grief down and honor it, so that it has somewhere to live other than ambushing you from underground.

If an anniversary is coming this week, I want to give you

permission to mark it, and permission to grieve it, and the assurance that the remembering is not a failure of healing but a part of it. The God who told Israel to build stones at the Jordan is not asking you to forget your hardest day. He is inviting you to build something honest where you can remember it, where you can tell the truth about both the loss and the God who was present in it, where the next generation, or just your own next year, can come and ask what these stones mean, and you can answer. There is a wisdom in marking the anniversary deliberately rather than letting it ambush you, and it is the wisdom of taking back some small measure of agency in a grief that mostly leaves you powerless. When you decide in advance how you will spend the day, when you plan to visit the grave or light the candle or gather the people who also loved them, you transform the day from something that happens to you into something you do, and that small shift matters more than it sounds. The grief is still grief. The loss is still loss. But you are no longer purely at its mercy, ambushed and helpless. You have built a container for it, a deliberate space where it is welcome and expected, which paradoxically keeps it from flooding everything else. The Israelites who built the stones at the Jordan were not at the mercy of their memory, they had given it a place, a marker they could visit and return from. Do the same with your anniversary. Give the grief a deliberate home on that day, a planned and intentional space, so that it does not have to break in through the windows the rest of the year. The remembering is holy. But the remembering can be stewarded, shaped, given its proper place, rather than left to ambush you from underground.

Here is what happened. Here is what it cost. And here is the God who was with me even there.

Week Twenty-Nine: The Comparison of Your Younger Faith

Job 42, verses 1 through 6

I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you. Job said that at the end, and it tells you that the faith you come out of suffering with is not the faith you went in with, and the change is not a loss.

There is a grief that does not get named, the grief for the faith you used to have. The simpler faith, the more certain faith, the faith from before the suffering, when God seemed close and prayer seemed to work and the answers fit the questions. And then the hard thing came, and it broke that faith, or seemed to, and now you have a faith that is quieter, more uncertain, full of unanswered questions, harder around the edges, and you find yourself mourning the believer you used to be, the one who could sing the worship songs without the words catching in your throat, the one who had not yet learned the things you now cannot unlearn. You wonder if you have lost something. You wonder if the doubt and the difficulty mean your faith has shrunk.

Job came out the other side of the worst suffering in the Bible with a different faith than he went in with, and it is worth asking what changed. He had been a righteous man, blameless, a faithful believer whose faith was, by his own later admission, secondhand. I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear. He knew God the way you know a thing you have been taught, the way you know the doctrines you were raised in, real but received, accurate but untested. And then everything was taken

from him, his children, his wealth, his health, and his neat theology shattered against the wall of his suffering, because the God he had heard about did not behave the way the secondhand God was supposed to.

The faith you lose in suffering is often the secondhand faith. What replaces it is a God you have actually seen.

And out of that shattering, after the whirlwind, after God answered him not with explanations but with His own overwhelming presence, Job says the thing that marks the change. Now my eye sees you. The faith he ended with was not bigger in the sense of more certain, he had fewer answers at the end than at the beginning, God never did explain why. It was deeper in a different way. It had moved from hearsay to sight, from received doctrine to personal encounter, from a God he had been told about to a God he had met in the storm. The suffering did not destroy his faith. It burned away the secondhand version and left him with the real thing, which was harder and quieter and infinitely more solid.

I think this is what is happening when your younger faith breaks. You are not losing faith. You are losing a kind of faith, the inherited and untested kind, the kind that worked fine until it met real suffering and then could not hold the weight. And what is replacing it, slowly, painfully, often without your noticing, is a faith that has been through the fire, that has fewer easy answers and more actual God, that has stopped saying the things it was taught to say and started saying the things it has learned are true the hard way. The faith from before could not have survived what you have survived. The faith you are growing now is being built precisely to survive it, and it is being built out of the wreckage of the old one.

So if you are grieving your younger faith this week, mourning the simpler believer you used to be, I want to reframe the loss. You have not gone backward. You are being moved from hearing to seeing, from the God you were told about to the God you have met in your own suffering, and the move feels like loss because the old certainties are genuinely gone and they are not coming back. But Job did not want his old faith back at the end. He had something better, something that no one could take from him because he had not received it from anyone, he had seen it with his own eye in the middle of his ruin. I have watched this transition wound people who did not understand what was happening to them, who mistook the breaking of their inherited faith for the loss of faith itself, and walked away from God at the very moment He was bringing them closer. They had been taught a faith with all the answers, a tidy system in which good people prospered and prayer worked and God behaved predictably, and then suffering shattered the system, because the system could not hold the weight of real suffering, no inherited system can. And feeling the system break, they concluded that faith itself had broken, that they had been believing a lie, that the shattering of their childhood certainties was the discovery that none of it was true. But it was not the discovery that none of it was true. It was the discovery that their version of it was too small, too neat, too dependent on a God who behaved according to their expectations. The God who is actually there is bigger and stranger and less controllable than the inherited system allowed, and meeting Him often requires the system to break first, because the system was standing in the way. If your old certainties are shattering, do not assume your faith is dying. It may be that the secondhand faith is dying so that a firsthand faith can be born, and the death of the one is the necessary condition for the birth of the other.

The faith on the far side of suffering is harder won and harder to shake. It is not less. It is the difference between a rumor and a face.

Week Thirty: Caring for a Body That Is Dying

2 Corinthians 4, verses 16 through 18

So we do not lose heart. Though our outer self is wasting away, our inner self is being renewed day by day. Paul wrote that while his own body was failing, and he did not pretend it was not.

We do not talk honestly about the body wearing out, neither our own nor the bodies of those we love and care for. We live in a culture that hides aging and death, that pretends the body will not fail if we eat right and exercise enough, and the church too often borrows this denial, acting as though faith should keep us young and well, as though a wasting body were a problem to be solved rather than a road every human being walks. And so the person watching their own body decline, or sitting at the bedside of a parent or a spouse whose body is failing, often suffers in a particular isolation, because no one will speak plainly about the thing that is happening, the slow unmaking of a body that used to work.

Paul speaks plainly. Our outer self is wasting away. He does not soften it, does not deny it, does not pretend that faith exempts the body from decay. The word he uses is the word for a thing being destroyed, corrupted, worn down to ruin. He is watching his own body fail, the beatings and the imprisonments and the years taking their toll, and he names it without flinching. The outer self is wasting away. This is not a failure of faith to admit. It is simply true, of him, of you, of everyone you love. Bodies wear out. The strong ones and the weak ones, the faithful and the

faithless, all of them, eventually, waste away.

The body wasting away is not the defeat of the soul. It is the slow uncovering of a self that does not waste.

But Paul holds two things at once, and the holding of both is the whole point. Though the outer self is wasting away, the inner self is being renewed day by day. He does not deny the decay and he does not despair in it, because he sees something happening underneath it, an inner renewal moving in the opposite direction from the outer decline. As the body fails, something else in the person is being made new, is growing, is being prepared for what comes next. The two processes run at the same time, the outer wasting and the inner renewing, and Paul fixes his eyes not on the visible decline but on the invisible renewal, because the things that are seen are transient, but the things that are unseen are eternal.

I have sat at many deathbeds, and I want to tell you that I have seen this be true, not as a comforting theory but as a witnessed reality. I have watched bodies fail completely while something in the person grew more luminous, more peaceful, more themselves, in the very last weeks, as though the wasting of the outer were uncovering the inner the way a receding tide uncovers what was always under the water. The decline is real. I will not lie about it, the body's failing is a hard and often ugly thing and I would not minimize what it costs to watch it or to endure it. But it is not the only thing happening. Underneath it, in the faithful, a renewal is moving that the failing body cannot touch.

If you are caring for a dying body this week, your own or someone else's, I will not tell you it is not hard, it is among the hardest things a person does. But I will tell you that Paul's two truths can be held together, and that holding them is the only

honest comfort. The outer self is wasting away. That is real, name it, do not pretend otherwise. And the inner self is being renewed day by day, also real, also happening, even now, in the very ward where the body fails. I want to speak directly to the caregiver, the one sitting at the bedside watching it happen, because your suffering is real and largely invisible and rarely acknowledged. You are watching a body you love unmake itself, day by day, and you are doing the exhausting, unglamorous, endless work of tending it, the feeding and the cleaning and the medicating and the long hours of presence, and almost no one sees what it costs you. You are grieving a person who is still alive, which is its own peculiar agony, mourning them in pieces as the disease takes them in pieces, saying goodbye over and over to a thousand small losses before the final one comes. And you are tired in a way that has no bottom, and you sometimes feel things you are ashamed of, exhaustion, resentment, the guilty wish that it would end, and then the horror at having wished it. I want you to know that all of this is normal, that the saints who tended the dying felt all of it, that there is no shame in the complicated feelings of long caregiving. And I want you to know that the inner renewal Paul promises is happening in you, the caregiver, as well as in the one you tend, that this brutal and holy work is shaping something in you that nothing else could shape, and that the God who sees what no one else sees is keeping careful count of every hour you spend in that room.

The wasting is not the whole story. It is the slow uncovering of a self that does not waste, being prepared, even as the body lets go, for a renewal that the grave cannot reverse.

Week Thirty-One: When the Healing Is Not Coming

John 5, verses 1 through 9

A man lay by a pool for thirty-eight years waiting for a healing that never came, and Jesus walked up and asked him a question that sounds almost cruel. Do you want to be healed.

Thirty-eight years. I want you to sit with that number before we go any further. The man by the pool of Bethesda had been an invalid for thirty-eight years, lying near a pool that was said to heal whoever entered the water first when it was stirred, and for thirty-eight years he had never been first, never been fast enough, never had anyone to help him in, and so he lay there, year after year after year, watching others get healed while his own healing never came. This is the wound of the long disappointment, the healing that everyone else seems to get and you do not, the prayer answered for the person in the next pew while yours goes unanswered for decades, the slow erosion of hope over years of watching the water stir and never reaching it in time.

And Jesus asks him, do you want to be healed. On the surface it is a strange question, almost insulting, of course he wants to be healed, he has lain by a healing pool for thirty-eight years. But I think Jesus asks it because thirty-eight years of disappointment can do something to a person, can wear hope down to the point where they have stopped really wanting the thing they cannot have, have made a kind of peace with the impossibility, have built an identity around the waiting itself. After enough years of the healing not coming, sometimes the saddest thing happens,

you stop hoping for it, because hope that is disappointed long enough becomes too painful to keep, and you protect yourself by ceasing to want.

After enough years of disappointment, the dangerous thing is not that you stop trying. It is that you stop hoping.

The man's answer reveals exactly this. He does not say yes, heal me. He says, essentially, I have no one to help me into the water, and while I am trying to get there, someone else always goes down before me. It is the answer of a man whose hope has curdled into resignation, who has stopped expecting and started explaining why it can never happen, who has made the disappointment into a story he tells about why his life is the way it is. Thirty-eight years had taught him to manage his hopelessness rather than to hope. And Jesus, instead of arguing with the resignation, simply heals him. Get up, take up your bed, and walk. And the man does, after thirty-eight years, in a single moment, when he had long since stopped believing it could happen.

I am not going to tell you that your healing is coming this week, because I do not know that, and this book does not lie, and the man waited thirty-eight years, which means sometimes the wait is very long indeed and some people die still waiting by the pool. But I am going to warn you about the particular danger of the long disappointment, which is not that you will stop trying but that you will stop hoping, that you will protect yourself from the pain of unanswered prayer by quietly ceasing to want the thing at all, and call it acceptance when it is really a wound so old it has gone numb. Do you want to be healed. It is worth letting Jesus ask you that, honestly, even after years, even if the wanting hurts.

Because the healing, when and if it comes, often comes the way

it came to that man, suddenly, from outside, by the word of a Lord who walked up to a pool. He was not summoned to and healed a man who had stopped asking. He did not heal the man because the man's hope earned it, the man had barely any hope left. He healed him out of His own freedom and compassion, on a day the man did not see coming, after a wait so long the man had stopped counting. There is a subtle thing that happens in the long disappointment, and Jesus' question to the man exposes it, and I do not want you to miss how merciful the question actually is beneath its sharpness. After enough years of unanswered prayer, we build an identity around the waiting itself, around being the one who suffers, the one who is sick, the one whose prayer goes unanswered, until the affliction becomes not just our circumstance but our self-understanding, the lens through which we see everything, the story we tell about who we are. And then, paradoxically, the prospect of healing becomes threatening, because if we were healed, who would we be. The man by the pool had been an invalid for thirty-eight years, and that was not just his condition, it was his identity, his place, his explanation for his life. Jesus' question, do you want to be healed, gently exposes the possibility that part of us, after enough years, becomes attached to the very affliction we hate, because we have built our whole sense of self around it. He is not accusing the man of wanting to stay sick. He is inviting him to want something he has been afraid to want, to risk a healing that would require him to become a new person, to hope again after thirty-eight years of building his identity around hopelessness.

Keep wanting the healing, even if it costs you to want it. And keep your eyes open, because the Lord has a way of showing up at the pool you have given up on, on an ordinary day, with a word that ends a thirty-eight-year wait in a single sentence.

Week Thirty-Two: The Marriage That Is Hard

Ecclesiastes 4, verses 9 through 12

Two are better than one. The Bible says it plainly, and it is true, and it is also true that being bound to another person is sometimes the hardest thing you will ever do, and both of those are in the same Scripture.

We do not preach honestly about marriage, and the dishonesty wounds people. We hold up the wedding and the romance and the two becoming one, and we are quiet about the years in the middle when the two who became one have grown so far apart they sleep in the same bed like strangers, when the love you vowed has gone cold and you cannot remember why, when you are not in crisis exactly but you are not well either, just two tired people sharing a mortgage and a history and a distance neither of you knows how to cross. The marriage that is not ending but is not thriving, the hard marriage, the long flat stretch, this we do not talk about, and so the people living it assume they are the only ones, and they suffer the loneliness of a hard marriage in silence.

Ecclesiastes, the most clear-eyed book in the Bible, the one that refuses every illusion, tells the truth about why we bind ourselves to another person, and the truth is not romance. Two are better than one, the Preacher says, because they have a good reward for their toil. For if they fall, one will lift up his fellow. But woe to him who is alone when he falls and has not another to lift him up. The reason for the union is not feeling. It is that

we fall, all of us, and we need someone to lift us up, and the alone person who falls has no one. The marriage exists not because it makes you happy every day, Ecclesiastes is too honest for that, but because life knocks you down and you were not built to get up alone.

The point of the covenant is not that it always feels like love. It is that someone is there when you fall.

This reframes the hard marriage entirely. We tend to measure a marriage by how it feels, and when it stops feeling like the wedding day we conclude something has gone wrong, that the love has died, that the covenant has failed. But Ecclesiastes locates the value of the bond not in its warmth but in its presence. If they fall, one will lift up his fellow. The hard marriage, the cold stretch, the long flat years, can still be doing the deepest thing a marriage does, which is to put another human being beside you in the dark, someone who is there when you fall even if neither of you feels much of anything on a given Tuesday. The presence outlasts the feeling. The covenant holds when the romance has gone quiet.

And the Preacher adds one more line that has carried more than one struggling marriage. A threefold cord is not quickly broken. Two strands, the two of you, can fray and weaken on your own, the marriage held together only by the two of you is vulnerable. But a third strand woven through it, the presence of God in the covenant, makes a cord that does not break easily even under strain. The marriages I have watched survive the hard years were not the ones with the strongest feelings. They were the ones with the third strand, two people who had bound themselves not only to each other but to God, and who held on through the flat stretch because the cord was stronger than their own waning love.

If your marriage is hard this week, not in crisis but not well, I will not pretend a feeling will descend and fix it, and I will not shame you for the distance, because the Bible itself is honest that being bound to another person is sometimes the hardest of all human things. But I will point you to what the covenant is actually for. Not perpetual romance, which no marriage sustains. Presence in the falling. Someone there in the dark. A threefold cord, you and your spouse and the God woven through, that does not break quickly even when the two strands have worn thin. Stay in the cord. Tend the third strand. The feeling may yet return, it often does, in seasons. I have officiated many weddings, and I have buried many of the same couples decades later, and I have learned to distrust the version of marriage we celebrate at the altar, the version built entirely on feeling, on the chemistry of the early years, on the conviction that this overwhelming emotion will last forever. It does not last forever. It cannot, no emotion can, and the marriages that staked everything on the feeling are the ones that shatter when the feeling inevitably wanes, because they had built on something that was never meant to bear the weight of a lifetime. The marriages that last are built on something underneath the feeling, on covenant, on the promise made and kept regardless of the day's emotion, on two people who decided that love is finally a commitment of the will and not merely a state of the heart. This is not a cold view of marriage. It is, in the end, a warmer one, because the feeling, when it returns, as it does in seasons, returns to a structure strong enough to have held without it. The couples I have watched grow old together did not feel the wedding-day emotion every day for fifty years. They felt many things across those years, including long flat stretches where they felt almost nothing. But they had built on the covenant, on the promise, on the third strand woven through, and the structure held when the

feeling could not, and inside that holding the feeling had room to come and go and come again.

But even before it does, the covenant is doing its hardest and most faithful work, which is simply that you are not alone when you fall.

Week Thirty-Three: The God Who Wrestles You

Hosea 6, verses 1 through 3

Come, let us return to the Lord. For he has torn us, that he may heal us. He has struck us down, and he will bind us up. That is a terrifying verse, and I think it is true, and we mostly refuse to look at it.

There is a question that sits underneath a great deal of suffering, and most devotionals will not touch it, because the safe answer is to blame everything hard on the enemy or on a broken world and to insist that God only ever gives good things. And there is truth in that, God is good, and much suffering does come from evil and from the brokenness of the world and not from God's hand. But the Bible is more honest and more frightening than our safe theology, because the Bible sometimes says that God Himself is the one who has wounded us, that the tearing came from His hand, that He struck us down on purpose, and that the wounding was, somehow, an act of love aimed at a healing we could not have reached any other way.

Hosea says it without flinching. He has torn us, that he may heal us. He has struck us down, and he will bind us up. The same God, in the same sentence, is the one who tore and the one who heals, the one who struck down and the one who binds up. This is not a comfortable theology and I am not going to make it comfortable. But I have lived long enough, and pastored long enough, and suffered enough myself, to believe it is sometimes true, that God in His love will wound us, will let us be torn, will

strike down the thing we were clinging to, because He is after a healing that our comfortable, unwounded life was actively preventing, and the only road to it ran through a tearing.

Sometimes the wound is from His hand, and it is still love, because He was after a healing you would not have chosen.

I think of the things in my own life that I would never have let go of if they had not been torn from me, the securities I trusted instead of God, the idols I had built out of good things, the self-sufficiency that kept me from ever really needing Him. And I think of how some of those were torn away in seasons of suffering, and how I hated it, and how I now see, from the far side, that I would have clung to those things until they destroyed me if God had not, in His severe mercy, pried them out of my hands through a wounding I experienced at the time as nothing but loss. The tearing was real. It hurt exactly as much as it seemed to. And it was, I have come to believe, the love of a God who wanted me more than He wanted my comfort.

This is not a thing to say lightly, and it is not a thing to say to someone else in their fresh grief, never tell a person in raw suffering that God did this to them on purpose, that is a cruelty, and Job's friends are the warning. This is a thing you can only come to slowly, about your own life, from the far side, in the privacy of your own reckoning with God. But it is in the Bible, and I will not pretend it is not, because pretending would be the lie this book refuses. Sometimes the God who heals is the same God who wounded, and the wound was love, severe love, love that was willing to hurt you to save you, the way a surgeon's love sometimes looks exactly like a knife.

If you suspect that some of your suffering came from His hand,

do not rush to a comfortable explanation that gets God off the hook, and do not collapse into the conclusion that He must therefore be cruel. Hold the harder thing. He has torn us, that he may heal us. The tearing and the healing are from the same hand, and the hand is love, even when it wounds, especially when it wounds, because there are healings that can only be reached through a tearing, and a God who loved us too gently to ever wound us would be a God who left us to be destroyed by the things we would not surrender. Let us return to the Lord, Hosea says, even to the One who tore us. I have to be careful here, more careful than anywhere else in this book, because this truth is the most easily abused of any I have written, and abused, it becomes a weapon that has wounded countless suffering people. There is a difference between recognizing, slowly and privately, from the far side, that God may have used a wound in your own life for your good, and declaring to a suffering person that God sent their suffering on purpose and they had better learn the lesson. The first is a hard-won wisdom you arrive at about your own story. The second is the cruelty of Job's friends, who looked at a man covered in sores and grieving ten dead children and informed him that God was teaching him something. Never do to another person what Job's friends did. Never tell the bereaved mother that God took her child to refine her. Never tell the cancer patient that God is wounding them for their growth. That is not your call to make about someone else's suffering, and to make it is to add cruelty to their grief. This is a truth for your own private reckoning with God, about your own life, arrived at over years, never a verdict you pronounce over another. Even Hosea is speaking of a whole people to whom God had spoken directly through a prophet, not handing us license to diagnose each other's pain. Hold this truth, but hold it only over your own life, and hold it gently, and never use it as a club against someone

else's wound.

He has not torn you to abandon you. He has torn you to bind you up.

Week Thirty-Four: The Numbness

Psalm 6, verses 1 through 7

I am weary with my moaning. Every night I flood my bed with tears. But there is a state past tears, a state where you cannot even cry anymore, and that numbness is its own kind of suffering, and it is harder to talk about than grief.

We have words for grief and words for fear and words for anger, but we do not have good words for numbness, for the state where you have gone past feeling into a kind of grey nothing, where you cannot cry and cannot pray and cannot feel God and cannot feel much of anything, where you go through the motions of your life like a person underwater, present but not present, alive but not quite living. It is not sadness exactly, it is the absence even of sadness, the place you arrive at when the pain has been too much for too long and something in you has simply switched off in order to survive. And it frightens people, this numbness, because at least grief feels like something, and the numb person fears they have lost even the capacity to feel.

The Bible knows about the place before the numbness, the weariness that precedes it. David in the sixth psalm is at the end of his emotional endurance. I am weary with my moaning, he says. Every night I flood my bed with tears, I drench my couch with weeping. My eye wastes away because of grief. This is a man who has wept until weeping itself has exhausted him, who is worn down past the point where he can keep producing the tears, and you can feel in the psalm the approach of the numbness, the place where even the grief runs out and there is

nothing left to feel. The flooding of the bed cannot go on forever. Eventually the floods run dry, and what comes after the dry is the grey nothing.

When you have gone numb, God has not gone anywhere. He is present in the grey, even when you cannot feel Him there.

Here is what I most need you to know about the numbness, because it is the thing the numbness most lies about. The numbness tells you that because you cannot feel God, God is not there. It tells you that the absence of feeling is the absence of presence, that your inability to sense Him means He has withdrawn. And this is exactly backward. Your feelings are not a measurement of God. They are a measurement of you, of your exhausted, overwhelmed, shut-down nervous system that has gone numb to survive. God's presence does not depend on your capacity to feel it, any more than the sun stops shining when you are too tired to open your eyes. He is present in the numbness exactly as fully as He is present in the tears. You simply cannot feel Him right now, and that is a fact about your exhaustion, not a fact about His absence.

I have walked through numb seasons, and I want to tell you the only thing that helped, because it is not what you would expect. It was not trying to feel something, the harder I tried to manufacture feeling the more the numbness mocked me. What helped was deciding to act on what was true regardless of what I could feel, to keep showing up to prayer with nothing, to keep going to worship as a body even when the heart was a stone, to keep doing the next faithful thing not because I felt like it but because it was true and faith is not a feeling. The numbness is not faithlessness. It is exhaustion. And faith in the numb season

is not the recovery of feeling, it is the decision to keep walking toward God on the strength of what you know rather than what you feel.

If you have gone numb this week, past tears, past feeling, into the grey, I will not tell you to feel better, that is the cruelest thing you can say to a numb person, as though they could feel on command. I will tell you that the numbness is not the truth about God, only the truth about your exhaustion, and that He is present in the grey exactly as much as He is present in the storm. Keep walking. Keep showing up with your nothing. The feeling will return, slowly, the way sensation returns to a limb that has gone to sleep, with that strange and even painful tingling as the deadness wakes back up. The numbness frightens people more than the pain, and I think it is worth understanding why. Pain, at least, is feeling, is aliveness, is proof that you still care, still love, still have a heart that can be moved. But numbness feels like death, like the loss of the very capacity that makes you human, and the person who has gone numb often fears they have become a monster, a hollow thing, someone who has stopped being able to love or grieve or feel anything at all. And underneath that fear is a deeper one, the fear that the numbness is permanent, that they will never feel again, that they have crossed into a greyness from which there is no return. I want to tell you, from having walked through it and having sat with many who have, that the numbness is not death and it is not permanent and it is not the loss of your humanity. It is a defense, a protective shutdown, the mind's way of surviving a load of pain it could not bear all at once, the circuit breaker tripping to prevent the whole system from burning out. It is not a sign that you have stopped caring. It is a sign that you cared so much the caring overwhelmed your capacity to feel it, and so the feeling went underground to keep you alive. It will come back. The breaker will reset. The grey

will give way to color again, slowly, often painfully, and you will discover that the love and the grief were never gone, only buried, waiting, until you were strong enough to feel them again.

And when it returns, you will find that God was there the whole time, in the numbness, in the grey, keeping you while you could not feel yourself being kept.

Week Thirty-Five: The Injustice That Was Never Made Right

Psalm 73, verses 1 through 17

The wicked prosper and the righteous suffer, and the man who wrote about it almost lost his faith over it, and the Bible put his near-loss in the songbook because it is the most honest thing.

There is a wound that festers in a particular way, the wound of injustice that was never made right. The person who hurt you and faced no consequence. The cheater who prospered. The liar who won. The abuser who was never held accountable, who lives a comfortable life while you carry the damage they did. And underneath the personal injustices, the larger ones, the systems that crush the innocent, the powerful who escape every reckoning, the evil that seems to pay and the goodness that seems to cost. It is one of the oldest and hardest tests of faith, and it has driven more people away from God than perhaps any other thing, this sense that the universe is not just, that the wicked prosper while the faithful suffer, and that God is doing nothing about it.

Asaph, who wrote the seventy-third psalm, nearly lost his faith over exactly this. He says it with startling honesty. My feet had almost stumbled, my steps had nearly slipped. For I was envious of the arrogant when I saw the prosperity of the wicked. He looked at the people who had abandoned God, the proud and the violent and the corrupt, and he saw them thriving, healthy, untroubled, rich, dying peacefully in their beds, and he looked at his own faithful life full of affliction and trouble, and he nearly

walked away. All in vain have I kept my heart clean, he says. For all the day long I have been stricken. He is on the edge of concluding that faithfulness is pointless, that the whole arrangement is a fraud, that the wicked have it figured out and the righteous are fools.

The injustice that was never made right in this life is not the end of the accounting. There is a reckoning you cannot see.

And then comes the turn, and it is not a cheap turn, it is a turn that took him into the presence of God before it could come. Until I went into the sanctuary of God, then I discerned their end. The shift did not happen through better arguments or through the injustice being suddenly fixed, the wicked were still prospering when he walked into the sanctuary. The shift happened when he got close to God again, when he stepped out of the relentless comparison and into the presence of the One who sees the whole story, and from there he discerned their end, he saw that the prosperity of the wicked was not the final accounting, that there is a reckoning beyond what he could see, that the books are not closed at death and the justice that fails in this life is not the last word.

I am not going to tell you that the injustice you suffered will be made right in this life, because often it is not, and Asaph is honest that often it is not, the wicked frequently prosper all the way to a peaceful grave. But I am going to tell you what Asaph learned in the sanctuary, which is that this life is not the whole accounting. There is a justice that you cannot see from where you stand, a reckoning held by a God who misses nothing, who has recorded every wrong, who will not let the abuser's escape from human consequence be the end of the story. The injustice

that was never made right here is not therefore never made right at all. It is held, by God, for a judgment that is real and coming, even though you cannot see it from inside the unfairness.

This is not a license to stop seeking justice now, Scripture commands us to do justice, to defend the weak, to resist evil. But it is a comfort for the wounds that no human justice ever reached, the wrongs that escaped every earthly court, the abusers who died comfortable and the cheaters who prospered to the end. Their end is not what it looked like from here. Asaph saw it when he drew near to God, and so can you. The reason injustice corrodes faith so effectively is that it strikes at our deepest assumption about how the universe should work, the assumption that goodness should be rewarded and evil punished, that the moral order should be reliable, that doing right should pay and doing wrong should cost. When that assumption is violated, when we watch the wicked prosper and the righteous suffer with no apparent reckoning, something in us concludes that either God is not just or God is not there, because a just and present God would surely not allow this. Asaph felt exactly this pull, nearly slipped, nearly concluded that his faithfulness had been in vain. And the resolution he found was not that the moral order is an illusion, nor that the injustice did not matter, but that the accounting is not finished at the boundary of this life, that the books we see balanced wrongly are not the final books, that there is a judgment beyond the grave where every hidden thing is brought to light and every wrong addressed. This is not a way of avoiding the problem of injustice. It is the only frame in which the problem can be borne, because the alternative, that this life is the whole accounting and the abuser truly did get away with it forever, is a despair no faith can survive. The justice you long for is real. It is simply not yet complete, and the part you cannot see is held by a Judge who has not, despite all appearances, lost

track of a single wrong.

The God who sees has not forgotten what was done to you. The accounting is not closed. The injustice that was never made right in this life is held in the hands of the only Judge who never fails, and from inside His sanctuary, even now, you can begin to discern their end, and yours, and find that the books balance after all, in a courtroom you cannot yet see.

Week Thirty-Six: The Fear of the Future

Matthew 6, verses 25 through 34

Do not be anxious about tomorrow, for tomorrow will be anxious for itself. Jesus said it, and He was not naive about how hard it is, He was teaching it to people who did not know where their next meal was coming from.

The future is a country we cannot enter, and yet we live there most of the time, in a place that does not yet exist, running scenarios of catastrophes that have not happened and may never happen, borrowing tomorrow's troubles to suffer them today on top of today's. The anxiety about the future is one of the great thieves of the present, and it is nearly universal, this compulsion to project forward into all the ways things could go wrong, to lie awake rehearsing disasters, to carry the weight of a hundred possible futures none of which has arrived and most of which never will. We suffer enormously over things that do not happen. We pay the price of catastrophes in advance, in full, and then the catastrophe often does not come, and we have spent ourselves for nothing.

Jesus addresses this directly, and I want you to notice He does not address it with a platitude. He does not say everything will be fine, He does not promise that the feared future will not come, He is too honest for that, and indeed He tells His followers elsewhere that they will face real trouble. Instead He points at the birds and the flowers. Look at the birds of the air, they neither sow nor reap nor gather into barns, and yet your heavenly

Father feeds them. Consider the lilies of the field, how they grow, they neither toil nor spin, yet Solomon in all his glory was not arrayed like one of these. The argument is not that the future holds no danger. The argument is that the same God who feeds the birds and clothes the fields is your Father, and He has not stopped being your Father in the future you are afraid of.

You cannot live in tomorrow. God is not there yet either, in the sense that His grace for it has not arrived, because you do not need it yet.

Here is the thing about the future that has helped me most, and it is hidden in the last verse of the passage. Sufficient for the day is its own trouble. Jesus is not denying that trouble is coming, He explicitly says each day has its own. What He is saying is that the grace to meet tomorrow's trouble does not arrive today, because you do not need it today, and so when you project into tomorrow you are walking into a country without the supplies for it, facing tomorrow's trouble with only today's grace, which is exactly why it feels unbearable. You are trying to carry a weight God has not yet given you the strength for, because the strength comes with the weight, on the day, not before.

This is the secret of the manna in the wilderness, and it is the secret of the anxious future. God gave Israel bread one day at a time, and when they tried to store it up for tomorrow it rotted, because the provision was daily, fitted to the day, not stockpiled in advance. And the grace for your future is the same. It will be there when you arrive in that future, daily bread for that day's trouble, but it is not available now, in advance, which is why the imagined future feels so overwhelming, you are facing it without the grace that has not yet been issued, because you are not there yet to receive it.

So when the fear of the future takes you this week, and you find yourself living in a tomorrow that does not exist, suffering catastrophes that have not come, I want you to hear Jesus pull you back to the only place you can actually live, which is today. Do not be anxious about tomorrow. Not because tomorrow holds no trouble, it may. But because you are not there yet, and the grace for it is not here yet, and when you arrive, the grace will arrive with you, daily bread for that day, manna fitted to that trouble, from the same Father who has never once failed to feed the birds. I have noticed that the fear of the future feeds on a particular illusion, the illusion that if we could just worry enough, plan enough, rehearse enough of the possible disasters, we could somehow control the future or at least be prepared for whatever it brings. And so we tell ourselves that the anxiety is responsible, prudent, a form of preparation, when in fact it prepares us for nothing and only steals the present. Think about it honestly. The catastrophes you have actually faced in your life, did the worrying beforehand help you when they came. Or did you find, when the real thing arrived, that the grace to meet it arrived with it, fresh, sufficient, nothing like the imagined version you had rehearsed in your anxious nights. And the catastrophes you worried about that never came, what did all that worry accomplish except to make you suffer them in advance, paying the full emotional price for events that never happened. Worry is not preparation. It is the suffering of a thing twice, once in imagination and once in reality, or worse, the suffering of a thing once in imagination that reality never even delivers. Jesus is not telling you to be irresponsible about the future, to make no plans, to ignore tomorrow entirely. He is telling you to stop living there, to stop paying in advance for troubles that have not come.

You cannot live in tomorrow. Come back to today. There is

enough grace here for today, and there will be enough there for then, and you are only ever asked to live one day at a time, with the bread that is given for it.

Week Thirty-Seven: The Strength That Comes and Goes

Isaiah 40, verses 28 through 31

They who wait for the Lord shall renew their strength. But notice it says renew, which means the strength runs out, which means even the renewed strength runs out again, and the waiting has to happen over and over.

We misread the famous promise at the end of Isaiah forty, and the misreading sets us up for despair. We hear they shall mount up with wings like eagles, they shall run and not be weary, they shall walk and not faint, and we picture a permanent state, a strength that, once received, never fails, an upgrade to a tireless version of ourselves. And then our strength does fail, again, the way it always does, and we conclude that we have lost the promise, that we are doing something wrong, that the eagle's wings were for other people, more faithful people, because here we are weary again, fainting again, out of strength again, and the promise seems to have expired.

But read the verb. They shall renew their strength. Renew. You do not renew a thing that never ran out. The promise is not that you will receive a strength that lasts forever and never depletes. The promise is that when your strength runs out, and it will, repeatedly, the waiting on God renews it, refills it, restores it, so that you can go again until it runs out again, at which point you wait again, and it is renewed again. The picture is not of a permanent reservoir. It is of a recurring renewal, a strength that comes and goes and comes again, fitted to a life that is long and

hard and full of depletions, where you will need to be renewed not once but a thousand times.

The promise is not a strength that never fails. It is a strength that is renewed, again and again, every time you wait.

And notice the order in the passage, because it descends rather than ascends, and the descent is the kindness. They shall mount up with wings like eagles, that is the dramatic strength, the soaring, the high moments of faith when you feel carried. They shall run and not be weary, that is the next register down, the strength for sustained effort, the long obedience that does not collapse. And then they shall walk and not faint, the lowest register, the strength simply to keep putting one foot in front of the other without falling down. Isaiah ends with walking, not flying, because most of life is walking, not soaring, and the deepest promise is not that you will always soar but that you will be given the strength to keep walking when soaring is long out of the question.

I have lived long enough to know that the soaring seasons are rare and the walking seasons are most of life. There are times you mount up like an eagle, times of vivid faith and clear strength and the sense of being carried, and they are real and they are gifts, but they do not last, they never last, and a faith built only for soaring will collapse the first time the wings give out. The strength I have come to depend on is the walking strength, the renewed-again strength, the grace that does not let me soar but does, somehow, every time I am sure I cannot take another step, let me take another step. Walk and not faint. It is the least dramatic of the three and it is the one I have needed most.

So if your strength has run out again this week, and you are weary again, and you feel like you have failed because the strength keeps depleting, I want to correct the misreading that is hurting you. The strength was always meant to run out, and the promise was always renewal, not permanence. You have not lost anything. You have simply arrived, again, at the place where the strength is renewed, the place of waiting on the Lord, which you will arrive at again and again across a long life, because that is how it works, deplete and renew, deplete and renew, soaring sometimes, running sometimes, and walking most of the time, but always, every time you wait, given enough to take the next step. There is a kind of shame that attaches to the depletion of strength, especially for those of us who have built our identity on being strong, on being the reliable one, the capable one, the one who can always go a little further. When that strength runs out, as it always eventually does, we do not just feel tired, we feel like failures, like we have let everyone down, like our worth, which we had quietly attached to our capacity, has collapsed along with the capacity. And so we push past the depletion, refuse to admit it, drive ourselves on the fumes of an exhausted tank because stopping would mean admitting we are not as strong as we needed to believe we were. But the promise of Isaiah is not a promise to the self-sufficient, to those who can generate their own strength indefinitely. It is a promise to those who wait on the Lord, which is to say, to those who have come to the end of their own strength and are now dependent on a renewal they cannot manufacture. The depletion is not the failure. The depletion is the doorway, the place where self-sufficiency ends and the waiting on God begins, the place where you finally stop drawing on your own dwindling reserves and start drawing on His inexhaustible ones. You were never meant to be the source of your own strength. The running out is how

you learn it, again and again, every time the tank empties and you are driven back to the only well that does not run dry.

Wait on Him. The strength is coming back. It always does. That is what renew means.

Week Thirty-Eight: The Guilt of the Survivor

2 Samuel 18, verses 31 through 33

O my son Absalom, my son, my son Absalom. Would I had died instead of you, O Absalom, my son, my son. David wished he had died in his son's place, and the grief of the one who lives when another died is its own dark country.

There is a guilt that belongs to those who survive, and it is one of the least understood of all griefs. The parent who outlives a child and feels they should have gone first, that the order is monstrous, that they have no right to still be breathing. The survivor of the accident that killed others, who cannot understand why they lived and the others did not. The one who walked away from the diagnosis their friend did not survive. The soldier who came home when others did not. This guilt is not rational, the survivor did nothing wrong, did not cause the death, could not have prevented it, and yet the guilt is real and it is crushing, the sense that you do not deserve the life you still have, that someone better or more deserving died in your place, that your survival is somehow a theft.

David knew this grief in its rawest form. His son Absalom had betrayed him, raised an army against him, tried to seize his throne and his life. And yet when Absalom was killed in the battle, David's response was not relief or vindication but the most anguished cry of a grieving father in all of Scripture. He goes up to the chamber over the gate and weeps, and as he goes he says, O my son Absalom, my son, my son Absalom, would I

had died instead of you. Five times he says my son in two verses, and the heart of it is the survivor's wish, would I had died instead of you. He would have traded his life for his son's. He could not understand why he, the father, the older one, the one who should have gone first, was still alive while his boy was dead.

The survivor's guilt is love with nowhere to go, love that would have died in the other's place and was not allowed to.

I want to say something carefully to the survivor, because the guilt you carry is not what it claims to be. The guilt presents itself as a verdict, as though your survival were a wrong you committed, a theft of a life you had no right to. But underneath the guilt, if you look closely, is something else, something that is not guilt at all but love. The wish that you had died instead is the wish of a love so deep it would have traded places, would have given its own life to spare the other, and was not given the chance. That is not a crime. That is the highest love there is, the love that would lay down its life for another, and it has been turned, by grief, into a guilt, because the love had nowhere to go when the other one died and you lived.

You did not steal your life. You did not deserve to die in their place, no one deserves to die, death is the enemy, not a debt you failed to pay. The fact that you lived and they did not is not a verdict on your worth or theirs, it is the inscrutable and often brutal arithmetic of a broken world, and it is not yours to carry as guilt. David's wish that he had died instead of Absalom was the cry of a father's love, and God did not rebuke it, God recorded it, tenderly, in Scripture, because God understood that it was not really guilt at all but love that had been given no other outlet than this terrible wish.

If you carry the survivor's guilt this week, I want to offer you a reframe that I have watched bring real relief to people who thought they would carry the guilt forever. The guilt is love. It is love that would have traded places, love that grieves it was not allowed to, love that does not know what to do with itself now that the other is gone and you remain. You are permitted to grieve that you survived. You are not required to feel guilty for it. The God who recorded David's would I had died instead of you understands the love underneath your guilt, and He does not condemn you for living. He grieves with you that you had to. There is often a specific torment in survivor's guilt that the bereaved cannot say out loud, the if-only that runs on an endless loop, the conviction that some different action, some earlier decision, some greater vigilance could have changed the outcome and saved the one who died. If only I had insisted on the doctor sooner. If only I had been driving. If only I had not let them go. The mind of the survivor becomes a prosecutor building a case against itself, finding in hindsight a hundred forks in the road where a different choice might have led to a different end, and convicting itself of a negligence that, examined in the clear light of day, was no negligence at all, only the ordinary not-knowing in which all of us live every moment, unable to see the future, making the best decisions we can with what we have. You could not have known. That is the thing the guilt refuses to accept, that you were not God, that you could not see what was coming, that the information which seems so obvious in hindsight was simply not available to you in the moment. The if-only assumes a knowledge you did not have and could not have had. Lay down the prosecution. You did not fail to save them through some culpable blindness. You lived, as all of us live, forward into a future you could not see, and the outcome was not in your hands, and it was never your fault.

And He has work for the life you did not think you deserved, because you are still here, and that is not an accident, and it is not a theft, and the love that would have died in their place can yet live for them instead.

Week Thirty-Nine: The Slow Return

Luke 24, verses 13 through 32

Two disciples walked home from Jerusalem on the worst day, certain it was over, and Jesus walked beside them the whole way and they did not recognize Him until much later, and that is how restoration usually comes.

We want our healing to be a moment, a single instant of breakthrough where the darkness lifts and we know, suddenly and certainly, that we are well again. And sometimes God does work that way, in a flash, in a clear before and after. But far more often, in my experience, restoration comes the way it came on the road to Emmaus, slowly, almost imperceptibly, walking beside us in a form we do not recognize, warming our hearts before our minds catch up, so that we only realize afterward that we have been in the presence of the One who heals, that the restoration was happening the whole time we were too discouraged to see it. The two on the road to Emmaus did not have a breakthrough moment in the middle of their grief. They had a long walk with a stranger they did not know was Jesus.

Look at where they were. It was the third day, resurrection day, though they did not know it. They were walking away from Jerusalem, away from the place of the crucifixion, going home defeated, and when the risen Jesus fell into step beside them and asked what they were discussing, they stopped, their faces downcast, and poured out their disappointment to the very One they were disappointed about. We had hoped, they said, that he was the one to redeem Israel. We had hoped. The saddest words

in the language, the past tense of a hope that has died. And Jesus, unrecognized, walked with them through their disappointment, listening to their account of His own death, before He said a word to lift them.

Restoration usually does not announce itself. It walks beside you in disguise, warming your heart before your mind catches up.

And here is the pattern of the slow return, the thing I want you to see. Jesus did not immediately reveal Himself and fix everything. He walked the whole road with them first, He let them say all of their grief, and then He opened the Scriptures to them, slowly, point by point, beginning with Moses and the prophets, interpreting the whole story until, though they still did not recognize Him, something began to thaw in them. Later they would say, did not our hearts burn within us while he talked to us on the road, while he opened to us the Scriptures. The burning came before the recognition. The restoration was underway long before they knew what was happening, working in them through an ordinary walk with a stranger who turned out to be the Lord.

The recognition, when it finally came, came in an ordinary moment, at a table, in the breaking of the bread, a gesture they had seen Him make before. He took the bread and blessed and broke it and gave it to them, and their eyes were opened, and they knew Him, and in that instant He vanished. The whole long walk had been leading to that table, but they could not have seen it from the road. They thought they were just trudging home in defeat with a talkative stranger. They were in fact being walked back to life, step by step, by the risen Christ, who chose to come to them slowly, in disguise, through Scripture and presence and a shared meal, rather than in a thunderclap.

If your return is slow this week, if you are looking for the breakthrough moment and it is not coming, I want you to consider that the restoration may already be underway in a form you do not recognize. The Lord has a way of walking beside the discouraged in disguise, of warming hearts before opening eyes, of working the healing through ordinary roads and ordinary tables and Scripture opened slowly over a long walk home. You may be further along than you can tell. The burning in your heart, faint as it is, may be the sign that He is already beside you, unrecognized, walking you back to a life you were certain was over. Do not despise the slow return. It is how He most often comes. I think we miss the slow return precisely because we are watching for the dramatic one, scanning the horizon for the thunderclap of restoration while the actual healing walks beside us in ordinary clothes. We expect God to come in the spectacular, in the breakthrough service, in the moment of sudden clarity, in the dramatic answer to prayer, and meanwhile He is coming in the form of a friend who keeps showing up, a Scripture that lodges in us and will not leave, a small returning of appetite or interest or the ability to laugh, a morning that is slightly less heavy than the one before. These do not announce themselves as the work of God. They feel too ordinary, too gradual, too undramatic to be the restoration we were waiting for. And so we discount them, keep waiting for the real thing, fail to recognize that the real thing is already underway in exactly these small and unremarkable forms. The two on the road to Emmaus did not recognize the risen Christ because He came as an ordinary traveler, not as a blaze of glory, and we miss Him for the same reason, because we have decided in advance what His coming must look like, and it rarely looks like that. Pay attention to the small returnings. The faint warmth in the heart. The slight lifting of the weight. They may be the disguised

presence of the One who is walking you home.

And one day, in some ordinary moment, the bread will break, and your eyes will open, and you will realize He was there the whole way.

Week Forty: The Bitterness You Are Becoming

Ruth 1, verses 19 through 21

Do not call me Naomi, call me Mara, for the Almighty has dealt very bitterly with me. A woman renamed herself Bitter, and the Bible let her, and then it spent the rest of the book bringing her back.

There is a danger in long suffering that is more frightening than the suffering itself, and it is the danger of becoming the suffering, of letting the bitterness sink so deep into you that it stops being something you feel and starts being something you are. We have all met the person it happened to, the one whose pain calcified into a permanent hardness, who became cynical and closed and sharp, whose every word carries the acid of an old wound that was never healed. And the frightening thing is that they did not choose it, not exactly, the bitterness crept in through a real injury and slowly took over, until one day they were not a person who had suffered but a person made of suffering, and they could not find their way back to who they were before.

Naomi felt herself becoming this. She had lost everything, her husband and both her sons, in a foreign land, and she came home empty, and when the women of Bethlehem greeted her with her old name, the name that means pleasant, she rejected it. Do not call me Naomi, call me Mara, for the Almighty has dealt very bitterly with me. I went away full, and the Lord has brought me back empty. She is naming, with terrible honesty, what the

suffering has done to her, that it has changed her so deeply she no longer recognizes her old name, that she has become bitter, Mara, and the bitterness feels like the truest thing about her now. And the Bible does not rebuke her for it. It lets her say it. It records the renaming without condemnation.

Bitterness does not arrive as a choice. It arrives as a slow hardening, and it can be reversed only as slowly as it came.

But here is what I want you to see, because it is the hope hidden in the book of Ruth, and it is a hope that takes a whole book to arrive. Naomi names herself Bitter in the first chapter, and the rest of the story is the slow, quiet, almost invisible work of God bringing her back from it. Not in a moment. Not through a dramatic reversal. Through small, ordinary mercies, through the loyalty of a daughter-in-law who would not leave her, through a field where there happened to be food, through a kinsman who happened to be redeemer, through a slow accumulation of small graces that, by the last chapter, have placed a baby in bitter Naomi's lap and drawn the women of the town to say, blessed be the Lord, who has not left you without a redeemer. The bitterness was real, and it was reversed, but only as slowly as it had come.

I think this is crucial for anyone who feels themselves hardening, because the bitterness will tell you it is permanent, that you have become Mara now and there is no going back, that the hardness is your new and final self. And the book of Ruth is the witness that this is not true, that bitterness, though it sinks deep and feels permanent, can be drawn back out, slowly, through ordinary mercies, through faithful people who will not leave, through a God who works underneath the surface of small events to bring the bitter back to pleasant. Naomi did not stay Mara. She did not

feel herself returning, the change was too gradual to feel. But by the end she was holding a child and surrounded by love, and no one was calling her Bitter anymore.

If you feel yourself becoming bitter this week, hardening around an old wound, turning into a person you do not want to be, I will not tell you to simply choose to stop, because bitterness does not work that way, it did not arrive as a choice and it will not leave as one. But I will tell you that it is not permanent, that the hardening can be reversed, and that the reversal comes the way Naomi's did, slowly, through small mercies you must let yourself receive, through people you must not push away, through a God who is working underneath your ordinary days to bring you back from Mara to Naomi. You are not stuck as the bitter version of yourself. Let the small graces in. Let the faithful people stay. I want to distinguish bitterness from honest grief and honest anger, because they look similar and the church often confuses them, treating all hard feeling as bitterness to be repented of. But Naomi's naming of herself as Bitter in the first chapter was not the sin of bitterness, it was the honesty of grief, the truthful naming of what the suffering had done to her, and God did not condemn it, He recorded it. The difference between honest grief and the bitterness that corrodes is not the intensity of the feeling but its direction and its duration. Honest grief, even honest anger at God, is brought to God, kept in relationship, allowed to move and change over time. Bitterness, by contrast, is grief or anger that has turned inward and hardened, that has stopped moving, that has cut off the relationship and set up permanent residence, that has become not a feeling you are passing through but a structure you live inside. Naomi felt the bitterness, named it, brought it home to Bethlehem, brought it before God and her community, and over the course of the book it moved, it softened, it gave way, because she did not wall it off, she let the

small mercies in. The danger is not that you feel bitter. The danger is that you stop letting anything in, that you build the bitterness into a fortress, that you refuse the small graces and the faithful people that would, if you allowed them, slowly draw the bitterness back out. Feel what you feel. But keep the door open. Bitterness only becomes permanent in a heart that has sealed itself shut.

The God who turned Naomi's emptiness into a lap full of redemption is not finished with your story either, and bitter is not the name He intends to leave you with.

Week Forty-One: When You Have to Forgive

Matthew 18, verses 21 through 35

Seventy times seven, Jesus said, when Peter asked how many times he had to forgive, and it is one of the hardest commands in the Bible, and I am not going to make it easy, because it is not.

Forgiveness is one of the most abused words in the Christian vocabulary, and the abuse has wounded the very people it was supposed to heal. We have used it to silence victims, to rush past real harm, to demand that the injured pretend they were not injured, to insist that forgiving means forgetting, means reconciling, means acting as though the wrong never happened. And so many people who have been deeply hurt carry a second burden on top of the first, the burden of a forgiveness they have been told they must perform but cannot honestly feel, the guilt of still being angry at someone the church says they should have forgiven by now. We have made forgiveness into a weapon against the wounded, and Jesus never meant it as one.

So let me be careful about what forgiveness is and is not, because the carefulness matters. When Jesus tells Peter to forgive seventy times seven, He is not telling the abused to return to the abuser, He is not telling the betrayed to pretend the betrayal did not happen, He is not commanding the wounded to feel warm toward the one who wounded them or to act as though justice does not matter. Forgiveness is not reconciliation, which requires repentance from the other person and may not be safe or possible. Forgiveness is not the erasure of the wrong or the

suppression of legitimate anger. Forgiveness is something more specific and, in a way, more difficult. It is the decision to release the debt, to stop demanding that the person who hurt you pay you back, to hand the right of vengeance over to God.

Forgiveness is not saying it did not matter. It is releasing your grip on a debt you will never be able to collect anyway.

The parable Jesus tells right after Peter's question makes this clear. A servant is forgiven an impossible debt, an amount he could never have repaid in a thousand lifetimes, and then he goes out and seizes a fellow servant who owes him a tiny sum and throws him into prison over it. The point is not that the small debt did not exist, it did, the man really was owed. The point is the disproportion, that a person who has been released from an unpayable debt to God should not clutch so tightly to the smaller debts owed to him. Forgiveness is the loosening of that clutch, the release of the grip, the decision to stop trying to collect on a debt that, in truth, can never really be paid anyway, because nothing the offender does can undo what they did.

This is why forgiveness is more for you than for them, though we are suspicious of that framing because it sounds therapeutic. But it is true in this sense: the debt you are clutching is uncollectable. The person who hurt you cannot give you back what they took, cannot un-betray you, cannot un-say the words or un-do the damage. To refuse to forgive is to keep yourself chained to a debt that will never be paid, to spend your life in the debtor's prison of your own resentment, waiting for a repayment that cannot come. Forgiveness releases you from that prison, not by pretending the debt was nothing, but by handing it to God, who alone can settle accounts that no human payment could ever

balance.

If you have to forgive someone this week, and you cannot, I want to free you from the false version of forgiveness that is making it impossible. You do not have to feel warm toward them. You do not have to reconcile, especially if reconciling is not safe. You do not have to pretend the wrong was small or that your anger is wrong. You only have to begin, slowly, often over years, to release the debt, to hand the right of vengeance to God, to loosen the grip that is keeping you chained to the one who hurt you. It is the work of a lifetime, not a moment, and seventy times seven means you will have to do it again and again, because the debt keeps presenting itself for collection and you keep having to release it. But every release is a loosening of your own chains. Forgiveness is the door out of the prison the offender built for you. There is a question that haunts the person being told to forgive, and it deserves an honest answer, because the glib version of forgiveness never addresses it. The question is, what about justice. If I forgive, does that mean what they did was acceptable. Does forgiving the abuser mean excusing the abuse. Does releasing the debt mean the wrong did not matter, that there will be no reckoning, that they simply get away with it. And the answer, which the glib version never gives, is no. Forgiveness is not the abandonment of justice. It is the handing of justice to God. When Paul tells us not to avenge ourselves, he does not say there will be no vengeance, he says leave it to God, for it is written, vengeance is mine, I will repay, says the Lord. Forgiveness does not mean the wrong goes unaddressed. It means you stop trying to address it yourself, stop appointing yourself judge and executioner, stop carrying the impossible weight of being the one who must make them pay, and you hand that weight to the only One competent to bear it, the Judge who sees everything, who will not let a single wrong go unreckoned,

whose justice is perfect where ours is partial and poisoned. This is why forgiveness can coexist with seeking justice through proper means, with protecting yourself, with refusing to return to harm. Forgiveness is not pretending the wrong was nothing. It is releasing your grip on a vengeance that was never yours to execute, and trusting it to the hands of a God who will see that justice is finally, fully done.

You are not opening it for them. You are walking through it yourself.

Week Forty-Two: The Smallness of Your Life

Zechariah 4, verse 10 and 1 Kings 19, verses 11 through 13

Who dares despise the day of small things. And the Lord was not in the wind or the earthquake or the fire, but in a low whisper. The Bible keeps insisting that God works in the small and the quiet, and we keep missing Him there because we are watching for the spectacular.

There is a grief that comes from feeling that your life is too small to matter, that you are not doing anything important, that your days are an unremarkable round of ordinary tasks that no one will remember, that whatever significance you once hoped for has shrunk to the dimensions of a life that feels, from the inside, like nothing much. The young dreams of doing something great have given way to the reality of laundry and commutes and meals to cook and bills to pay, and you wonder if this is all it amounts to, if your one life is being spent on things too small to count, if God could possibly be interested in a life this ordinary. The smallness becomes its own kind of ache, the sense of being overlooked, unremarkable, insignificant in the scheme of things.

The Bible attacks this from two directions, and both are bracing. The first is Zechariah's question to a discouraged people rebuilding a temple that was nothing compared to the glory of the old one, a small and shabby work that made the old men weep at how diminished it was. Who dares despise the day of small things, God asks through the prophet. The small work, the unimpressive rebuilding, the thing that looked like nothing next

to the former glory, God refused to let them despise it, because God was in it, God was building something through the small and shabby thing that the people could not yet see, and to despise the day of small things was to despise the very work of God.

God is almost never in the spectacular. He is in the whisper, the small thing, the ordinary day you keep dismissing.

The second direction is Elijah on the mountain, waiting for God to pass by. And there came a great wind, strong enough to tear the mountains and break the rocks, but the Lord was not in the wind. And after the wind an earthquake, but the Lord was not in the earthquake. And after the earthquake a fire, but the Lord was not in the fire. And after the fire, the sound of a low whisper, and that is where God was. Not in the spectacular displays, the wind and earthquake and fire that we keep watching for, the dramatic interventions and the mountaintop experiences. In the whisper. In the smallest, quietest thing. God passed by Elijah not in the cosmic spectacle but in a sound so soft Elijah had to wrap his face in his cloak and lean in to hear it.

I have come to believe that we miss God constantly because we are watching for Him in the wrong size. We expect Him in the wind and the fire, the big moments, the dramatic answers, the spectacular breakthroughs, and meanwhile He is passing by in the whisper, in the small faithful act, in the ordinary day we are too busy despising to notice is holy. The mother folding laundry, the man showing up to a job no one praises, the believer praying a prayer no one hears, the small kindness, the quiet obedience, the unremarkable faithfulness of an ordinary life, this is where God most often is, in the day of small things, which He dares us not to despise.

If your life feels too small to matter this week, I want to challenge the standard you are measuring it by, because it is the world's standard and not God's. God is not impressed by the spectacular and unmoved by the small, the way we are. It is closer to the reverse. He passed by Elijah in a whisper. He chose to rebuild His temple through a small and shabby work. He came into the world not as an emperor but as a baby in a forgotten town, and lived thirty obscure years before three public ones, most of His life spent in a smallness no one recorded. Your small life is not beneath His notice. It may be precisely where He is, in the whisper, in the day of small things, doing something through your ordinary faithfulness that you will not see the shape of until the end. I think of how Jesus spent His own life, because it is the strongest rebuke to our hunger for significance that I know. The Son of God, through whom all things were made, spent roughly thirty of His thirty-three years in total obscurity, in a forgotten town in an unimportant province, working with His hands as a carpenter, doing the small and unrecorded things that make up an ordinary human life. We have not a single word of what He said during those thirty years, not a single recorded act, because there was nothing the world counted worth recording, just the daily smallness of a workman's life in a place that mattered to no one. And those thirty hidden years were not a waste, not a delay before the real work began, not time to be despised on the way to significance. They were the life of the Son of God, lived in full, in the smallness, sanctifying by His presence in it the very ordinariness we are so desperate to escape. If the eternal Word could spend thirty years in obscurity and call it a life worth living, then the smallness of your days is not the insignificance you fear. It may be precisely the soil in which the holiest things grow, hidden, unrecorded, witnessed only by the God who spent most of His own earthly life there, in the small things, in the

daily round, in a life the world would have called too ordinary to matter.

Do not despise the day of small things. God does not. He lives there.

Week Forty-Three: The Hope That Embarrasses You

Romans 5, verses 1 through 5

Hope does not put us to shame. Paul says it, but he says it only after he has walked through suffering and endurance and character, which means the hope he is talking about is not the cheap kind, it is the kind that has been through the fire and embarrassed itself surviving.

There is a particular vulnerability in hoping, and it is why so many wounded people stop. To hope is to expose yourself, to admit you still want something, to risk the humiliation of wanting it and not getting it, of being the fool who believed it might get better when it did not. After enough disappointment, hope starts to feel naive, even dangerous, the setup for another fall, and the self-protective thing, the sophisticated thing, the thing that will keep you from being hurt again, is to stop hoping, to expect nothing, to armor yourself in a weary cynicism that cannot be disappointed because it has stopped expecting anything good. Hope embarrasses the wounded, because hope has betrayed them before.

Paul knows this, and the way he builds toward hope in Romans five is the opposite of naive. He does not say, just hope, cheer up, expect good things. He traces a hard road to hope, a road that goes through suffering. We rejoice in our sufferings, he says, and you can feel how strange that is, and then he explains the chain. Suffering produces endurance, and endurance produces character, and character produces hope, and hope does not put us

to shame. Notice that hope is at the end of that chain, not the beginning. The hope Paul trusts is not the hope you start with, the untested optimism that has not yet met real suffering. It is the hope you arrive at, the hope that has been forged by going through suffering and learning endurance and being shaped into character, the hope that has earned its place by surviving the very things that should have killed it.

The hope that survives suffering is not naive. It is the most hard-headed thing in the world, because it has already been tested.

This is the difference between cheap hope and costly hope, and it is the whole argument of this book. Cheap hope is the hope that has not suffered, the bright expectation of someone to whom nothing terrible has yet happened, and it is fragile, it shatters the first time life delivers what it delivers. Costly hope is the hope that comes out the far side of suffering, that has been disappointed and endured anyway, that has watched its expectations fail and kept hoping not because it is naive but because it has found something underneath the disappointments that the disappointments could not destroy. This hope does not put you to shame, Paul says, precisely because it has already survived the things that shame cheap hope. It has been embarrassed and lived.

And Paul tells you why this tested hope does not disappoint, and it is not because circumstances finally cooperate. It is because God's love has been poured into our hearts through the Holy Spirit who has been given to us. The ground of the costly hope is not optimism about outcomes, it is the love of God experienced in the very midst of the suffering, poured in by the Spirit while the suffering was still happening. The hope is not that the

suffering will end, the hope is that the love is real, that it has been poured into you, that it held through the worst and will hold through whatever comes, and a hope grounded in that love cannot finally be put to shame, because the love does not depend on the circumstances and neither, in the end, does the hope.

If hope embarrasses you this week, if you have been disappointed too many times to risk it again, I want to give you permission to distrust the cheap kind, the naive optimism that has not suffered, because it deserves your distrust, it will let you down. But I want to point you toward the costly kind, the hope that comes out the far side of suffering and endurance and character, the hope grounded not in good circumstances but in a love that has been poured into you and proven itself in the dark. That hope is not naive. It is the most hard-headed thing in the world, because it has already been to the bottom and found something there that held. There is a reason hope is so much harder than despair, and we should be honest about it, because the difficulty is not a sign of weakness. Despair is safe. Despair cannot be disappointed, because it has already concluded the worst, has already given up on the good, has already armored itself against any further blow by expecting nothing. Hope, by contrast, is exposed, vulnerable, open to the wound of a disappointment that despair has foreclosed. To hope is to want something you might not get, to expose your heart to the possibility of another fall, to refuse the safety of expecting nothing. This is why the wounded so often drift toward despair, not because they are weak but because they are tired of being hurt, and despair, whatever else it is, does not get hurt. But despair, for all its safety, is a kind of death, a closing down of the self, a refusal of the future, and the saints have always understood that hope, costly and exposed as it is, is the braver and more alive thing. It takes more courage to hope than to

despair, because hope keeps the heart open in a world that keeps breaking it. The costly hope this book has been pointing toward is not naive about the danger of hoping. It knows the danger fully, has been disappointed before, and chooses to hope anyway, not because it expects to be spared further wounds, but because it has found, underneath all the disappointments, a love worth staying open for.

You are allowed to hope again. Not the embarrassing, untested kind. The kind that has been through the fire with you and is still, somehow, against all the evidence, alive.

Week Forty-Four: The People Who Did Not Show Up

2 Timothy 4, verses 9 through 18

At my first defense no one came to stand by me, but all deserted me. Paul wrote that near the end, abandoned, and then he wrote the most astonishing next sentence, and both of them are true.

There is a wound that comes not from what people did to us but from what they did not do, the wound of absence, of the people who were not there when we needed them. The friends who disappeared when the diagnosis came. The family who went silent during the divorce. The church that did not call, the people who said let me know if you need anything and then were nowhere to be found, the ones you were sure would show up and did not. It is a quiet wound, easy to dismiss, because nothing was technically done to you, but the absence of the people you counted on can hurt as much as any active injury, and it carries its own particular loneliness, the discovery of who is actually there when it costs something to be there.

Paul knew this wound at the end of his life. Writing from prison, facing death, he names the abandonment plainly. Demas, in love with this present world, has deserted me and gone to Thessalonica. He lists others who have left. And then, about his trial, the hardest line. At my first defense no one came to stand by me, but all deserted me. No one came. At the moment of his greatest need, facing a capital charge, the man who had founded churches across the empire, who had poured out his life for thousands, stood alone in a Roman court and not one person

came to stand beside him. He does not hide it or spiritualize it. He names the absence, the desertion, the loneliness of looking around the courtroom and seeing no friendly face.

The discovery of who is not there when it costs something to be there is one of life's quietest and deepest wounds.

But watch what Paul does next, because it is the part that has held me through my own versions of this wound. Right after no one came to stand by me, he writes, may it not be charged against them. He forgives them in the same breath in which he names their absence. He does not pretend it did not hurt, he named it clearly, all deserted me, the wound is real and he says so. But he refuses to let the wound harden into a grudge. May it not be charged against them. He hands their failure to God and asks God not to hold it against them, which is a stunning generosity from a man who had every right to bitterness, abandoned in his final trial by everyone he had served.

And then comes the sentence that reframes the whole abandonment. But the Lord stood by me and strengthened me. The very next thing after no one came is the Lord stood by me. Paul discovered, in the courtroom where every human friend had failed to appear, that there was One who did appear, who stood by him when all others deserted him, who strengthened him for the defense no human had come to support. The absence of the people did not mean he stood alone. It meant he discovered, in the most acute way possible, the presence of the One who never deserts, who shows up precisely in the courtroom everyone else avoided, who is most reliably there in exactly the moment the others are most reliably gone.

If you are wounded this week by the people who did not show

up, I want to give you Paul's two responses, because together they are the only way through this particular wound without being poisoned by it. First, name the absence honestly, do not pretend it did not hurt, all deserted me, the people you counted on were not there and that is a real grief. And second, refuse to let it harden you, may it not be charged against them, hand their failure to God rather than building it into a wall of resentment. I have learned something hard and useful about the people who do not show up, and it is this: their absence is almost never about you, and almost always about them. We take the absence personally, read it as a verdict on our worth, conclude that we were not important enough to them to be worth the effort, that if we mattered more they would have come. But the truth is usually smaller and less cruel than that. People fail to show up for a thousand reasons that have nothing to do with how much you matter. Some are simply not capable of being present to suffering, because suffering frightens them, or reminds them of their own losses, or demands a steadiness they do not have. Some mean to come and are paralyzed by not knowing what to say, and so they say nothing and do nothing, and their silence, which feels to you like rejection, is actually their own helplessness and fear. Some are wrapped so tightly in their own troubles that they have nothing left to give. Their absence is a statement about their limitations, not about your value. This does not make the wound hurt less, the absence is still real and still painful. But it can keep the wound from doing its deepest damage, which is to convince you that you were not worth showing up for. You were worth it. They simply could not, for reasons that belong to them and not to you, and the One who is competent to be present to all suffering did show up, in the empty courtroom, and stood by you when they could not.

And underneath both, hold the discovery that Paul made in the

empty courtroom, that the absence of the people is the place where you most clearly find the presence of the Lord, who stood by him when no one else would, and who stands by you in exactly the moment you have learned who does not.

Week Forty-Five: The Faith of Your Worst Day

Mark 4, verses 35 through 41

Teacher, do you not care that we are perishing. The disciples screamed it at a sleeping Jesus in a sinking boat, and He did not rebuke them for the fear, He calmed the sea, and then He asked them a question that takes a lifetime to answer.

Everyone has a worst day, or a worst season, the time the storm came and the boat was going down and it seemed certain you would not survive it. And on that day, faith does not look like the serene trust we imagine faith should be. On that day faith looks like the disciples in the boat, terrified, soaked, bailing water, certain they are about to drown, screaming at Jesus that He does not seem to care. We imagine that real faith would be calm in the storm, would trust quietly, would not panic. And then our own storm comes, and we panic, and we scream, and we accuse God of not caring, and we conclude afterward that our faith failed, that we proved on our worst day that we never really trusted Him at all.

But look closely at what the disciples actually did in the storm, because it is more faithful than it first appears. They were terrified, yes. They accused Jesus of not caring, yes. But where did they take their terror and their accusation. To Jesus. In the middle of the storm, convinced they were perishing, they did not abandon the boat, they did not give up on the sleeping teacher, they went to Him and woke Him and brought Him their raw, accusing, frightened cry. Do you not care that we are perishing.

It is not a serene prayer. It is barely a respectful one. But it is aimed at Jesus, it is brought to Him, it is the cry of people who, even in their panic, even accusing Him of indifference, still turned to Him as the only one who could do anything. That turning, in the storm, terrified, is faith. Not calm faith. But faith.

Faith on your worst day is not calm. It is the terrified cry that still, somehow, turns toward Jesus instead of away.

And Jesus does not rebuke them for the fear, not exactly. He rises, and He speaks to the storm, peace, be still, and the wind ceases and there is a great calm, He answers their terrified cry before He addresses their hearts. Only then does He ask them the question, why are you so afraid, have you still no faith. And we read that as a rebuke, but I think it is more like an invitation, a question He is asking them to grow into over a lifetime, because the answer is not that they had no faith, they had just enough faith to wake Him, which turned out to be all the faith the situation required. The question why are you so afraid is the question that the whole rest of the spiritual life is spent answering, not a condemnation of the worst day but an invitation toward a deeper trust they did not yet have.

I want to be honest about what the worst day's faith actually is, because the false picture wounds people. When your storm comes, you will probably not be calm. You will likely be terrified, you will likely panic, you may well scream at God that He does not seem to care whether you live or die. And that will not be the failure of your faith. That will be your faith, in the only form it can take on the worst day, the form of a terrified cry that still turns toward Jesus. The faith of your worst day is not measured by your calm. It is measured by your direction, by the

fact that even in the terror, even in the accusation, you turned toward Him and not away, you woke Him rather than abandoning the boat.

So if you are in the storm this week, or remembering the time you were, I want to free you from the verdict that your panic proved your faithlessness. The disciples panicked, and accused Jesus of not caring, and He calmed the sea anyway, because their faith was never the thing keeping the boat afloat, He was. Your worst day's faith does not have to be calm or serene or impressive. It only has to turn toward Him. The terrified cry, do you not care, brought to Jesus in the sinking boat, is faith, real faith, enough faith, the faith of the worst day, and He has never once rebuked a drowning person for crying out too loudly. He calms the sea. There is a detail in this story that I almost passed over for years, and when I finally saw it, it changed how I read the whole scene. Jesus was asleep in the boat. The storm was raging, the waves were breaking over the sides, the boat was filling with water, the seasoned fishermen were certain they would drown, and Jesus was asleep in the stern on a cushion. We tend to read this as a kind of failure on His part, an inattention, the thing the disciples accuse Him of, do you not care that we are perishing. But consider what it actually reveals. He was asleep because He was not afraid. He could sleep in the storm because He knew something the disciples did not, that the storm did not have the final say, that He was held even as the waves broke, that the worst the sea could do was not the worst that could happen. His sleep was not indifference. It was the deepest possible trust, the rest of one who knows he is safe in his Father's hands even in the heart of the storm. And the disciples, terrified, woke that trust and asked it to act, and it did. I do not think you will sleep through your storm, few of us can. But I want you to see that there is a kind of rest available even in the raging boat, the rest of

the One who knew the storm was not the end, and that the more you come to know what He knew, the more even your worst storms will lose their power to convince you that you are about to be lost.

That was always His job, not yours. Yours was only to wake Him, which, in your terror, you did.

Week Forty-Six: The God Who Stays in the Fire

Daniel 3, verses 19 through 27

There were three men thrown into a furnace, and the king looked in and saw four, and the fourth one was walking with them in the flames, and that is the only promise about fire that the Bible actually makes.

We want God to keep us out of the fire, and we pray for it, and sometimes He does, and we are right to ask. But the deeper and harder promise of Scripture is not that God will keep us out of the fire. It is that He will be with us in it. We misremember the story of the three men in the furnace as a rescue, as God keeping them from harm, and there is rescue in it, but notice the shape of the rescue, because it is not what we usually want. God did not keep them out of the furnace. He let them be thrown in. The flames were so hot they killed the soldiers who threw them in. The three men went all the way into the fire, into the real fire, into the worst that the king could do to them. And only then, inside the flames, did the rescue come, in the form of a fourth figure walking with them in the fire.

Before they were thrown in, the three men said something that I think is the bravest sentence of faith in the Old Testament, and it is brave precisely because it refuses the cheap version of trust. Our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, they tell the king, and he will deliver us out of your hand. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods. But if not. They believed God could rescue

them, and they held out hope that He would, and then they added the three words that make their faith costly rather than cheap. But if not. Even if He does not rescue us, even if we burn, we will not bow. Their faith was not contingent on the rescue. It would hold even in the fire, even if the fire was the end of them.

The promise is not that you will be kept from the fire. It is that you will not be alone in it.

And the rescue, when it came, came inside the fire, not instead of it. The king, expecting to see three burned corpses, looks into the furnace and leaps up in alarm. Did we not throw three men into the fire, he asks, and they answer yes. But I see four men unbound, walking in the midst of the fire, and they are not hurt, and the appearance of the fourth is like a son of the gods. There was a fourth in the fire. God did not spare them the furnace, He met them in it, He walked with them through the very flames that should have killed them, and the deliverance was not the absence of the fire but the presence of God in the middle of it, so that the fire that should have destroyed them could not, because He was in it with them.

I have stopped praying only to be kept out of the fire, though I still pray it, because the Bible's clearest promise is the harder and better one, that God will be with me in the fire. I will be with you when you pass through the waters, Isaiah says, and through the rivers, they shall not overwhelm you, when you walk through fire you shall not be burned. Notice the through. Not around. Through. The promise is not exemption from the fire, it is presence in it, a presence so real that the fire, though you pass all the way through it, does not finally consume you, because the One who is the fourth in the furnace is walking through it at your side.

If you are in the fire this week, and you have prayed to be kept out of it and you were not, I do not want to pretend the furnace is not real, the flames killed the soldiers, the fire is hot and it hurts and it is not a metaphor. But I want to point you to the fourth figure, the one the king saw, the one walking unhurt in the middle of the flames with the people who were thrown in. You may not be kept out of the fire. The three men were not. But you will not be alone in it, and that is the promise, the harder and deeper promise, that there is a fourth in the furnace, that the Son of God walks into the flames with His people, and that the fire which should consume you cannot have the last word, I have wrestled with the but if not of those three men more than almost any other phrase in Scripture, because it is the dividing line between a faith that can survive and a faith that cannot. The faith that says God will rescue me, and stakes everything on the rescue, is a faith that will shatter the moment the rescue does not come, the moment the furnace stays hot and the fire is not quenched and the deliverance the person was counting on simply does not arrive. But the faith that says God is able to deliver me, and He will, but if not, I will trust Him still, that faith cannot be defeated by any outcome, because it has already surrendered the outcome to God. It hopes for rescue without requiring it. It trusts the God whether or not He does the thing it is asking for. This is the costly faith, and it is the only faith that holds in a real furnace, because real furnaces do not always open, real fires do sometimes consume, and a faith contingent on always being rescued is a faith that will fail exactly when it is needed most. The three men did not know whether they would be delivered. They hoped so, they said God was able, but they added the but if not, and they walked into the fire with their trust intact whether they lived or died. That is the faith I want, and rarely have, and am still learning, the faith that walks into the furnace trusting

God even without the guarantee of rescue, because it has found a God worth trusting on the other side of any outcome at all.

because He is in it with you, all the way through, until you come out the other side with not even the smell of smoke on you.

Week Forty-Seven: The Scars That Remain

John 20, verses 24 through 29

When the risen Jesus appeared to Thomas, He still had the wounds. He could have come back perfect, unmarked, the suffering erased, and instead He came back scarred, and He offered Thomas the scars, and that tells you something about what resurrection actually does to a wound.

We assume that healing means the wound disappears, that to be made whole is to be returned to the condition before the injury, the scar erased, the damage undone as though it never happened. And so we wait for a healing that will take us back to who we were before, before the grief, before the betrayal, before the loss, and we measure our progress by how close we are getting to that unmarked former self. But the resurrection of Jesus suggests a different and stranger pattern, because the most healed body in the history of the world, the resurrected and glorified body of Christ, the body that had conquered death itself, still carried the wounds. He rose with the scars. The holes were still in His hands. The wound was still in His side. Resurrection did not erase what had happened to Him. It transformed what the wounds meant.

Thomas, who had refused to believe unless he could touch the wounds, is offered exactly that. Jesus appears and turns to him and says, put your finger here, and see my hands, and put out your hand, and place it in my side. Do not disbelieve, but believe. The risen Lord invites Thomas to touch the scars, to put

his fingers in the holes, because the scars are the proof, the evidence that the one standing before him is the same one who was crucified, that the resurrection did not replace the crucified Jesus with a different unwounded Jesus but raised the very one who had suffered, wounds and all. The scars were not erased by the resurrection. They were carried through it, glorified, made into the very marks by which the risen Christ is known.

Resurrection did not erase the wounds. It carried them through, transformed, into the body of the One who conquered death.

I have found enormous comfort in this, because it tells me that my own healing does not depend on the erasure of what happened to me. The wounds I carry, the losses, the grief, the scars of the things that have marked me, may not disappear, even in the fullest healing God gives. But they may be transformed, carried through whatever resurrection God works in me, made into something other than open wounds, made into scars that testify rather than wounds that bleed. The difference between a wound and a scar is not that one happened and the other did not. The difference is that the wound is still open and the scar has healed, while still bearing, permanently, the mark of what happened. Jesus did not come back without a history. He came back with His history written on His body, healed but visible, marked but no longer bleeding.

This reframes what we are hoping for, and it is a more honest hope than the erasure we usually want. You may never go back to who you were before the wound. That person is gone, the way the un-crucified Jesus is gone, replaced not by a worse version but by a risen one who carries the marks of what He suffered. The hope is not that the scar will vanish. The hope is that the

wound will become a scar, that what is open and bleeding will close, that what now only hurts will one day testify, that the very mark of your suffering will become, somehow, like the wounds of Christ, the place where others recognize the resurrection in you. The scars do not disappear. They become the proof that you have been through death and come out alive.

If you are waiting this week for a healing that will erase what happened, take you back to the unmarked former self, I want to offer you the stranger and truer hope of the scarred and risen Christ. You will carry the marks. They will not disappear. But they can be transformed from wounds that bleed into scars that testify, from the proof that you were destroyed into the proof that you were not, carried through your own resurrection the way Christ carried His through Easter morning. He kept the scars. They are in heaven now, on the body of the Lamb who was slain, the eternal evidence that suffering is real and that it does not get the last word. Your scars, too, may be headed somewhere, may be becoming the very marks by which the risen life in you is known. The wound becomes a scar. The scar becomes a witness. There is a reason, I have come to believe, that the risen Christ kept His scars, and it is not only so that Thomas could believe. It is that the scars are the eternal proof that the love of God went all the way, that it did not stop short of the worst, that it entered the full horror of human suffering and death and bears the marks of that entering forever. In heaven, John tells us in Revelation, the One on the throne appears as a Lamb looking as if it had been slain, scarred even in glory, the wounds carried into the very center of heaven's worship. This means that suffering is taken with ultimate seriousness by God, that it is not waved away or forgotten or treated as though it never happened, but carried, marked, remembered, woven permanently into the glorified body of the Lord. Your suffering, too, is taken that seriously. It will not

be erased as though it never mattered. It will be transformed, carried through, made into a scar rather than a wound, but it will not be forgotten or trivialized, because the God who bears His own scars eternally does not pretend that suffering is nothing. He honors it by carrying it. And the scars you carry, the marks of what you have survived, will be honored the same way, not erased, not minimized, but transformed into the eternal evidence that you suffered, and that the suffering did not have the last word, and that the love which carried you through it bears, on its own hands and side, the proof that it understood your wounds from the inside.

I think often of the people whose scars have become their truest credential, the ones whose visible history of suffering is precisely what makes them safe to the suffering. There is a quality you cannot fake, a depth in the eyes of someone who has been through the fire and come out the other side, that the untouched simply do not have, and it is the very thing that allows them to sit with another person's agony without flinching, without rushing to fix it, without the panic that drives the comfortable to platitudes. Their scars announce, before they say a word, that they know the country, that they have been where you are, that they did not drown though they went under, and the announcing is itself a kind of healing for the one who is still in the water. This is what the scars of Christ do for all of us. They announce, eternally, that God knows the country of suffering from the inside, that He went under and did not stay, that the wounds He carries are the permanent proof that He understands ours. And the scars He is forming in you, the marks of what you have survived, may become the same kind of credential, the visible proof to someone still in the dark that the dark can be survived, because here you are, scarred and alive, walking proof of a resurrection that does not erase the wounds but carries them

through.

And the witness says, against everything death claimed, He is risen, and so, somehow, am I.

Week Forty-Eight: The Hope You Cannot Manufacture

Lamentations 3, verses 19 through 24 and Psalm 130, verses 5 and 6

I wait for the Lord, my soul waits, and in his word I hope. My soul waits for the Lord more than watchmen for the morning. Hope, the real kind, is not something you generate. It is something you wait for, like the dawn, which you cannot summon and can only await.

We talk about hope as though it were a choice, as though we could decide to be hopeful, manufacture it by force of will, talk ourselves into it with positive thinking and the right verses. And there is a kind of grim determination that masquerades as hope, the gritted-teeth insistence that things will get better, the willed optimism that is really just exhaustion wearing a brave face. But true hope, the hope this book has been circling all year, is not something you can produce on demand. You cannot squeeze it out of yourself by trying harder. When you are in the depths, the manufactured hope rings hollow even to your own ears, and the harder you try to feel hopeful the more clearly you can hear that you do not, and the failure to manufacture hope becomes one more weight on top of the despair.

The psalmist understands hope differently, and his image has stayed with me through many dark seasons. My soul waits for the Lord more than watchmen for the morning, more than watchmen for the morning. Think about the watchman waiting for the dawn. He does not manufacture the morning. He cannot make the sun rise faster by wanting it, cannot summon the dawn

by force of will, cannot generate the light himself no matter how desperately he longs for it. All he can do is wait, in the dark, watching the eastern sky, trusting that the morning will come because the morning has always come, because the dawn is not dependent on the watchman's effort but on the faithful turning of the world toward the sun. His hope is not a feeling he produces. It is a posture he holds, the posture of waiting and watching for a light he cannot create.

You cannot manufacture hope any more than the watchman can manufacture the dawn. You can only wait for it, and it comes.

This is the freedom hidden in the hardest seasons, and I wish someone had told me sooner. You are not required to manufacture hope. You cannot, and the attempt only exhausts you further and adds the guilt of failure to the weight of despair. What you are asked to do is far smaller and far more possible. You are asked to wait, like the watchman, in the dark, watching for a dawn you cannot produce, trusting that it will come because the One who is the dawn has always come, eventually, in His time, faithfully, the way morning faithfully follows even the longest night. The hope is not your achievement. It is His arrival. Your part is only to keep watching the eastern sky.

The writer of Lamentations, in the same passage where the mercies are new every morning, says the thing that grounds this waiting. The Lord is my portion, says my soul, therefore I will hope in him. The hope is in Him, not in an outcome, not in a feeling, not in a circumstance that might change. It is grounded in a person, in the steadfast love that never ceases, in the God who is the watchman's morning, and because that God is faithful, the hope that waits for Him is not finally in vain, even when it

cannot be felt, even when it cannot be manufactured, even when all you can do is sit in the dark and watch the place where the light is supposed to appear.

If you cannot manufacture hope this week, stop trying, because you were never meant to. Hope is not a feeling you produce, it is a dawn you wait for, and your inability to summon it is not a failure of faith but simply the truth about what hope is and is not. Take the watchman's posture instead of the manufacturer's. Sit in the dark and watch the eastern sky. Wait for the Lord more than watchmen for the morning, trusting not in your ability to feel hopeful but in His ancient faithfulness to bring the dawn. You cannot make the morning come. But you do not have to. It comes, in His time, because He is faithful, and the longest night this world has ever known still ended, on a Sunday, with a stone rolled away and the sun coming up over an empty tomb. There is a discipline in the watchman's posture that is worth learning, because it is the opposite of both despair and false cheer, and most of us oscillate uselessly between those two. The despairing person has stopped watching the eastern sky altogether, has concluded that the dawn will never come, has turned away from the place where the light would appear and given up on the morning. And the falsely cheerful person pretends the dawn has already come when it has not, manufactures a daylight that is not there, insists on a brightness the dark hours do not yet contain. The watchman does neither. He does not turn away from the eastern sky in despair, and he does not pretend the sun has risen when it is still dark. He keeps his eyes on the place where the light will appear, in the dark, waiting, neither giving up nor pretending, holding the hard tension of a night that is real and a dawn that is certain. This is the posture of costly hope, and it is harder than either despair or denial, because it requires you to stay in the dark, fully acknowledging the dark, while keeping

your eyes fixed on the promise of a light you cannot yet see. You do not have to manufacture the dawn. You do not have to pretend it has come. You have only to keep watching the place where it will, trusting the faithfulness of the One who has never yet failed to bring the morning, even after the longest of nights.

The dawn came then. It will come for you. Keep watching the sky.

Week Forty-Nine: When Joy Returns and You Feel Guilty

Psalm 30, verses 4 through 12

Weeping may tarry for the night, but joy comes with the morning. And when it does come, when you find yourself laughing again after a season you thought would never end, there is a strange guilt that ambushes you, and I want to speak to that guilt, because no one warns you about it.

We spend so long in the dark that we forget about this particular wound, the wound that comes not in the suffering but in the recovery, when joy unexpectedly returns and we feel guilty for it. The grieving person who laughs at a joke and then is stricken, how dare I laugh when they are gone. The one who has a good day after a long depression and then panics, does this mean I did not really care, that my grief was not real, that I am betraying the loss by feeling better. There is a survivor's guilt to joy itself, a sense that to recover is to be disloyal to what we suffered, to the person we lost, to the seriousness of the wound, as though staying in the dark were the only way to honor what happened there. And so people sabotage their own returning joy, pull themselves back into the grief out of a misguided loyalty, because the joy feels like a betrayal.

The thirtieth psalm knows both the night and the morning, and it does not treat the morning as a betrayal of the night. Weeping may tarry for the night, but joy comes with the morning. The psalmist had been in the depths, had cried out from the pit, had felt God's face hidden, and he tells us so. And then the morning

came, the weeping that had lasted through the long night gave way to joy, and the psalmist does not feel guilty about it, does not pull himself back into the weeping to honor it. He celebrates the turn. You have turned for me my mourning into dancing, he says, you have loosed my sackcloth and clothed me with gladness. The mourning was real. He wore the sackcloth honestly. And then God turned it into dancing, and the psalmist let himself dance.

When joy returns, it is not a betrayal of your grief. It is the morning that your grief was always waiting for.

I want to tell the recovering that the return of joy is not disloyalty. It is the very thing your grief was for. Grief is not an end in itself, not a state to be preserved forever as proof of love, not a debt you pay by refusing to ever feel good again. Grief is the long night, and the night is real and it must be honored and it cannot be rushed, but the night was always meant to give way to morning, and when the morning comes, receiving it is not a betrayal of the night, it is the night's fulfillment. The person you lost, if they loved you, did not want you frozen forever in the dark. The God who saw you through the night did not bring you through it so that you would refuse the morning out of guilt. Joy is allowed to come back. That is what it is for.

And here is the deeper thing the psalm understands, the thing that frees the returning joy from guilt entirely. The point of the deliverance, the psalmist says, is praise. You have turned my mourning into dancing, that my glory may sing your praise and not be silent. O Lord my God, I will give thanks to you forever. The morning was not just for the psalmist's relief, it was for God's glory, so that the one delivered would have a song to sing, a testimony of a God who brings people through the night into

the morning. To refuse the returning joy out of guilt is, in a strange way, to rob God of the praise the morning was meant to produce. The joy is not selfish. It is the song that the whole long night was reaching toward.

If joy is returning to you this week, and the guilt is ambushing you, I want to free you from the false loyalty that would pull you back into the dark. The weeping tarried for the night, and the night was real, and you honored it. But joy comes with the morning, and the morning is not a betrayal of the night, it is the night's whole purpose, the thing God was bringing you toward the entire time you wept. You are allowed to dance again. You are allowed to laugh. You are allowed to feel the gladness return, and the One who loosed your sackcloth and clothed you with joy did not do it so that you would feel guilty for wearing it. I have watched people sabotage their own returning joy out of a misplaced loyalty to the dead, and it is one of the quieter tragedies of grief. They feel that to be happy again is to forget the one they lost, that joy is a kind of abandonment, that as long as they keep suffering they are keeping faith with the beloved, and the moment they laugh freely again they have somehow let the beloved go. And so they cling to the grief, refuse the morning, treat their own continued suffering as the proof and the measure of their love. But ask yourself what the one you lost would actually want, if they loved you, and the answer is plain. They would not want you frozen forever in the dark on their account. A love that demanded your permanent misery as the price of remembering it would not be love at all. The truest way to honor someone you have lost is not to suffer forever in their memory but to carry them forward into a life that has found its joy again, to let them be present in your laughter rather than only in your tears, to live well as a tribute to a love that wanted your flourishing. The joy that returns does not erase the one you lost.

It carries them with you into the morning, where they would have wanted you to go all along.

Receive the morning. Let the joy come. And let it become, as the psalmist did, a song of praise to the God who turns mourning into dancing, which is the only thing the long night was ever for.

Week Fifty: The Wounds That Become Your Ministry

2 Corinthians 1, verses 3 through 7

God comforts us in all our affliction so that we may be able to comfort those who are in any affliction, with the comfort with which we ourselves are comforted by God. The wound, it turns out, is not wasted, and Henri Nouwen had a name for what you become. The wounded healer.

We want our suffering to be meaningful, and one of the cruelest things about deep pain is that it so often seems meaningless, a waste, a stretch of agony that accomplished nothing, that we would undo in an instant if we could, that taught us nothing we would not gladly trade back for the absence of the pain. And I will not insult you by claiming all suffering has a tidy purpose, that God sends every wound for a reason you will one day be grateful for, because that is the lie this book has refused all year and I am not going to start telling it now in week fifty. Much suffering is simply the result of a broken world, and God did not author it, and there is no neat reason for it, and to pretend otherwise is to become Job's friends.

But there is something the Bible does promise about suffering, and it is more modest and more honest than the claim that everything happens for a reason. It is the promise that God can take the comfort He gives you in your affliction and turn it into comfort you can give to others in theirs. Not that the suffering was good. That God can bring good out of it, which is a different and truer thing. The God of all comfort, Paul writes, comforts us

in all our affliction so that we may be able to comfort those who are in any affliction, with the comfort with which we ourselves are comforted by God. The comfort you receive in your dark season is not only for you. It becomes a thing you can give away, a fluency in suffering you could only have learned by suffering, a credential of compassion that cannot be earned any other way.

The wound does not become meaningful because it was good. It becomes meaningful because God can give it away to someone else who is bleeding.

Henri Nouwen called this being a wounded healer, and the phrase has shaped how I understand my own ministry and my own scars. The people who have helped me most in my worst seasons were never the ones who had never suffered, the untouched advisors calling instructions from the dry bank. They were the ones who had been in the water themselves, who knew the cold from the inside, whose comfort carried the weight of having needed it first. A person who has grieved can sit with a griever in a way no one else can. A person who has doubted can hold a doubter without panic. A person who has been to the bottom can meet you there without flinching, because they recognize the place, they have been there, and their presence says, without a word, you will not drown here, because I did not, and here I am beside you.

This is, I think, the closest thing to redemption that suffering offers in this life, and it is not the redemption of the suffering being made good, but the redemption of the suffering being made useful, given away, turned into the one thing that can actually reach another person in the same dark. Your wound, the very thing you would undo if you could, may become the place from which you are able to reach someone that no untouched

person could reach. Not because the wound was a gift. It was not. But because God, who wastes nothing, can take even the wound you hated and make it the doorway through which you walk to someone else who is bleeding in the dark you have already survived.

If you are wondering this week whether your suffering will ever mean anything, I will not promise you it had a hidden purpose, because I do not believe all suffering does, and I will not lie to you in week fifty. But I will tell you what God has promised, which is that He can give your comfort away through you, that the wound you carry can become the very thing that lets you sit with another wounded person and bring them the comfort you yourself received. You did not choose the wound. You would undo it if you could. But you can choose what to do with the comfort it taught you to need, and there is someone, somewhere, bleeding in a dark you already know, who needs exactly the wounded healer that your suffering has made you. I want to be careful, even here at the end, not to let this truth curdle into the lie it sits next to, because they are dangerously close. The lie says your suffering was sent so that you could help others, that God wounded you on purpose to make you useful, that the pain had a purpose and the purpose justifies the pain. I do not believe that, and I will not say it. The truth is more modest and, I think, more beautiful. It is not that the suffering was sent for a purpose, but that God, who did not waste even the cross, can take a suffering He did not author and bring something from it that would not otherwise have existed, can redeem what He did not cause, can bring a strange and unexpected good out of an evil He hates. The difference matters enormously to the sufferer. You do not have to believe that God gave you cancer so you could comfort cancer patients, that He took your child so you could sit with bereaved parents, that He sent the wound for the sake of the

ministry. You only have to believe that God, finding you wounded by a broken world, can take the comfort He pours into you and let it overflow to others, can make even your worst suffering bear a fruit you never asked for and would still trade back for healing. The wound was not a gift. The fruit that grows from it, in the hands of the God who wastes nothing, can be.

The wound is not wasted. It becomes, in the hands of the God of all comfort, the doorway to someone else.

Week Fifty-One: The Hope With Nail Holes in It

1 Peter 1, verses 3 through 9 and Isaiah 53, verses 3 through 5

We have come almost to the end of the year, and I have promised you all along that the hope at the end of this book would not be cheap, would have nail holes in its hands, and I owe you now the fullest account of that hope, the costly hope this whole year has been walking toward.

The reason I cannot offer you a cheap hope is that I have seen what cheap hope does when real suffering arrives. Cheap hope is the hope that has not reckoned with the worst, the bright assurance that everything will be fine, that God will fix it, that your best life is just around the corner. And it works, for a while, for the comfortable, for those whom nothing terrible has yet touched. But the day the cancer comes, the day the child dies, the day the marriage ends or the faith collapses or the body fails, cheap hope shatters, because it was built for a world without real suffering, and the moment real suffering arrives it has nothing to say, it goes silent, it abandons you exactly when you need it most. I have watched cheap hope fail people at gravesides. I have watched it leave them with nothing. And I made up my mind long ago that I would not hand my people a hope that breaks the first time it is tested.

The hope I have found that does not break is a hope grounded in a God who suffered. This is the center of everything, the thing the whole year has been circling, and I want to say it as plainly as I can. The God of the Christian faith is not a God who

watched our suffering from a safe distance and offered explanations. He is a God who came down into the suffering Himself, who took on flesh and entered the very pain He could have stayed above, who was, in Isaiah's ancient words, despised and rejected by men, a man of sorrows and acquainted with grief. He knew grief from the inside. He was not a stranger to the dark country we have walked through all year. He lived there. He died there.

The only hope that does not break under real weight is a hope held out by hands that still have the nail holes in them.

And He did more than visit our suffering. He took it into Himself and let it do its worst to Him. Surely he has borne our griefs and carried our sorrows, Isaiah says, and we esteemed him stricken, smitten by God, and afflicted. But he was pierced for our transgressions, he was crushed for our iniquities, upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed. With his wounds we are healed. The healing that the whole book has been reaching for, the binding up of the brokenhearted that we read in the very first epigraph, is accomplished not by a God who stayed unwounded but by a God whose own wounds became the source of our healing. He heals the brokenhearted with a heart that was itself broken, on a Friday, on a hill, under a darkened sky, crying out the very psalm of abandonment we read back in the early weeks of this year.

This is why the hope does not break. It does not break because it has already been to the bottom. It is not a hope that avoids suffering, denies suffering, or explains suffering away. It is a hope born on the far side of the worst suffering the universe has ever seen, the suffering of God Himself, abandoned and pierced

and laid in a tomb, and it carries the marks of that suffering permanently, the way the risen Christ carries the nail holes. When you bring your suffering to this hope, it does not flinch, it does not go silent, it does not abandon you, because it has been where you are, it knows the cold of the water from the inside, and the hands that hold it out to you are scarred hands, hands that were pierced, hands that understand exactly what it costs to suffer because they have suffered.

Peter, writing to people scattered and suffering for their faith, calls this a living hope, born through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, an inheritance that is imperishable, kept in heaven for you. And he is honest, in the same breath, that the people he writes to are grieved by various trials, that the suffering is real and present and painful. He does not pretend the trials away. He holds them and the hope together, the way this whole book has tried to, the way the cross and the resurrection are held together, a Friday that was real and a Sunday that was also real, and neither one canceling the other, the wounds carried right through the empty tomb into the risen and scarred body of the Lord.

So this is the hope I have walked you toward all year, and I will not dress it up beyond what it is. It is not a promise that your suffering will end soon, or that God will explain it, or that everything happens for a reason you will one day be glad for. It is something harder and deeper and more durable than any of that. It is the hope held out by pierced hands, the hope of a God who entered the dark Himself and came out the other side still bearing the marks, the hope that says to every broken heart, not from a safe distance but from inside the very wound, with his wounds we are healed. I have stood at enough gravesides to know which hope holds and which one shatters, and I will tell

you what I have seen, because it is the whole reason I have written this book the way I have. At the graveside, the cheap hope says nothing of any use. It cannot, because it was built for a world without graves. The platitudes fall flat, the everything-happens-for-a-reason goes silent, the your-best-life-now has nothing to offer a coffin. But the costly hope, the hope with nail holes in it, can stand at a graveside and speak, because it has been to a grave before, the grave of God Himself, and it knows that graves are not the end of the story. It can look death in the face without flinching because it has already faced the worst death there is and watched the stone roll away. This is why I cannot offer you the cheap version. It would fail you at the exact moment you most needed it, the moment of real loss, real death, real darkness. I have watched it fail people, and I made up my mind that I would hand my people only the hope that holds at the graveside, the hope grounded in a God who entered the grave and came out, the hope that does not avoid death but goes through it, the hope with the marks of suffering on its own body. That hope has stood at every graveside in two thousand years of Christian history and it has not yet shattered, because it was forged in a tomb and proven on an Easter morning, and the grave that should have ended it only confirmed it.

Let me say plainly what the costly hope asks of you, because nothing in this book should be received as easy. It asks you to follow a God who did not exempt Himself from the worst, and who therefore does not promise to exempt you. It asks you to bring your suffering to a Savior whose own answer to suffering was to enter it rather than explain it, which means you will not always get the explanation you want. It asks you to trust, in the dark, a love whose deepest demonstration was a cross, which is to say a love that looked, at the time, exactly like abandonment. This is not a comfortable arrangement, and I will not pretend it

is. The costly hope costs you the cheap comforts, the easy answers, the guarantee that faith will spare you pain. What it gives in return is the only thing that actually holds when the pain comes anyway, a God who is not above your suffering but inside it, not explaining it from a distance but bearing it alongside you, scarred hands and all. I cannot make this hope cheaper, and I would not if I could, because the cheaper it gets the less it holds. It is expensive precisely because it is real, and it is real precisely because it was paid for in blood, on a Friday, by a God who would rather die with us than reign without us.

That hope has nail holes in it. That is exactly why it holds.

Week Fifty-Two: He Heals the Brokenhearted

Psalm 147, verses 1 through 6 and Revelation 21, verses 1 through 5

We have arrived at the last week, and I want to end where we began, with the verse that named this whole book. He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds. A year ago I told you to read it slowly, and now, after fifty-one weeks of refusing to lie to you, I want to read it slowly with you one final time.

He heals the brokenhearted. Notice again what it does not say, because the whole year has been teaching us to read it honestly. It does not say He spares them the breaking. It does not say He keeps their hearts from breaking in the first place, exempts them from the loss and the grief and the long dark we have walked through together. It says He heals the brokenhearted, which means they were, first, broken, which means the breaking is assumed, is real, is part of the very people this promise is for. This is not a promise to the unbroken. It is a promise to the broken, and you cannot receive it without first admitting that you are among them, that your heart has been broken, that the wound is real, which is the thing we spent the first weeks of the year learning to say out loud.

And He binds up their wounds. The image is of a physician's hands, careful and close, wrapping a wound that is real enough to need binding, a wound that does not heal by being ignored or denied but by being tended, slowly, by hands that come near enough to touch it. The God of this verse is not a distant God who waves suffering away from a throne in the sky. He is a God

who comes close, who kneels down at the level of the wound, who binds it with His own hands, the same hands, we learned last week, that carry the nail holes. He does not heal from a distance. He heals from inside the room where we fall apart, which is where I told you at the very beginning that He writes, and where I have tried to write to you all year.

*He does not heal the brokenhearted from a distance.
He kneels down in the wreckage and binds the wound
with pierced hands.*

I cannot tell you, in this last week, that all your wounds have healed over the course of this year. That would be the lie I promised never to tell. Some of you are ending the year still in the dark, still grieving, still waiting for a prayer that has not been answered, still carrying a wound that has not closed. The year has not fixed everything, because a year does not fix everything, because healing is not a calendar, because some wounds are bound up slowly over a lifetime and some are not fully healed until the other side. I will not pretend you arrive at week fifty-two whole. Many of you do not. I do not, on the things I have carried longest. The healing this verse promises is real, but it is not always fast, and it is not always complete in this life, and I would betray everything this book has been if I tied a bow on it now.

But there is a final word, and it is the word the whole Bible ends on, and it is the only thing that lets me promise you a healing that is total without lying about how incomplete it still is now. At the very end of Scripture, John sees a new heaven and a new earth, and a voice from the throne says, behold, the dwelling place of God is with man, He will dwell with them, and they will be His people, and God Himself will be with them as their God.

And then the promise that has held more dying saints than any other. He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more, neither shall there be mourning nor crying nor pain anymore, for the former things have passed away. I want you to notice the tense of that final promise, because it is the hinge on which everything turns, and it is easy to read past. He does not say I have made all things new, as though it were already finished and you were simply failing to see it. And He does not say I will make all things new someday, as though it were entirely future and had no bearing on your present dark. He says I am making all things new, present continuous, an action already underway and not yet complete, a making that has begun and is moving toward an end it has not yet reached. This is exactly where you live, in the middle of the making, after it has started and before it is finished, in the long stretch where the renewal is real but partial, begun but not complete, where some things have been made new and many things have not, and you are waiting in the gap for a work that God has promised to finish but has not yet finished. The making of all things new is not a fairy tale about the far future that has nothing to do with your Tuesday. It is happening now, in you, in the world, slowly, against the resistance of a creation still groaning, and it will not stop until it is done. You are not waiting for a God who has not started. You are living inside a renewal already in motion, held by a God who is making all things new, including you, including the very wounds this year could not heal, and who will not lay the work down until the last tear is wiped from the last eye.

And he who was seated on the throne said, behold, I am making all things new.

Every tear. Wiped away by God's own hand, the same hand that binds the wounds now, finishing then what it begins here. Death

no more. Mourning no more. Pain no more. Not because the suffering was not real, the tears that get wiped away were real tears, the very tears we have wept all year, the ones God kept in His bottle and counted in the dark. But because the God who entered our suffering and came out scarred is making all things new, is bringing the broken to a healing so complete that even the deepest wounds of this life will be bound up forever, will become like the scars of the risen Christ, marks of a suffering that is over, evidence of a death that has been swallowed up in life.

So this is where the year ends, and it is where I have been bringing you all along. Not to a healing that is finished now, but to a healing that is certain, held out by pierced hands, guaranteed by a God who broke His own heart to bind up ours, and completed on a day that is coming, when He will wipe away every tear with the same tenderness He has shown all along, kneeling in the wreckage, binding the wounds, refusing to leave us alone in the dark. He heals the brokenhearted. He is healing you now, slowly, in ways you may not feel. And He will finish it, on the morning when there are no more nights, when the last tear is wiped away by the hand that was pierced for you, and every wound this year could not close is bound up at last, forever, by the God who has been with you in the dark the whole time, and who is, even now, making all things new.